

*Daughter to
Bligh*

JOYCE THORPE NICHOLSON

"THANKS TO PENELOPE NELSON WHO WROTE A NOVEL,
"BLIGH'S DAUGHTER".

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ON THE BLIGH YEARS);

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ARTWORK AND PAGE LAYOUT: GEOFF AND STEPHEN DIGBY;
PUBLISHED BY WWW.DIGBYS.COM 2012

ISBN: 978-0-9803893-5-7

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JOYCE THORPE NICHOLSON

Dedicated to Melissa



*William Bligh, pictured in his 1792 account of the Mutiny voyage, *A Voyage to the South Sea*.*

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JOYCE THORPE NICHOLSON

*Edited and completed by
Michael Nicholson*

From the Editor

My mother, Joyce Thorpe Nicholson (Thorpe being her maiden name), was an author of over twenty-five books and Managing Director of D.W. Thorpe Pty. Ltd., from 1968 until 1987, the publisher of The Australian Bookseller and Publisher and other trade magazines. She was a founding member of the Women's Electoral Lobby and Sister's Publishing.

Over the summer of early 2010, when my mother was 90 years old, she started talking about a manuscript she had written in the late 1950's on William Bligh's Daughter. I did a search for it amongst her archives and found it. There was a folder of 200 pages and various notes including letters to the Home Office in London from 1945 when she began her research into Bligh. The manuscript was unfinished. So my mother commissioned me to complete it and have it published. I was delighted with the challenge.

I can remember as a three or four year old watching my mother sitting at her Olivetti typewriter on the family table in our sunroom typing away at her various books and this was one of them. Already she had the book *Mutiny on the Bounty* published, so I guess her interest in feminist issues and the enormous amount of research in hand gave her the idea for writing about William Bligh's daughter, Mary, who was to become the First Lady of New South Wales.

I would particularly like to acknowledge the encouragement and help of Penelope Nelson who wrote the book, *Bligh's Daughter*. This excellent novel is set in New South Wales and was my main reference point for the completion of my mother's book along with *The Fatal Shore* by Robert Hughes.

MICHAEL NICHOLSON

Foreword

Joyce Nicholson's splendid *Daughter to Bligh* recounts a narrative as much about the late eighteenth century as about post-Second World War Australia. To be sure, Nicholson keeps her narrative hand firmly on the tiller of her novel as it moves through the period of Australia's late eighteenth-century founding. Hers is the skill of both the historian and the novelist: the historian sets the Australian narrative in its global perspective, a perspective that embraces British naval domination of the Mediterranean as much as the South Seas; the novelist captures the narrative energy of this extraordinary moment of globalization.

The overall narrative power of this book is, however, driven by fresh, post Second World War energies: this book starts not with men, boats and guns, but rather with mothers and daughters.

And so however much its narrative arc encompasses that male world of governance, governance of both boats and colonies, the real energy, and the future, lies not with the men, but rather with the young women. The young, not the old, and the female, not the male, turn out to provide our line into the future, in the sage, energetic person of Mary Bligh, *Daughter to Bligh*.

I write this foreword both as an enthusiastic reader of the novel, and as a person whose intellectual life was shaped by its author. I first came to know Joyce Nicholson in the late 1960s. Melbourne in the late 1960s, or my Melbourne at any rate, was not the especially intellectual place it has since become. So meeting Joyce Nicholson was electrifying: here was a radical parent, who was thinking hard about, and arguing with, the very male culture from which her son and her son's friends came. I enjoyed

her company and admired her energy many dozens of times on the veranda of the modest but beautifully positioned Nicholson house at Mornington, Victoria, about fifty minutes drive from Melbourne. Sitting on that veranda, one looks across to the city skyline of Melbourne just visible on the sea's horizon across Port Phillip Bay.

As Joyce trenchantly argued this question or that (frequently about the Women's Movement) we knew that this was no idle, merely academic debate, conducted at a safe, seaside distance from the real world.

Instead, Joyce gave us the model of the engaged intellectual, whose interests were not ruminative, but applied: she was always directed to that city skyline and the world of entrenched, male power relations it embodied. Her novel, no less than her life, marks the extraordinary and transformative victory of alternative, female forces over a world dominated by men.

PROFESSOR JAMES SIMPSON

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Preface

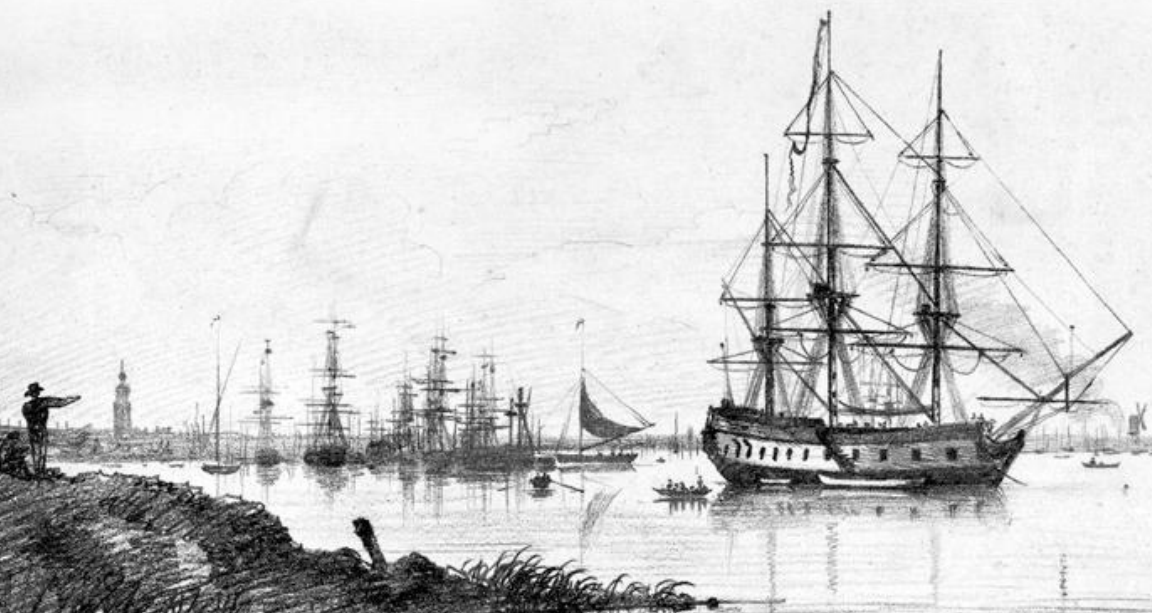
BY JOYCE NICHOLSON

It is customary to commence books with the statement that the characters bear no resemblance to any living person. In this book, on the contrary, every character has been drawn as similar to the real person as research has made it possible. The only exceptions are Tommy and Matt, the two small orphan boys. They were invented from truth, because of the author's fascination with the life that must have been led by the many orphan children in Sydney's early history.

The events of history, and the people who participate in them, are more fascinating than any fiction. This, we hope, is revealed in this book. Every extract from letter or diary given herein is an exact copy (although with grammatical and spelling errors corrected for easier reading ~ editor) of original copies, most of which are to be found in the Mitchell Library, Sydney.

The Manifest

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Chapter One

“I cannot go, Mama. I most certainly cannot go.” Mary sat down suddenly on the chair in front of the bedroom mirror. “My legs will not support me for another minute.”

“Mary, my dear, when you get there, you know you'll enjoy it immensely.”

“But do I look all right?”

“Of course you do, Mary. You know quite well that you look very lovely.”

“But my dress, Mama? Is it elegant enough?”

“It's beautiful, Mary. Didn't we spend long enough choosing it?”

“I'm positive it's too low. Everyone will look at it.”

“And wasn't that the idea?” replied her mother. “Didn't you beg to have it just a little lower?”

Looking in the mirror, Mary was blind to the beautiful young girl pictured there with dark hair, bright blue eyes of a strange almond shape, and dressed in her first ball dress. She could see nothing but a large expanse of white throat and shoulders above a tiny bodice of pale blue silk. How badly she had wanted it, and yet how shocking it now appeared! Suddenly a fresh terror assailed her.

“Do you think anyone will dance with me, Mama?” she continued in an agonised voice. “Just imagine my humiliation if no-one, absolutely no-

one, dances with me.”

“For heaven's sake, Mary,” interrupted Harriet suddenly. “Stop going on like that. You know that probably everyone in the whole place will want to dance with you.”

With irritation, Mary's older sister, Harriet, looked at her mother. “Do please hurry everyone, Mama. It's getting later and later and Mr. Baker will be waiting for us.”

“It's all very well for you, Harriet,” said Mary, “You'll have Mr. Baker. But I won't have anyone. Why, oh why, does my first ball have to be a Grand One? I can't face it, Mama, I can't. Lord Nelson himself may be there! You know Papa said that.”

“I'm quite sure he won't.” replied Harriet. “We'll be fortunate if even some of his officers attend. Do calm yourself. I'm tired to death of you talking like that. Ever since you were about two years old, you've behaved this same way. You reduce us to a complete state of nerves before a party. And the moment you get there you win all the games and play the piano better than anyone else.” Harriet turned impatiently to her mother. “Honestly, Mama, do let us get away. If Mary is going to keep on like this, we'll just need to leave her behind.”

“If only I had another dress,” said Mary dismally. “This one is absolutely hateful. I feel quite sure no-one will dance with me.”

“And what about Papa?” Asked Harriet. “Have you by any chance forgotten Papa? Do you think he'll let you sit around without partners? Goodness me, if necessary, he'll see that every young officer there dances with you.”

Mary's face suddenly brightened. "Yes, he will, won't he, Mama?" Her pride and confidence in her father suddenly had her on her feet again, twirling around, excited, and bright-eyed. "They'll dance with Captain Bligh's daughter won't they Mama? No matter how plain or dull they think me. They will, Mama, won't they?"

"Yes child they will." Betsy laughed at her beautiful and glowing daughter who was describing herself as plain and dull. "But I don't really think we need worry. Now for goodness sake, please be careful of your dress. The carriages are waiting."

"Betsy! Betsy! Come here quickly! There's a bit of my gold braid here that needs a stitch in it." came the agitated voice of a man from across the hall.

"Yes William..." called Betsy as she left the two girls. "Do calm down. I'll be there in a moment," she said as she entered her own room where William Bligh was standing. "With you and Mary both going out this house gets into an absolute and useless uproar."



Vice Admiral Horatio Lord Nelson

It was November, 1800, and London was in a ferment. Lord Horatio Nelson, the hero of the Battle of Cape St. Vincent, of Teneriffe, and the Battle of the Nile, had finally returned home. On November 8, he had entered London in triumph.

Mary and Harriet, with Papa and Mama and thousands of others, had gone to see him. Standing on Aunt

Jane's balcony they had watched him pass by. A small, tired man, with only one arm and one eye and laden down with a gold and blue uniform and the three glittering stars and two gold medals on his chest.

With him in the carriage and sharing the triumphal progress had been Lord and Lady Hamilton. What food for gossip there had been with the rumour going around that Lady Nelson was waiting for him at Nerot's Hotel in St. James. Everyone knew about Emma Hamilton. Everybody knew why Nelson had been so long in returning to England. The Battle of the Nile had been in 1798, but for two years he had lingered at the Sicilian Court, basking in the gratitude of the King of the Two Sicilies, and unable to drag himself away from his affair with Emma.

Uneasiness in London grew. Was the greatest of all naval commanders to remain away forever just to become the mere plaything of the divine Emma? But at last Nelson returned, bringing his beloved with him. The little people of England did not let that worry them. Here was Horatio Nelson, about whom there were already scores of legends. He was their hero and they were going to show it.

He landed in Yarmouth, and from there to London, the crowds were out to greet him. He was given receptions by the civic leaders and the freedom of the cities through which he passed. When he went to the Lord Mayor's Feast in London, the mob took the horses from his carriage at Ludgate Hill and pulled it along themselves to the Guildhall. Wherever he went, Emma stood beside him.

"Wouldn't it be wonderful if Nelson did come?" Mary asked forgetting her fears. "And imagine if he bought Lady Emma Hamilton! Wouldn't it be wonderful, Harriet, to stand right next to her? To see what makes her

so beautiful?"

"Really, Mary! It would be better if Lady Nelson came. That other woman should have stayed in Sicily."

"You don't really mean that? She's his true love, I feel sure of that. He's devoted to her."

"I still think it's wrong," Harriet replied scornfully.

"And what about the Prince of Wales?" Asked Mary. "Doesn't he live quite openly with Mrs. Fitzherbert? In between his other loves of course... and if he can do it, I don't see why Lord Nelson can't? He's done more for England than the Prince of Wales surely..."

"That's not the point," Harriet snapped back. "Husbands should stay with their wives. The way the Prince of Wales has treated Princess Charlotte is abominable... keeping her practically a prisoner while he does what he likes at Carlton House and at that terrible Brighton Pavilion."

"I think it sounds rather exciting. And Princess Charlotte shouldn't be so ugly and dull. He only married her for the succession... now they have a daughter I expect he never wants to see her again!"

"You're impossible, Mary. How would you like your husband to leave you the moment you had a child?"

"I'd see to it that no husband ever wanted to leave me. I'd marry for love, anyway," Mary stated wistfully.

Harriet looked impatiently towards their bedroom door. "I do wish Papa would hurry. Whatever can be keeping him now?"

"Mr. Baker will wait for you. Don't be so impatient," an irritated Mary

replied.

“He particularly wanted us to be early in case Lord Nelson did come. He said he would present me to him.”

“What was that Harriet? You haven't said a word! Do you think he would? Why haven't you mentioned it before?” Mary scowled at her older sister.

“I didn't want to say anything in case nothing happened. I'm quite sure he won't come.” Harriet said as she inspected her nails.

“Does Mr. Baker know him as well as that?” Mary replied knowing full well that Mr. Baker had met Nelson and Lord and Lady Hamilton while painting in Italy. But to be able to speak to him in London was quite another matter.

“He has been to see the Panorama of the naval victories my Mr. Barker painted. He especially requested that Mr. Baker should show it to him... and he was exceedingly impressed.”

Mary looked accusingly at her older sister. “And you have kept it all a secret. How could you?”

“I wanted to surprise you tonight, but now it has been spoilt. Really, it is too trying of Papa to be late.”

“There must be some good reason. You know quite well that Papa's always on time.” But Mary's mind was scarcely on what she was saying.

How fortunate Harriet was, she thought, to have fallen in love with someone like Henry Baker, a young handsome man who had already travelled so far and met so many people. A famous artist, and son of the man who had invented the Panorama, the long painting that could cover

the length of an entire wall.

Mary sighed. She felt sure that such a thing would never fall to her lot. Why, Mr. Baker was almost as famous as Papa. She remembered his dramatic drawings of the Fleet drawn up at Spithead. Then there had been his journey to Turkey and the huge Panorama of Constantinople, and his painting of the Peace of Amiens, through which he had been introduced to Napoleon.

And now there were the paintings of Nelson's victories. She herself had stood several times in the centre of the huge circular building and gazed with wonder at the tremendous oil canvasses encircling the room.

Imagine if it was your future husband that had painted them!

Harriet's mind was occupied with more practical thoughts. Irritated as she was at the delay, and at having to reveal her secret, she was at least relieved that Mary had been distracted from giving her views on the Royalty and their mistresses.

Meanwhile, the last stitch had been put in Captain Bligh's braid and there was a sudden bustle in the hall as he appeared impatiently at the door.

"Come on, now, girls," he said excitedly. "Hurry up! We're very late."

"We've been waiting for hours," complained Mary.

Harriet said nothing. She followed the others quietly down the stairs and into the waiting carriage. Sometimes she wondered how her mother endured the noise and disturbance that always seemed to follow both her father and Mary. It was bad enough managing the younger girls but with these two and their tempers and excitability it was far worse.

Once they were on their way down the cobbled road there were no more demurs from Mary. And as Mrs. Bligh and Harriet had expected, as soon as the carriage stopped, Mary stepped out with the greatest of ease and walked gracefully up the steps to the entrance of the Grand Ball.

Once inside, however, even Mary was over-awed by the size and magnificence of the occasion; the lights from the crystal chandeliers, the size of the huge halls, the richly dressed footmen, the highly scented flowers, and the numbers of people caused her to falter and wait for her elder sister.

“Harriet,” she murmured, “Isn't it grand?”

From then on she gladly followed Harriet who had experience in these matters. With eyes bright but without knowing exactly what was happening Mary found herself, her pelisse taken from her, at the entrance to the ballroom. Still with the feeling that she was playing a part in some grand play she heard their names announced and found herself being greeted by the host and hostess. Then she and Harriet were standing alone.

She gazed in wonder at the groups of people around her; the officers in their blue and gold uniforms, the other men in their velvet jackets and flowered waistcoats and the women in their beautiful but flimsy gowns, low cut and daring. Why, thought Mary, my gown is almost too proper.

For a minute they were separated from their parents. Harriet was looking to see if Mr. Baker had arrived and Mary was trying to absorb the lights, the colour, and the music. Just then she heard a cool, amused voice behind her.

“Did you hear old Bully Bligh announced? I wonder what mutiny he's

stirring up now?" The person said and then laughed.

The aura of dreaminess and unreality fell from Mary. She turned around slowly and deliberately. Could she believe her ears? Behind her stood two naval officers and a civilian; a tall thin man, dressed in velvet and lace, with an amused look on his face.

Mary gazed at him, the colour high in her cheeks, her eyes bright and hard. With her thoughts racing she continued to stare at him... angrily, steadfastly, and without moving her eyes from his face. What would she do to this man, she wondered. Who could say such a thing? Would she slap his face? Or scratch his eyes out? Or tear his beautiful lace cravat?

Nothing she could think of would be bad enough. Just then Harriet, who had also heard the remark and had been watching Mary took her gently but firmly by the hand and led her quietly away.

"What are you doing, Harriet?" muttered Mary furiously. "What are you doing? Let me go!" She was too well brought up to struggle, but her anger increased. Mrs. Bligh had spent many years teaching Mary to outwardly control the anger that flared so easily in her husband.

"Let me go," Mary muttered again as Harriet led her firmly on. "Didn't you hear what that man said?"

"Of course I heard," replied Harriet. "But you can't make a scene you know. You were going to make a scene, weren't you?"

"I couldn't think what he most deserved," replied Mary through clenched teeth.

"You must ignore people like that."

Mary stopped being angry for a moment, "But Harriet, don't you care?" she said in amazement. "How could you ignore it?"

"Of course I care," replied Harriet resolutely moving Mary down the side of the ballroom. "But you simply cannot make scenes. Look, just sit here for a moment until you calm yourself."

They reached an alcove and Harriet pushed Mary into one of the chairs. "You've always known these things were being said about Papa," she continued. "You've heard us talk of it often enough. But we know they're wrong and we must not take any notice."

Suddenly tears started to well up in Mary's eyes. "How can you take no notice? How can you bear it?" she asked. "To hear, to actually hear, someone speak like that about Papa who is always so kind to his men. How can you let it happen?"

"If you're going out into society, Mary dear, you'll have to get used to it. Not that you often hear a remark like that, of course... that was unfortunate. But you get to know that some people believe these things and Mr. Baker often hears them too when people don't know he's a friend of ours."

Suddenly Captain and Mrs. Bligh appeared.

"What's the matter?" asked Bligh. "Are you all right, Mary? We saw Harriet bring you in here."

"It's all right, Papa," replied Harriet quickly. "Mary just felt a little faint."

Mary's tears changed to a smile. She looked up at her father and laughed. "I'm fine now, Papa. I don't know what could have happened." Dear kind fussing Papa, she thought. Nothing, she vowed, nothing would

ever persuade her to let her father know what she had just heard.

In the ballroom, from where Harriet had just led Mary quickly away, a stunned trio of men were left standing, gazing after the girls.

"I say, old chaps," asked Carruthers, the one of whom Mary's wrathful gaze had been bent. "Who was that perfectly gorgeous looking creature and why did she look at me like that?"

"Don't you know?" replied Martin Townson, one of the officers, as he laughed. "Don't you really know? They were two of Captain Bligh's daughters. At least, I presume they were. I've met the fair one, Miss Harriet, and I guess the other one is her sister. So now you understand."

"You mean she heard what I said about her father?"

"I'm sure she did."

"Well why should she jolly well look so furious anyway? I expect she knows all about him. After all, she lives with him doesn't she?"

"But it's not true, you know. None of it's true. The old man's got a furious temper, but apart from that he's a mighty fine man."

"I find that hard to believe. You know what they say..."

"I know Thomas Hayward very well. Do you remember? He was one of the midshipmen on the *Bounty* voyage, and was with Bligh on that journey home in the small launch. It's a fascinating story, I can tell you. He says the old man's terribly difficult at times, and insists on everything being absolutely right, but that under all his talk, he reckons he's the kindest Captain he's ever sailed with... he goes to no end of trouble to look after the men's health and what not. He reckons he punishes them less than any Captain he knows..."

“Then why all these stories?”

“It was the relatives of Heywood and Christian that set them about. Two of the mutineers, do you remember? The only way to clear their names was to blacken old Bligh's.”

“Well, well!” replied Carruthers. “There's always something you can learn isn't there? All the same, I think there must be some truth in it...”

Meanwhile the third man in the small group had been silent, but not inattentive. He had missed nothing that had occurred. He had watched every expression on Mary's face and had understood the way Harriet had led away her younger sister.

While listening to the conversation, he had kept his eyes fixed on the two girls, and had seen them disappear into the alcove. He had seen Captain and Mrs. Bligh follow their daughters.

“You know the Blighs, do you?” He asked Martin abruptly.

“Yes. At least I've met them. Not that dark one though.”

“Do you think you could present me to them? They went into an alcove over there.”

Martin laughed. “Yes, of course, John. Which one have you got your eye on?”

“Why,” replied John, surprised. The beautiful dark haired one, of course. I didn't really notice the other one.”

“You can have her,” said Carruthers. “She looked as if she was going to tear my eyes out.”

“Can't really blame her, can you?” retorted Martin as he and John

moved away.

So it happened that they approached the Bligh family just as Mary was assuring her father she was fine. Bligh looked up at the two young Navy Lieutenants and frowned at the intrusion.

"Yes? What do you want?" he asked abruptly.

"Do you remember me, Sir?" asked Martin tentatively. "Martin Townson, Sir. I'm a friend of Thomas Hayward's and I met you a few weeks ago."

Bligh's manner changed immediately. "Oh! Yes, yes, Mr. Townson. I remember you now," he replied, smiling. "Of course. Young Hayward told me you fought under Nelson at the Nile. Very pleased to meet you again."

"I would like to present Lieutenant John Putland, Sir. He was another with us at the Battle of the Nile."

"Well now! Was he now? That's very interesting. Delighted to meet you, Lieutenant Putland." He turned towards Betsy and the two girls. "My dear, I'd like you to meet two of Nelson's Lieutenants."

The introduction was soon made, and John Putland found himself standing before the bright-eyed, small, dark, sixteen-year-old girl, whom he had seen so angry a few minutes earlier, and who still had traces of tears on her cheeks.

He felt it was a moment of supreme importance and yet he could think of nothing to say. Never a very articulate young man, words, when they were most wanted, were failing him completely. Normally Mary would have helped him. Usually she had plenty to say, but at this moment she

was struggling to look happy and was barely aware of the young man in front of her.

John felt the important moments passing. In a minute he knew this party would move on to speak to others and the occasion would pass. Then he became aware that the music was playing. There was one sure way of solving his immediate problem.

“May I have the pleasure of this dance, Miss Bligh?” He asked politely.

Mary scarcely saw the tall fair-haired Lieutenant who was so humbly asking her to dance. She was determined to show her father that everything was fine and to show the world that the Blighs held their heads high.

“Yes, of course,” she replied with a warm smile.

Betsy smiled after her retreating back. How like Mary she thought! Worried about being plain and dull, and the minute they arrived, she was snatched away from them by a strange young man.

Chapter Two

Lieutenant John Putland led his young partner gently on to the floor and they joined a set in silence. As they began to dance he kept his eyes on her face. He noted the proud lift of her head and a mouth that was curved into a half smile. When they came briefly together he could still think of nothing to say and was content to watch.

As for Mary, she was acting automatically. He mind was on what she had heard about her father and her focus was directed towards showing Papa, and indeed the world, that she was not concerned. She had not even looked closely at her partner.

It was her first dance at her first ball. In spite of her fears she had been asked to dance almost immediately and yet she did not know what her partner looked like. The tears in her eyes had blurred her vision.

Slowly she regained her scattered senses and the next time their eyes met she glanced up shyly to smile at him. She noticed his fair hair and his open, sunburned face. Then suddenly the smile left her face and her eyes became doubtful. Surely she thought... surely had she seen this man before?

John glanced down at her and saw the angry look in her bright blue eyes, an expression he had already seen just minutes before.

“W-what's the matter?” he asked. How stupid, he thought, to stammer like a schoolboy before the hostile eyes of a young girl and yet he was a battle veteran.

"Weren't you one of the men," Mary asked coldly, "who were talking about my father?" John smiled. So that was it. She had recognised him.

"In a way, Miss Bligh, I was," he replied still smiling. "It would be more correct to say I was listening. And you didn't wait long enough, you know. You should have heard what Lieutenant Townson said to our fine friend Carruthers."

"What did he say?" She had to wait for his reply. "What did he say?" she asked again when they parted once more in their ballroom dance together.

"He said Carruthers said was completely unfair. He's a friend of Hayward, you see, and had heard the whole story. He said your father is a very fine seaman putting the men's welfare before everything else... is that correct?"

Mary smiled. "Of course it is", she said with her eyes bright. Her mouth was a beautiful curve. Here was a beauty, thought John Putland, and here was loyalty.

For the moment, the dance continued, and in spurts and dashes Mary returned repeatedly to the subject nearest her heart; the virtues of her father and the wickedness of the false rumours that had been circulated.

"But what has me puzzled," asked John, "is why your father did not answer these accusations."

"He wasn't here for the trial of the mutineers!" replied Mary quickly.

"He had been sent on the second bread fruit journey. While he was away a Captain Edwards in the ship Pandora was sent in search of the mutineers."

Just then the music stopped. Mary was so intent on her story, and her partner happy to watch her talk, that they walked without thinking to one of the alcoves by the ballroom floor and sat down.

“Captain Edwards caught fourteen of them. Two had already been killed by the natives,” Mary explained as her face grew angry. “But the worst of them, including Fletcher Christian, were never caught. They sailed away on the *Bounty* and have never been heard of since.”

Mary then described the complete inhumanity of Captain Edwards.

“Even to the four men Papa described as innocent... and then there was the wooden coop, eighteen feet by eleven, called Pandora's Box and in this box lay the fourteen men unable to stand upright, manacled hand and foot. They lay there through the cold, rain and intense heat while Edwards searched the Pacific for Christian and the other mutineers he couldn't find. Then he set sail for New Holland and was wrecked on the great Australian Barrier Reef.”

John Putland was not as incredulous as Mary expected. But she continued in a hushed whisper as the dancing continued outside the alcove. “When the ship was sinking Edwards did not allow the prisoners to be released until four had drowned!”

John Putland knew of many tales of inhumanity and sadism practised by officers on crews and prisoners, but he listened intently as Mary kept talking. “The others then faced further brutalities during the journey home... to Timor, and in jails and ships from there to England... and all of this had a very bad effect on Papa's reputation,” she concluded.

“How was that?” Putland was puzzled by the final remark. “I don't see how it could make any difference to your father...”

“Well Mama thinks some of the cruel stories about Captain Edwards became associated with Papa. And then, of course, they reached home long before Papa, and the trial was held when he was away at sea that was when the real damage was done. Up until then no-one had ever suggested that anything could have caused the mutiny, you see?”

“Yes, I do, Miss Bligh. It's fascinating...”

“Good gracious me!” exclaimed Mary. “I'm terribly sorry Lieutenant Putland. I have been talking so long. Mama says that when I get onto the subject of Papa nothing will stop me.”

John smiled down at her. “He's a very fortunate man, Miss Bligh. And I have enjoyed every minute of it. Do you think...” he hesitated for a moment, “do you think you could have another dance with me? Perhaps there is more you could tell me...”

“Oh there is,” replied Mary earnestly.

“Then please let me hear it,” he replied, and led her once again onto the dance floor.

Again the conversation continued in small pieces, as opportunities arose, but Mary was not to be stopped. She explained how at the trial the only way to clear the names of the mutineers was to blacken that of their commander. She described the spate of letters to the papers, articles, and even books, written to prove that Bligh was a tyrant and a bully, a cruel commander, a foul-mouthed, ill-educated man who beat and starved his crew.

“Mama was nearly worried to distraction about it,” she continued. “Papa was not there to defend himself, and she did not know what to do. I was

only seven or eight at the time, yet I can recall it all quite clearly,” she said thoughtfully. “I suppose Mama was so worried, and being on her own, talked to us about it. Fletcher Christian's brother and the family of Heywood, one of the young midshipmen, were the worst... horrible people.”

Lieutenant Putland had only expected small talk. The music had stopped again and Mary and her partner walked off the floor together still absorbed in the story. “Heywood's still in the Navy now isn't he?” Putland asked. “I'm sure I've heard of him.”

“Oh Yes. He was convicted at the trial, but later on he was reprieved. Morrison and Musprat were reprieved too. Only three of the mutineers were hanged and yet they put Papa and the other men in that tiny launch to drown or to starve.”

Mary could still remember how angry and resentful her father had been on his return. After the mutiny he had been a hero, yet now, with his second journey an unqualified success, he found himself coolly received by the Admiralty.

Lieutenant Putland listened to the story patiently and sympathetically. Not only was he fascinated by the changing lights in Mary's eyes, the anger and sorrow reflected there, but the story itself was full of interest. So fascinating indeed, that both Lieutenant Putland and Mary were unaware of her father approaching stormily down the ballroom floor. She and John looked up to find William Bligh suddenly standing angrily before them.

“I'll have you know my man,” Bligh said abruptly, “that this is my daughter's first ball and I would like her returned to me.”

"I'm terribly sorry Sir," stammered Lieutenant Putland standing to attention. "I didn't realise we had been so long."

"Two dances," replied Bligh firmly, "and the third about to start. There are other young men who want to dance with her."

"Oh Papa," laughed Mary. "You must not be angry with him. It was all my fault. I've been talking and talking, you know me..."

"He should have known better," replied Bligh speaking as if the unfortunate young man were not there. "His behaviour is entirely lacking in manners and quite unworthy of His Majesty's Navy."

"And Papa," continued Mary, suddenly looking downcast, "I was having such fun and perhaps no-one else will want to dance with me..."

"I have two young men along here now, Mary, waiting to be presented to you. Good evening to you young man," he quickly concluded as he took Mary's arm and hurried her away from Putland.

Mary gave the Lieutenant a quick little smile as she went. "Papa, Papa," she wailed, as she almost ran to keep up with him, "you should not be so bad-tempered. He was so nice, and perhaps I shall never see him again."

Chapter Three

The ball was over. No-one was surprised that Lord Nelson had not arrived. Mary and Harriet were home in the large four-poster bed they had always shared.

Harriet was asleep, but Mary lay awake. Too much had happened in one night to allow her to sleep. The dazzling colour and pomp of the large occasion amazed her. Never had she dreamt that men and women could dress so lavishly, that food could be so delicious, or lights shine so brightly. Then there had been the succession of young men with whom she had danced. Above all, there had been the incident concerning Papa. Over and over again Mary thought of what she had heard. If what Harriet said was true, how distressing that even one person, let alone many, could think such a thing of Papa. If only she could spend her life telling people the truth! Then she thought of Lieutenant Putland, who had listened so sympathetically. She wished she had been allowed more time to speak to him. Would she ever see him again?

She turned restlessly in bed. She remembered when Papa had sailed on the first breadfruit voyage. Mary was only three then and was sure she could remember it. Harriet said she could not but everything was so positive in her mind, every picture so clearly etched. Perhaps, as Harriet said, it was because she had heard it discussed over and over again.

Whatever the truth, in her mind, she could recall the excitement and pride of the family when Papa had been asked to command the *Bounty* and to transplant bread fruit trees from the South Seas to the islands in



Captain James Cook.

the West Indies. It was his first sole command. Papa had told them about the strange large fruit, which tasted and looked like soft white bread and was used as the main item of diet by South Seas natives. He explained how merchants and planters in the West Indies thought perhaps it would grow on their plantations and provide food for their slaves.

That was in August 1787. Then Mary recalled how disappointed Papa had been when he discovered how scantily the Admiralty was to equip his expedition. Only one ship had been provided, the *Bounty*, a tiny ship of two hundred and fifty tons and a crew of forty-six men. Mary had heard her parents talking about it.

“Why,” Papa exclaimed angrily, “on Cook’s last voyage Betsy, you’ll remember we had two ships... two ships. And both bigger than my small *Bounty*.”

“Mama had been dismayed. “How can they expect you to do it, William? With such a small boat? So few men?” Mary remembered her pride at her father’s reply.

“I’ll do it all right, Betsy,” he replied emphatically. “Have no fear about that... no matter how small the ship.” Then he frowned again. “But they could have treated me better. And no marines either, to discipline the crew! We had marines on both ships on the last voyage with James Cook... not that you need them... if you treat the men well, you don’t

need to fear them. Good food and exercise keep them happy. That blind fiddler I'm taking with us, he'll do a lot to keep the men cheerful. I mean to have dancing every night!"

Papa's confidence had often changed to intense irritation with the bungling of the Admiralty. He was to be the only officer on the *Bounty*, yet he was still only a Lieutenant. Captain Cook always had two or three lieutenants to assist with the command and Mary remembered how Mama had taken her and Harriet down to Portsmouth so that they could be with Papa during the last weeks. She was certain she could remember. They had taken lodgings near the docks. Mama said they were bleak, unhappy weeks, but Mary thought they were exciting.

In spite of everything, Papa had been determined that the journey would be a success. Nothing had been overlooked. Every care was taken in selecting the crew and fitting the boat. Once the men were selected everything possible was done for their comfort and for the safe keeping of the plants that were to travel so many miles on such a small ship.

Weeks passed with not a single word from the Admiralty. Ideal sailing weather came and went, other ships weighed anchor and disappeared down the channel, but the *Bounty* was delayed until the winds were against her and the season unsuitable.

Mary sighed for her dear Papa. The promotion never did come for that journey, but at long last, the final orders did. Then on a cold wintry day, November 28th, 1787, the *Bounty*, with her commander still a Lieutenant, tried to sail but the winds were too strong for her to even get down the Channel and for over three stormy weeks the ship was further delayed. Then at last the fair winds came and they sailed.

Once again Mary was sure she could remember standing and holding

one of Mama's hands, with Harriet on the other side, cold, wind-blown, excited, as the ship sailed out of sight. Such a small ship to go round the world, only ninety feet long and twenty-four feet wide, with only its sails to carry it and Papa's great seamanship to guide it. Mary felt she wanted to go with him.

How much of this, wondered Mary, could she really remember? They had talked about it so much. They had read the letters and the book so often. It was hard to know what was memory and what were pictures she had built up in her own mind. Mama had stopped reading the letters. She would only read them only on special occasions.

For the last time Mary turned over again. At last she was beginning to feel drowsy. She would ask Mama in the morning if she could read the letters one more time. She would go over the many details so if she ever saw Lieutenant Putland again there would be so much more to tell him and so many things she could explain.

Maybe these early impressions were the ones that made Mary want to sail herself and be with her father. But he disappeared for an inordinate length of time and there had been nothing; no news, no letters, nothing. Then finally one fateful letter arrived and brought the news that was to change their lives. Papa was to become a legend of the sea.

Chapter Four

The next morning Papa ate his breakfast quickly and left but everyone else lingered on at the table. They wanted gossip about The Grand Ball. The family was spellbound with Harriet's dramatic story of the conversation she and Mary had heard about Papa and how she had barely managed to prevent Mary from making a shocking scene. Mary was immediately teased by everyone.

"Fancy," exclaimed Elizabeth, "your first dance was with one of Lord Nelson's Lieutenants."

"He must like a girl with a temper," added Harriet.

"But wait," said Mary, "until you hear how Papa treated him." As Mary told them everyone laughed at Papa's quick dismissal of the young man.

"Isn't that just like Papa?" said Harriet.

"And it was so unfair, Mama," Mary complained, "for I was simply telling him how unjust people had been over Papa. And Lieutenant Putland was so sympathetic and understanding. And then Papa came raging up to us like a storm."

"The poor young man," smiled Betsy. "I'm afraid he must have wondered what had happened to him. People who don't know Papa never realise that he doesn't mean half of what he says."

"And," continued Mary, "of course I could not explain to Papa why we were talking so much or why Lieutenant Putland was so interested for I would not hurt Papa's feelings for all the world."

"But Mary dear," said her mother seriously for a moment, "you must not

go bursting forth with our life history every time you hear anything said about Papa. You will never be successful in society.”

“I don't care,” replied Mary. “I shall never as long as I live, listen to insults about Papa, without standing up for him. Even,” she concluded, “if it means that no-one will ever speak to me again.”

“Well all I can say,” replied Harriet, “is that you're going to make life as difficult for yourself as Papa does...”

At last the meal was finished. Harriet went into the drawing room to practise the piano and the four younger girls walked around the corner to the Academy for teaching young ladies. When everyone had gone Mary went to find her mother.

“Mama,” she asked, “could I please have your letters from Papa? Please, Mama?”

“Is there any special reason?”

“I want to remember everything... everything about Papa and the mutiny.”

Betsy paused and looked at her daughter. “Of course you can have them, my dear. But remember one thing, in case you're getting ahead of yourself, if you marry a sailor you may be marrying someone you love, but you're also marrying someone you'll hardly ever see,” Betsy said with a knowledgeable smile.

“I know Papa spends years on the sea... that's what I want to read about. We haven't looked at his letters for such a long time...” Mary lamented.

“I know they will be in safe hands. But Mary darling,” Betsy hesitated for a moment, “try not to take it too much to heart, we must not live in the past.”

“But Mama, what happened last night is not in the past. It's the present.

It's now."

"You were very upset by it, weren't you child?"

"Yes Mama. I could not conceive that people should say such things about Papa."

"Then perhaps reading the letters will help you, darling. It will make you realise how completely good your Papa is. That is what we must always remember. Provided we know the truth, what other people think, or say, does not matter."

Mary took the letters from her mother and collected the famous book she wanted from the library shelves and went up to her bedroom. She sat down on the large bed and spread the papers around her. As Harriet was practising her piano, she knew she would have the room to herself for at least a precious hour to read.

She sorted through the pile of letters written from Papa to Mama from all parts of the world. They were written meticulously in Papa's careful slanting handwriting. How strange, thought Mary, that a sailor should be such a prolific writer of letters and what devotion and love they expressed.

She knew how and when Mama had first met Papa. She had always loved to hear as much about him as possible and had begged for more detail. And Betsy, because her husband was often away, and because she loved to be surrounded by her children, had willingly complied with their requests.

As a midshipman, at twenty years old, from the eight gun sloop *Ranger*, Papa had first visited Mama's family at Douglas, on the Isle of Man.

Mama had described his eagerness as a young man, how his face would light up as soon as the Navy was mentioned and how he was determined

to succeed.

Mama's father, a Collector of Customs at Douglas and a Doctor of Laws from the Edinburgh University, often brought home officers from the war ships. Among the many, there had been an immediate attraction between Mama and William Bligh.

The first letters were from the Ranger when it had sailed from Douglas. Through them ran the theme of Papa's determination to succeed in the Navy and descriptions of the long hours he spent studying navigation and hydrography. Mary soon came to the first mention of Papa's early troubles, probably confided to no-one but Mama. He explained the difficulties of advancement in the Navy without influence. Corruption was everywhere at its height and nowhere was it more evident than in the Navy.

In several letters there were stories of midshipmen Papa knew who, with less ability and training, had been promoted to Lieutenant. These midshipmen either had close ties, or were even related, to Admirals. Mary's cheeks flared with indignation. It was so unfair and little wonder Papa grew angry.

Suddenly the letters became more exciting. Papa had met Captain James Cook... The Captain James Cook who had praised him for his surveying and navigation! Two weeks later, Captain Cook had asked Papa for one of his maps. Again he had praised the beautiful work.

Mary knew that very good news was coming soon. Quickly she opened another letter. Yes, here was the one. Suddenly Harriet entered the room. "Whatever are you reading?"

"The letters! Harriet, Papa's letters. Aren't they wonderful? I haven't seen them for such a long time... and look, I've just come to the one where

he's to sail with Captain James Cook on his third journey. Can you imagine the excitement? Poor Mama though... See, here it is, he's to be Sailing Master of the Resolution. I remember Mama saying that on a journey of exploration, Sailing Master was a more important position than Lieutenant. Papa would be in charge of surveying and mapping."

"For heaven's sake, Mary, I know. We've read these letters countless times... Really I sometimes think you're a little daft about Papa."

"Harriet! At present you've other things on your mind... It's different for me. Do you think anyone at all will write letters like this to me?"

"What about that nice Lieutenant Putland?" Harriet responded.

"I don't expect I shall ever see him again. Not after the way Papa spoke to him," Mary replied.

"Well, there you are! That's what I mean about Papa. He has lots of faults."

"Only a bad temper. Just one fault. That's all."

"One's enough," Harriet cautioned.

"Don't be silly. Most people have dozens. He was away for four years with Captain Cook, wasn't he? Poor Mama! Four years! I remember she told me he had made her promise to wait for him... he was afraid she would marry someone else."

"I'm not surprised," Harriet continued, "after all, Mama was twenty-three. It's just as well, she was practically an old maid then. And if she waited until she was twenty-seven, without knowing they were going to marry she'd have been very foolish indeed."

"She loved him! She would have waited forever... look, Harriet, these letters are from all over the world. And here's the one where Captain Cook was killed by natives at Hawaii in 1779," Mary said softly as she felt

the texture of the paper, "How terribly, terribly sad..."

Harriet began dressing to go out and Mary fell silent for a while, reading.

"This always makes me so angry," she said suddenly causing Harriet to glance at her through the mirror. "I can hardly bear it. Here Papa says Cook should never have died... those stupid officers... and so cowardly. If only Papa had been near him to help..."

"Papa might not have been able to do anything. He just thinks he could."

"Harriet! How can you say that? Whatever's the matter with you? I've never heard you speak like this about Papa before. You've always loved him like we all do.... what is it?" persisted Mary. "There must be something you're getting at."

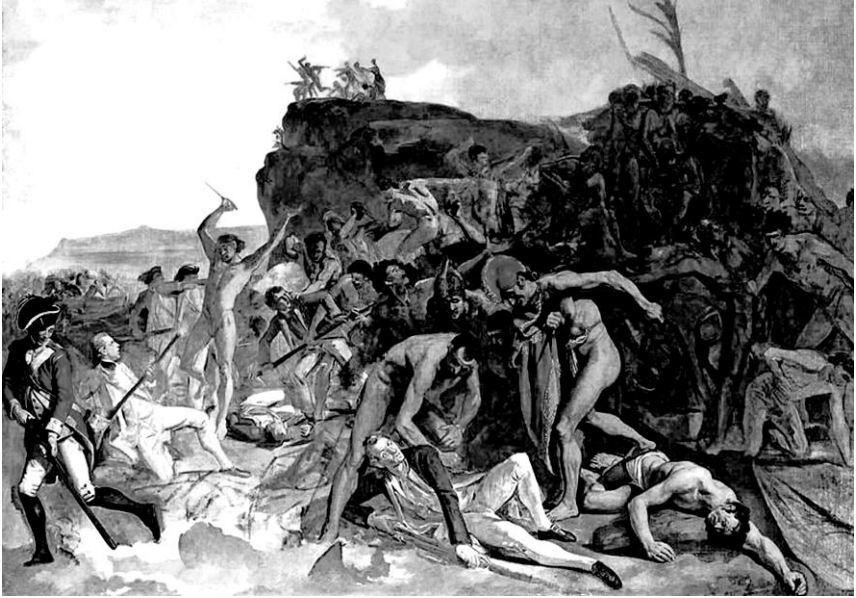
"If you must know, at the Grand Ball last night in front of a whole group of people, Papa criticised one of Mr. Baker's paintings. I am to marry him remember. He said one of the sails on a ship was wrong."

"Oh Harriet," exclaimed Mary, her face full of sympathy. "Was it too awful?" "Yes, it was... it was humiliating. You know how careful Henry is about detail. He takes tremendous trouble..."

"I'm sorry. But you know what Papa is like if anything is wrong. He must point it out. And he's always praising Mr. Baker's work you must admit," Mary continued, "why, he tells everyone how good his work is..."

Harriet sat down on the bed next to Mary and looked disconsolate. "Yes Mary, you're right. And he's taken many people to see the Panorama. But I do wish he were not so tactless. He has no idea how people remember these remarks of his. Papa forgets them the minute he has made them but others don't. My Henry was angry the whole evening."

"Harriet, your Henry will forget about it, you see if he doesn't. It's obvious he loves you very dearly and I'm sure he understands Papa."



The death of Captain James Cook 14 February 1779.

“I only hope so,” replied Harriet with a sigh, as she stood up. “Mama and I are walking round to see Aunt Hallett and Ann. “Do you want to come?”

“No... I’m going to read all these letters.”

Harriet smiled down at her sister. “You really are ridiculous.”

“There’s a big gap now,” Mary continued as she searched through the dates on the letters. “This must be when Papa returned home and was helping write the book about Cook’s voyage. You know the one, Harriet?”

“Of course I do,” replied Harriet, “it was one of the few times in their early life when Mama saw much of Papa... I cannot imagine anything worse than marrying a sailor.”

Mary’s eyes sparkled with indignation. “Don’t be silly Harriet. If you fell

in love with a sailor you would marry him.”

“Well I’m very thankful I haven’t.” Harriet concluded. “Henry is an artist.”

“Poor Papa, waiting for promotion to come through... and when you think how much he did on that last voyage of Cook’s.”

“I hope you have finished the letters by dinner time Mary... for until you have, we shall certainly get no sense from you.” At last Harriet was gone and Mary thankfully sank back on her bed. What a blessed relief to be alone again.

Once more she picked up the letters. It was clear that Mama and Papa were married at last, and that Papa had received another posting. It was sad, Mary thought, that he would have to leave so soon after their marriage, yet how tender the letters were.

Once again they came from many different places. One was the good news that the promotion to Lieutenant had finally been received and another described the part Papa had played in the Battle of the Dogger Bank where he fought under Admiral Hyde Parker against the Dutch and then another of his part in the relief of Gibraltar under Lord Howe.

All this fighting for so little money. But then another letter told of the thousands of pounds Papa received as his share of the royalties for the book on Captain Cook’s last voyage. And because of this windfall Papa told Mama to look around for a bigger house in London.

Then there came a change. The letters no longer were from warships but from merchant ships. The navy had been reduced and Papa was put on half-pay.

Mingled with the news, were the messages of love and affection, first for

Mama, but later for the growing family. First Harriet was mentioned then Mary thrilled to the first loving mention of, "that new little angel, Mary." Then Elizabeth appeared in the correspondence.

Mary lay back and gazed at the canopy around the top of her bed. She wondered if ever she would inspire such love in a man? Would she deserve it? Mama must have possessed infinite love and patience to have her babies and look after them when her husband was nearly always away. And what of Papa? Did he mind the ever-increasing family of daughters? If he did he never revealed his disappointment.

There was now another gap in the letters. This was when she was three, the time she thought she could remember, when the appointment to the Bounty came and she and Harriet went to Portsmouth to see Papa sail away.

Slowly she picked up the next letter, the important one. She looked at the address. This one had been written on the Bounty and she found it had been sent home by a whaler they had passed. She carefully read Papa's descriptions of the health and happiness of his crew and the care he was taking of them.

He fed them sauerkraut and malt, hot breakfasts and soup so that there were no signs of the dreaded scurvy. He described the constant airing and cleaning of the quarters below deck and the dividing of the watch into three to make the men's work less tedious. He said how successful it had been taking Byrne, the blind fiddler, so the men had constant exercise and entertainment by dancing.

"We are all in good spirits," Mary read on, "and my little ship is fit to go around a half of the world. My men are all active good fellows and what has given me much pleasure is that I have not yet been obliged to punish

anyone.

“My officers and young gentlemen are all well-disposed and we now understand each other so well unless I fall out with the doctor who I have trouble to prevent from being in bed fifteen hours out of twenty-four.

“I am at present determined to push around Cape Horn without touching anywhere as I have plenty of water but that must depend on the winds...”

Did that, thought Mary, sound like a man who bullied his crew? Surely it was more like a loving father talking about his children. The next letter came from the Cape of Good Hope. Mary knew why. For all his efforts, Papa had not been able to battle around Cape Horn.

“I arrived here yesterday,” he wrote from the Cape of Good Hope, “after experiencing the worst of weather off Cape Horn for thirty days; constant gales and very heavy snow storms. Indeed I may say for these last three months I have never seen such violent winds or such mountainous seas...

“We were obliged to be constantly battered down and if my little ship had not performed wonderfully we could not have born it so long. I still persevered in hope that the wind would moderate but to the contrary it increased and the heavy snow and hailstorms rendered my people sometimes incapable of doing anything. Winter has severely set in and I see no prospect of success. My people were falling ill of the rheumatism...

“During this time I suffered the greatest fatigue and anxiety. My people and I were obliged to nurse ourselves with utmost care and attention to keep dry clothes and bedding, which could only be done by constant

fires that I kept up night and day and by seeing they complied with my directions. I am satisfied for all my trouble by bringing them all here safe without a single complaint. A Dutch ship came today having buried thirty men and sent many to hospital..."

Yes, thought Mary, she had often heard Papa say how much better the English looked after their crews than some of the Dutch and French. It was not Papa's fault he had been unable to get around Cape Horn. In spite of all the Admiralty bungling he had been determined to succeed. After that letter Mary knew there was another long wait. The months of waiting turned into years. Now she could positively remember the anxiety, the brooding that hung over their narrow, three-storied house at Number 4 Broad Street, St. Georges-in-the-East.

And the memory of that fateful day, when the long-awaited letter arrived, was clear in her mind. She and Harriet were having tea with their Mama. Dear Mama, Mary appreciated, she had never banished them to the nursery as so many other mothers did but had always kept them around her. Through the years they had painted, read, played and sung together. "It's an overseas letter, Ma'am." The maid said as she handed Betsy a long folded packet. Mary remembered the moment so clearly.

"Overseas?" asked Mrs. Bligh hesitantly. She had waited so long for a letter that now it was difficult to believe in its existence. Mary thought Mama would never open it.

"Is it from Papa?" she asked excitedly as she watched her mother turn it over and look at the red seals and the address on the back.

"Yes... but there is something strange here. It is from Coupang in Timor. That was not on the Bounty's route. Has something happened?"

"Open it Mama! Please open it!" But still Mama looked at it, and then

studied the ends of the sheets of paper. With trembling hands Mrs. Bligh finally broke the seals. Slowly she unfolded the sheets and spread them out on her lap.

Chapter Five

“Coupang in Timor, August 19, 1789.

“My Dear Betsy,” Mary read to herself on her bed.

“I am now in a part of the world that I never expected. It is however a place that afforded me relief and saved my life and I have happiness to assure you I am now in perfect health.

“What emotion does my heart and soul feel that I have once more an opportunity of writing to you and my little Angels, and particularly as you would have no person who regards you as I do, and you must have spent the remainder of your days without knowing what has become of me, or what would have been still worse, to have known I had been starved to death at sea or destroyed by Indians.

“All these dreadful circumstances I have combated with success and in the most extraordinary manner that ever happened, never despairing from the first moment of my disaster that I should overcome all my difficulties.

“Know then my own Dear Betsy, I have lost the Bounty.”

Mary remembered how the pages had dropped from her mother's hands. “He has lost the Bounty!” she cried. “How can he bear it! What care he took of it. It will break his heart. Poor dear William.”

“What happened, Mama? Was it a storm? A reef?” Mary and Harriet shrieked as they had crowded around her in disbelief.

“I left Otaheite all well on the April 4, 1789 with 1,015 bread fruit plants

in pots and many more in tubs and boxes in perfect condition. On April 24, I anchored at the Friendly Islands and on April 26, I sailed with my expectations raised to the highest pitch of the great success I was likely to meet with. The ship in the most perfect order and every soul well.

“On April 26, at day light in the morning Fletcher Christian, having the morning watch, with several others came into my cabin while I was asleep and seized me holding naked bayonets at my breast and tied my hands behind my back and threatened instant destruction if I uttered a word. I however called loudly for assistance, but the conspiracy was so well laid that the Officers cabin doors were guarded by Sentinels, so that Nelson, Peckover, Samuels or the Master could not come to me.

“I was now dragged on deck in my shirt and closely guarded. I demanded of Christian the cause of such a violent act, and severely degraded him for his villainy but he could only answer, 'Not a word Sir or you are dead.'”

Once again Mama stopped reading. “Fletcher Christian! My darlings, how could Fletcher Christian do this to Papa? William had been so good to him.”

“Didn't he beg to go on this journey with Papa?” Harriet asked.

“Yes, he did. And he has twice before sailed under Papa, on Uncle Duncan's ships, and Papa has always treated him like a son. I can't believe it.”

“I dared him to act and endeavoured to rally someone to a sense of their duty but to no effect. Besides this villain I saw young Heywood as one of the ringleaders, and besides him I saw Stewart joined with him. I had assured Christian of promotion when he came home and with the other two I was every day rendering them some service. It is incredible! These

very young men I placed every confidence in yet these great villains joined with the most able men in the ship and got possession of the arms and took the *Bounty* from me with calls of 'Huzza for Otaheite!'"

"Isn't that the tropical island... the paradise?" Harriet interrupted. "And I thought the Heywoods are friends of Papa, aren't they?"

"Yes, yes. Both the Christians and the Heywoods are, I imagined," Betsy lamented. "As you know, there are many young midshipmen who want to go on these voyages to the South Seas. Papa took these two as a special favour. I don't know what your Papa will think." Betsy read out more of the letter to her astounded children.

"I therefore determined again to bring on some people to my assistance but I was carried across the deck, guarded and forced over the gangway where the boat was waiting for me.

"They had got water and a few trifling articles in the boat with about 150 pounds of bread and Samuel saved clothes for me but all my valuable maps, drawings and instruments were kept and the Timekeeper. I was now cast adrift."

"Cast adrift!" Exclaimed Mary. "Cast adrift! How dare they?"

"Do you remember the launch, darlings? Do you remember it? It was only twenty-three feet long and I can remember it on the plans."

"How many were put on it this small boat Mama?" Mary asked.

"Nineteen!"

For a moment there was silence. The picture before them was frightening. "Yet Papa must be safe. Here was the letter!" Harriet said in disbelief. Betsy read the whole letter to them.

"I can scarcely believe it," said Mama. "It sounds incredible."

Mary remembered how difficult it had been at first to fully understand the frightfulness of the journey. The few lines that described it were so simple. Mama had read it again and again, and they had calculated that eighteen men, crowded in that tiny boat for forty-three long days and nights and had journeyed four thousand miles of unknown ocean.

Mary had tried to imagine their sufferings in the wet and the cold, their cramped positions, their thirst and hunger. Betsy finally read out the last part of Papa's letter in distress.

"My misfortune I trust will be properly considered by all in the world. It was a circumstance I could not foresee. I had not sufficient officers and had they granted me Marines most likely the affair would never have happened. My conduct has been free of blame and I showed everyone that tied as I was, I defied every villain to hurt me.

"I know how shocked you will be at this affair but I request of you my Dear Betsy to think nothing of it. All is now past and we will again look forward to future happiness. Nothing but true consciousness as an officer that I have done well could support me.

"Give my blessing to Dear Harriet, my Dear Mary, my Dear Betsy and to all and tell them I will soon be home. To you my love I give all that an affectionate husband can give; love, respect and all that is forever will be in the power of your ever affectionate friend and husband.

William Bligh."

That was the end. Now, eleven years later, Mary read again the last loving words, and gently put down the letter. She was surprised to find her cheeks were wet with tears.

Without warning, the picture of Lieutenant Putland came before her eyes. How kind and understanding he had been the night before. It was

because of him, Mary remembered, that she had started reading the letters. Would he understand Papa? And what had her dearest Papa done to deserve such a mutiny?

It all seemed so strange. To hear what she had heard last night, such cruel words. Yet how had it all come about? She knew, of course, as she told Lieutenant Putland, that it had been caused by the Christians and Heywoods but it was frightening that such malicious rumours could be so successful.

Once more her mind went back, this time to when Papa came home from the mutiny. There had been no rumours then. Not the slightest blame was attached to him. Instead, there was honour and glory for his bravery and praise for his amazing journey.

She remembered every detail of his return; that wondrous day when Papa arrived home. It was at their old home near the docks. She would never forget the day he appeared on the door step, the blue and gold of his uniform and his piercing blue eyes. Everything that then happened she could clearly remember.

Of the nineteen men put adrift by the *Bounty* mutineers, twelve reached England safely. Two were lost on the way home and four died while still in Coupang or Batavia, the result of the hardships endured during the open boat voyage or most likely too much hard drinking when they finally reached land. What a tribute, thought Mary, to Papa's resilience and courage and iron will that so many men were saved.

For months there had been nothing but excitement. Her father was a hero. Not a breath of criticism was spoken against him then. He had

been the victim of a mutiny yet he had accomplished an amazing sea voyage to safety. Notices and accounts of it appeared in papers and magazines. A play was written around it and presented at the Royalty Theatre.

And there was a constant stream of visitors who called at No. 4 Broad Street. Invitations arrived also, some to very fashionable affairs, quite unusual for a Lieutenant in the Navy. Mary remembered how she had watched and listened as each exciting event followed the one before. Sir Joseph Banks called at their home several times. So famous had Papa become that Sir Joseph took him to be presented to the King. How they listened with bated breath to Papa's description of the Royal Court, of poor old George III, still in the possession of his thoughts, and of Queen Charlotte standing sternly in the background.

Not only was Papa famous but he was prosperous too. In such high favour did he stand with the Admiralty that he was kept on full pay most of the time, yet scarcely employed, and it was a time when many other officers were being put on half pay. Then more importantly came his appointment as Commander to be followed in only one month's time by the long anticipated promotion to Post-Captain.

Mary smiled as she remembered herself saying to her small friends and relatives, "and the Navy rules say that Commanders must wait three years before they can be made Captain. But Papa was made a Captain in a month!"

There was even more excitement to follow. The family could scarcely believe the next piece of news. The House of Assembly in Jamaica voted Bligh a gratuity of five hundred guineas. What a fortune it was for them. Although Bligh was not successful in his attempt to bring them

breadfruit, the Jamaicans wanted show their appreciation for his efforts and their sympathy for his misfortunes.

This led to Mama and Papa deciding to move to a larger and more attractive house. What excitement there had been in choosing the three storied house in Durham Park. It was a lovely home, thought Mary, with a park opposite and very convenient to everything.

Amidst all this excitement, a sixth little daughter had been born, Anne. She was nine now, and yet it seemed no time since the move to Durham Place and the birth of the new baby.

It was a year that Mary would never forget, a year that Papa rose from being an obscure Lieutenant to a famous Captain. Everyone understood the real reason for the mutiny, the determination of Fletcher Christian and the other men to get back to the beautiful women and the idle life on Otaheite. Christian's own native girl, Isabella, was to have a baby, and he was determined to return. Papa did not know this at the time, but he heard afterwards that one night Christian made a raft and was going to paddle back to the island on that. The other sailors told him he was crazy and prevented him. What a pity they didn't let him go!

But no, thought Mary, no-one blamed Papa for the mutiny then, only Christian and the mutineers. And how anxious everyone had been to read Papa's book. The book of everything that had happened. There was so much exploration happening around the world and here was a journey with a twist.

She picked it up from the bedside table, a large, thin book, and read the title,

“A NARRATIVE OF THE MUTINY ON BOARD HIS MAJESTY'S SHIP 'BOUNTY', AND THE SUBSEQUENT VOYAGE OF PART



The Bounty mutineers turning Lt. Bligh and some of the crew adrift.

OF THE CREW IN A SHIP'S BOAT, FROM TOFOA, ONE OF THE FRIENDLY ISLANDS TO TIMOR, A DUTCH SETTLEMENT IN THE EAST INDIES."

And underneath were the words, "WRITTEN BY LIEUTENANT WILLIAM BLIGH".

Mary would never forget the day that Mama brought the book home from the printer, Mr. Nicol. Betsy was so proud.

"Why is the title so long?" Mary had asked her father at the time.

"It was a long journey, my dear, so it called for a long title," he had replied.

As she had done then, she opened out a folded page near the front. She remembered how she called out excitedly, "Look Mama, the picture of the actual boat!" Once again Mary studied the diagram of the twenty-three foot launch.

Every board was marked in showing the exact size of each part of the tiny

vessel. It looked just like a small fishing boat and Mary marveled that eighteen men had travelled nearly four thousand miles in it. Next she pulled out yet another long folded sheet from the book, which showed the exact route the launch had followed. There were other maps. One was part of the Fiji Islands, which Papa discovered, and Mary remembered he had told her that, in spite of the terrible difficulties in the launch, he had gone a little out of his way to do this.

Lastly, there was the chart of the coast of New Holland, along which they had sailed. If they had been certain that Governor Phillip was already at Sydney Town they could have landed there, but it was too risky. When Bligh had first sailed, Arthur Phillip had not left England with his first fleet of convicts and soldiers.

As Mary sat on her bed and turned the well-worn pages, reading bits here and there, it brought to her mind a series of pictures so vivid that it was hard for her to believe she had not been present on the small boat. She realised that her early readings of the book had been supplemented by stories and descriptions told to her by Papa.

Nevertheless, the pages of the book carried her back, ten years, to relive that hot tropical dawn in a place she had never been and with people she had never seen.

Chapter Six

It was April 28, 1789, and William Bligh lay asleep in his cabin. His door was open to catch any breath of cool air that might find its way below deck, and also so he could easily be called by the crew. He slept with a clear conscience. He was a man who had brought this boat, the *Bounty*, with a small band of men, right around the world without illness or misadventure.

It was hardly the picture of a bully or a tyrant, thought Mary. Here was a man who slept with his cabin door open, a man who considered himself as a father to an adventurous, if not, irresponsible set of boys.

As he slept so peacefully, so unprotected, Fletcher Christian, a man inflamed with his desire to return to his beautiful native wife Isabella from Otaheite, was stirring up the crew against his Commander.

Suddenly Bligh was aroused to find his cabin full of rough swearing men and with Christian hauling him from his bunk. "One word from you, Mr. Bligh," he shouted angrily, "and you're a dead man."

Bligh was not to be silenced so easily. He roared for help, struggled and argued. It was no use however because the mutineers had control of the ship's arms and the other officers were imprisoned in their cabins below.

Bligh continued to struggle and shout but he was powerless against six armed men. Two of them held his arms behind his back while Christian cruelly tied his wrists with a thin cord. Then holding the cord he thrust Bligh, still only in his shirt, in front of him up the companionway onto the deck and all the way threatening to blow his brains out.

On the deck was utter confusion. Some of the mutineers were lowering the launch and men who were standing loyal to Bligh were being forced into it. The midshipman and Mr. Samuel, Bligh's clerk, were the first into the boat. Mr. Samuel had been quick witted enough to collect Bligh's journals, his commission, a few other ship papers, a quadrant, a compass and also a little food and some of Bligh's clothes.

Into the launch then went the whining carpenter, the cantankerous master, the quartermasters, the old sailmaker, the surgeon, the hard working botanist, and many others, who clambered down the side amid jeers, curses and shouts of abuse from the mutineers.

Bligh wrote in his diary, "The launch was hoisted out and eighteen people and officers were put into it while I was kept under armed guard with Christian holding me by the bandage round my wrist and a bayonet at my breast fearing I should get loose. He told me then, 'Sir, you're officers and men are now in the boat and you must go with them.'

Slowly the small launch sank lower and lower into the water and now there were roars of laughter from the mutineers. This was good sport. How many more before it would sink? Those already in the boat were calling out for food and water and arms. Some cutlasses and pieces of pork were roughly thrown down to them. Next the boatswain clambered in with sails, rope, a grapnel and a small cask of water. Then came the gunner and the cooks and the butcher until the launch could hold no more.

Confusion, shouting and swearing were mingled with roars of laughter and abuse. All this time Fletcher Christian held a bayonet to Bligh's throat while he both roared and pleaded with the mutineers to come to their senses. But they were drunk with power and carried away with their

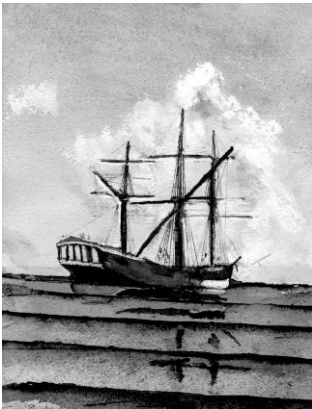
easy victory.

“Let's get back to the girls!” Christian called out triumphantly. So great was the appeal of the island paradise they had stayed at called Otaheite that mutiny was the only answer.

“Fletcher Christian!” Bligh whispered urgently. “How can you treat me like this? You have been as a son to me...”

Christian would not meet his Commander's eyes. His scowl deepened. “I have been in hell for the past two weeks,” he muttered angrily. “Not for a minute have I been able to forget my beautiful Isabella. Now be gone with you!” he shouted as he held the bayonet closer, “or I'll run you through.”

The small boat was finally set adrift with nineteen men in a twenty-three foot launch. The mutineers roared down their final insults and crude jokes. Michael Byrne, the blind fiddler, fingered the rail and leant over the side of the *Bounty* crying out because he had been left behind. And the two carpenter's mates and a loyal armorer called out that they had no part in the mutiny.



*Watercolour of the Bounty by
Dr Graham Harper*

Slowly the gap between the launch and the *Bounty* widened and the last sounds that could be heard echoing across the water from the *Bounty* were “Huzza for Otaheite!” As the sounds died away William Bligh gazed at the bewildered men gathered so closely around him.

His fury slowly abated and the enormity of the task before him gradually made itself

apparent. Leadership was needed as he counted those on board. Nineteen men, and hardly a good seaman among them; cooks, a butcher, a sail maker, a carpenter, a botanist, a clerk. Nearly all the sailors were on board the *Bounty*, and drawn from the lowest ranks of society, they were only too willing to risk mutiny for the sake of a life of leisure on a tropical island.

Any lesser man than Bligh would have quailed at the mere thought of getting those nineteen men home in a twenty-three foot launch. There was scarcely room for them to sit up comfortably. What was the possibility of returning them to civilisation? But the challenge was immediate and compelling. 'My God,' Bligh whispered to himself, 'if it's the last thing I ever do, I'll get them home.'

His first thought was for the food. "Pass it all up here," he said bluntly. "Every scrap of bread, every piece of pork. Come on there, let's see what we've got."

It was soon collected and there it lay, an inadequate and miserable heap of provisions any expedition had ever boasted. There were one hundred and fifty pounds of bread, sixteen pieces of pork, weighing about two pounds each, six quarts of rum, six bottles of wine, and only twenty-eight gallons of water for drinking.

"We will row and sail for that nearby island Tafoa and collect more food and water," Bligh ordered immediately giving his bewildered men hope. But these hopes were soon dashed when they reached the island. After three days searching they found only a few coconuts and a little water. Worse was to follow.

On the third day natives began gathering in their hundreds, some bringing a little food for the white men, some talking and some just

standing still watching. Gradually a change came over them and their friendliness changed to indifference. Then slowly an atmosphere of hostility spread amongst them. As small hostile acts went unpunished the natives began to realise that Bligh and his men didn't have firearms. Quietly at first, then more and more loudly, the natives started the slow knocking together of stones. The Englishmen knew that this was a sign of attack. A feeling of dread and presentiment started to overwhelm the small band of castaways. They heard the knocking together of stones growing louder and louder as the afternoon wore on. They saw the numbers ever increasing.

Bligh had seen his best friend Captain James Cook killed by natives. There was nothing he could have done at that time. It was a nightmare. Here he was witnessing a similar scenario unfold, except his men were unarmed.

At no time was William Bligh's courage and leadership greater than during that afternoon of fear. Bligh continued to bargain with the natives for small amounts of food they were bringing. He spoke cheerfully to the Chiefs and asked them to stop the natives touching his boat and he kept firm control over his own men who obeyed him implicitly. Some wanted to leave at once.

"No!" he responded sharply. "Can't you see? That's what they're waiting for. If they know we're leaving, they'll attack at once, and we shall have to fight our way out. We won't stand a chance!"

"Won't they attack anyway?" the armourer asked.

"If we wait until tonight we may be able to convince them we are going to sleep on the boat. Then we can get away. And if they do attack... and they probably will... we'll have more chance in the dark," Bligh confided

to his men casually. "Behave as if nothing happening." At the same time he ordered them to gradually get their supplies into the boat.

Then in front of hundreds of hostile natives, Bligh ordered the ration for dinner and had it served; a coconut and a breadfruit for each person and he also gave some to the Chiefs. After that some of the men began to get into the launch. And as darkness descended over the scene, Bligh gave the order for those still with him to collect the last of their supplies and move slowly towards the boat.

Immediately the tension became unbearable and a "silent kind of horror" fell over them. The knocking together of stones grew to an even higher pitch and the natives moved closer. Bligh then took the arm of one of the Chiefs, and holding it in a firm but friendly manner, walked with him to the water's edge until every other white man was in the launch. If they were attacked, Bligh determined the Chief would die also. But at the water's edge, with the men safely aboard, the Chief suddenly broke away and ran up the beach calling for the natives to attack. Bligh jumped on board and for an exhilarating moment it looked as if all would be right. Alas, disaster was near. John Norton suddenly realised that the stern rope had not been cast off and he jumped over the side and ran up the beach to undo it.

Confusion was everywhere. Everyone in the boat shouted for him to come back but it was too late. The natives jumped on this lonely, brave man, and in a few seconds he was clubbed and stoned to death.

Meanwhile, Bligh had quickly cut the rope. He knew he could offer no help to poor Norton as he roared to the men to start rowing fast and furiously.

As they drew away in the darkness a shower of stones hailed down

striking many of the men. Then dozens of natives loaded their canoes with stones and commenced to paddle after them. To the horror of those in the launch it was quickly obvious that the fast native canoes were gaining on them.

“Throw over some clothes!” roared Bligh. “Now, hurry!” He knew only too well the insatiable curiosity of the local inhabitants. The ruse was successful for the Englishmen.

The natives stopped to collect and examine the clothes as complete darkness fell over the small boat of frightened and bruised men. Once again they were safely on the ocean, though this time with only eighteen men aboard and even less provisions than before.

Then followed one of the strangest conferences in naval history. Bligh pointed out that the nearest white settlement was in Timor, nearly four thousand miles away and that the only hope of relief would be on the coast of New Holland. He announced that their provisions would allow them only one ounce of bread and a quarter of a pint of water a day for the whole journey and a little piece of pork or breadfruit. But worse, they didn't have a map.

The very next morning a violent storm hit the boat and every few moments waves came right over the men. Everyone had to start bailing desperately and by dinnertime they were drenched and miserably cold. Yet they were amazed to find their leader measuring out their dinner of one teaspoon of rum and a quarter of breadfruit. He was determined to make the food last the eight weeks he anticipated it would take to reach Timor.

For fifteen long dreary days the bad weather continued. By day and night the men were soaking wet and freezing cold with rain pouring

down and the sea breaking over them. The men had to bail constantly and although this exhausted them it probably kept them alive.

At first Bligh measured out the rations by guesswork but then to be certain everyone received an exact amount he made scales from two coconut shells with a pistol ball for weight. He arranged it so that half the men could partly lie down to sleep. No matter how tired they were he made them strip off their clothes and wring them out in salt water. This gave them some warmth.

For all of this, they were miserably, agonisingly cold, wet, cramped, and hungry. Everyone suffered from severe pains, and many of them regularly begged for more food but Bligh was adamant. He sat hunched up at the end of the boat, over chests of precious food, never sleeping, like a small squat bulldog. The lines that quickly grew on his taut, determined face, and the black stubble of beard, soon changed him from a young man of thirty-five to a harsh man of fifty.

As one cruel day succeeded another, the weather increased in its ferocity as if determined to blow the struggling castaways off the sea, yet Bligh wrote in his log every day.

“At dawn some of my people seemed half-dead; our appearances were horrible; and I could look no way but I caught the eye of someone in distress. Extreme hunger was now too evident, but no one suffered from thirst. I endeavoured to prove that we were more happy in our present situation than if we had fair weather.”

The storm and the rain continued and on May 22, it appeared as if the end were near.

“Our situation this day was extremely calamitous. We were obliged to take the course of the sea, running right before it, and watching with the

utmost care, as the least error in the helm could in a moment have been our destruction.”

Then the weather changed. On May 24, twenty six days after the mutiny, the sun shone again. Thankfully, the men were able to strip off their clothes and dry them and the warmth of the sun gently eased away some of the pain from their aching bodies.

One day, much to everyone's excitement, a large bird was caught. After that, practically every day brought them another bird, some days two. They were known as 'boobies', because of their foolish habit of landing in the boat and allowing themselves to be caught and they were as large as a duck. Bligh would divide the bird into eighteen parts, including entrails, beak and legs. The parts would then be given by lot to each man, a pitiful enough portion, but a feast in the circumstances.

The boobies made the men sure that land was near and renewed hope. Unceasing vigilance was kept and early in the night of May 28, the lookout suddenly saw the white foam of ocean breakers hurling themselves on reefs. Beyond this lay smooth water but there was no way through the treacherous coral. They sailed and rowed north with Bligh eagerly scanning the coast for a break.

His anticipation proved correct and with the greatest skill Bligh manoeuvred the small boat between the jagged, wonderfully coloured coral outcrops, showing their teeth on either side. Once on the smooth water inside they soon found an island and for the first time in twenty days the men were able to step wearily onto warm dry land.

“We now returned God thanks for His gracious protection, and with much content took our miserable allowance of a twenty-fifth of a pound of bread and a quarter of a pint of water for dinner,” Bligh wrote.

The island they named Restoration Island and on it they found oysters and fresh water and several kinds of berries. From the oysters and the inner part of a palm top they made several hot stews. Gradually they became rested and a little strengthened but natives were seen in the distance. So on the afternoon of May 30 they set sail again.

For the next three days they sailed up the inside of the Great Barrier Reef stopping at islands to sleep and to gather more oysters and clams and to replenish their water supply.

Bligh kept his iron control threatening to fight anyone who opposed his discipline and by June 3 they had reached the northern most tip of Australia. Then the little vessel was once more launched into the open ocean and encouraged by Bligh's reckoning that eight or ten days would bring them to Timor, the men were filled with optimism.

Almost immediately bad weather struck again and the exhausted men, soaked, cold and already weakened by their ordeal, were forced to commence bailing night and day. Gradually they began to fail. The surgeon and the old sail maker appeared near the end and Bligh gave them the blood of the birds and a little of the wine that had been kept.

By Wednesday, June 10, the whole crew was in an extreme state. Their legs were swollen, they were covered with sores, and their faces hollow with skin burned black and stretched over the bones. Several had great difficulty keeping awake or understanding what was happening.

"The boatswain," Bligh wrote, "innocently told me that he really thought I looked worse than any in the boat. The simplicity with which he uttered such an opinion amused me and I returned him a better compliment."

In such physical distress discipline was still maintained and only the thought that they had nearly reached their objective kept them alive. Finally, when hope almost died, and endurance almost ended, land was sighted. But natives could be unfriendly, so Bligh resisted all requests to land. He kept his men going until early in the morning of Sunday, June 14, 1789, when they reached Coupang, the small Dutch settlement at Timor.

Although the people of Timor could not hide their horror at the sight of the eighteen men that barely scrambled out of the small boat, they carried them up the shore to feed, clothe and care for them.

“And thus,” Mary read from her father's narrative, “happily ended, through the assistance of Divine providence, without accident, a voyage of the most extraordinary nature that ever happened in the world, let it be taken in its extent, duration, and so much in want of the necessities of life.”

Chapter Seven

Mary found that there were tears again on her cheeks. She put down the book on the bed and lay back with her eyes closed.

Why, she wondered, could people be so successful in spreading malicious stories about a man who could think, act, and write like that. Every word was so sincere and every action so obviously for the good of his men. Yet others, to suit their own ends had so wickedly twisted the truth.

Perhaps if he had not gone on the second breadfruit voyage it would not have happened. If he had been at home he would have been at the trial of the mutineers. He could have answered immediately the assertions of the Heywoods and Christians. He could have asked other witnesses, men from the actual open boat voyage to deny the allegations. By the time Bligh returned everyone had been scattered around various ships throughout England.

Nor could he have refused to go on the second voyage. It was an opportunity not to be passed up. And his good friend Sir Joseph Banks would not have taken kindly to the refusal of such an offer. And of course no-one envisaged a campaign to discredit William Bligh.

She remembered well the day he came to tell Papa the good news. Mary and Harriet were young then and had been ushered in to meet this great botanist. What sharp eyes and beetling eyebrows he had and the smartest velvet coat. She recalled how they had put on their best white

muslin frocks with cherry dots and velvet ribbons and they had been very careful with their curtsies.

“Upon my soul, Bligh,” Sir Joseph had said, “you have a couple of beauties here. Wait until they're sixteen and you'll have a house full of young naval officers after them.”

“I won't let them in!” Bligh had joked with pride.

“Are you proud of your Papa?” he asked them. “He's a famous man as you know. And I've got good news for you all, too.”

“What's that, Sir Joseph?” asked Papa.

“I've been making enquiries this morning. And giving advice and plenty of it, I can tell you, around at the Admiralty. And I've also seen the Secretary of State.” He paused for a moment, and looked around at the family group surrounding him. “They're going to send you after the breadfruit again my good man.”

Complete silence followed his announcement. This was not what they expected. Another appointment had been in their minds, but not this. Sir Joseph was obviously tremendously pleased with himself but Mary remembered the doubt in Papa's face. As for Mama, her smiling face clouded over, and Mary standing near her had immediately sensed that something was wrong.

“Good news, Sir?” asked Papa hesitantly.

“Yes Sir, yes indeed. You needn't look so worried. No mistakes this time, I can tell you. Two ships and you can choose them yourself. Plenty of officers, and a company of marines. What do you think of that?”

Papa's face had cleared instantly and he smiled at everyone.

“But that's magnificent, Sir Joseph,” he exclaimed. “Hear that my dear?”

He turned jubilantly towards Betsy. “Two ships!”

Mama had looked delighted but Mary knew now that her heart had been heavy with despair. She knew better than to displease Sir Joseph, one of Papa's few patrons, but another trip to the South Seas? Another long separation?

But young Mary had thought it sounded wonderful. She remembered how her eyes had moved quickly from Sir Joseph to her father as each spoke. Papa to go to the South Seas again! And two ships! If only she could go with them. If only she could be part of the adventure.

Suddenly her daydream was interrupted by a knock on her bedroom door and her mother put her smiling face in. "Mary, have you forgotten Sir Joseph is here for dinner? He would like to see you..."

"Oh..." Mary replied sitting up surrounded by her father's letters. "I was just thinking of him... what a strange coincidence... I'll be down in a moment Mama..."

The whole morning had seemingly whizzed by in a historical vortex. Mary quickly tidied together the letters from her father on his second breadfruit journey and went downstairs and entered the dining room.

There was Sir Joseph Banks and her Papa engrossed in conversation at the end of the dinner table as they were served soup by the maids. They were chatting about Lord Nelson and how he had been conspicuous by his absence the night before at the Grand Ball.

"Well I don't think he has any time for socialising I'm afraid," Sir Joseph was muttering, "you know he's been saying we should watch that fellow Napoleon... early days now..."

"I'd give anything," Bligh replied to Sir Joseph, "Just anything to serve under that man."

“Who? Nelson or Napoleon, William?” At that comment the two men burst into uproarious laughter.

“You men,” laughed Betsy, “always wanting action.”

They all smiled at Mary as she sat down at the table. “What a pleasure to see you again Sir Joseph.”

“Indeed, young lady. I was just admiring your dancing at the Grand Ball last night... what an evening...” Banks replied with a twinkle in his eye.

“Have you recovered from your first ball?”

“Yes I have. As a matter of fact I’ve spent the morning reading the letters Papa sent home from his various voyages. And I was just thinking of you, Sir Joseph,” Mary said as she placed her napkin on her lap.

“Really?” Banks replied with a surprised look. “What have I done this time?”

“I was thinking of that time you arrived here many years ago and offered Papa the second breadfruit journey...”

“Ah yes... a great success. But it didn't help your cause being out of the country did it William?” Banks said looking at Bligh.

“It must be wonderful, absolutely wonderful, to take part in voyages and battles. Do you remember when we went to see you off at Portsmouth on that second breadfruit journey Papa? How proud we were of the two ships, and what fine names they had; the Providence and the Assistant. Did you think of them, Papa?”

“Yes, I did my girl.”

“I remember thinking how small the Assistant was.”

“It was only a cutter,” replied Bligh, “just to help with the navigating.”

“I remember how angry you got, Papa”, said Harriet, “when Mama said

they seemed to be giving you everything this time.”

“Me angry, my girl? I’m never angry,” Bligh replied glancing at Banks.

“Oh yes, you were Papa,” agreed Mary. “You gave us quite a lecture on how badly they’d fitted out the first expedition, and if they’d fitted out the first expedition properly there’d have been no need for the second and probably no mutiny on the first either...”

“Well... that’s quite right too,” Bligh replied as he raised his eyebrows.

“Do you remember showing us the long shelves fitted with holes to take the breadfruit pots? And then we met that nice young midshipman who sailed with you, Matthew Flinders?” Mary continued as she glanced at Sir Joseph.

“Matthew Flinders!” Bligh enthused. “He’s a Lieutenant now. He went out to New Holland and I’ve just heard that he’s back in England again.”

“You know, the man wants to call Terra Australis, Australia, I don’t like that name... anyway he sailed around Van Dieman’s Land. They found that it’s quite separate from New Holland. Most interesting.” Banks continued with interest having been the botanist on Captain Cook’s first voyage of discovery to Australia in 1770.

“Sir Joseph showed us some of the charts, and they’re very good,” Bligh continued. “I was able to teach him a great deal on that second voyage, and I must say he’s profited from it. He wants the Admiralty to give him a ship so that he can sail round New Holland and chart every part of the coast in detail... it’s huge.”

“Papa, how wonderful!” exclaimed Mary. “And to think we met him. Do you think they’ll give him the ship? Will they let him go? They will surely approve of it.”

“I believe they are considering it,” Sir Joseph assured them all.

"That would be wonderful too," continued Mary, "to be the first person to sail right around New Holland. Do you know what I remember most from seeing you off that time, Papa?"

"No I don't..." Papa replied as he and everyone at the dinner table became absorbed in Mary's train of thought.

"I remember how I longed to go with you. I imagined how I could discover new islands with you and help you to chart new coasts... if I were with you I was positive no-one would hurt you. I was determined that I would be able to keep you safe from mutineers and natives."

"Really Mary?" said Harriet bluntly, "you're an idiot! Your mind runs on like a waterfall."

William and Sir Joseph laughed out aloud.

"I am sure you mean it, my dear," Bligh continued. "And any man who has the good fortune to win you for a wife will gain a loyal and steadfast partner."

"As a matter of fact, Papa," said Harriet, "the way you go on, I don't think any of us will get husbands."

"Whatever do you mean?" asked Bligh with an irritated tone. "What could make you say a thing like that?" Harriet's courage suddenly failed her and she looked down at the table.

Mary quickly came to the rescue. "It was that nice Lieutenant Putland who danced twice with me last night, Papa. You were so rude to him and it was all my fault. You know how I go on talking! I guess I shall never see him again..."

"He had no right to have two dances with you," replied Bligh indignantly. "I only told him what I think."

"And then," continued Mary staunchly, "you criticised Mr. Baker's

paintings in front of everyone. It was most tactless of you.”

“He had one of the sails wrong, you don't expect me to sit and say nothing do you?”

“He should be glad to learn,” Sir Joseph interceded in support of Bligh.

“But you could choose a better time, Papa,” said Mary. “If you continue to insult our suitors we shall all end up as spinsters, and just imagine, six spinster daughters!”

William Bligh suddenly smiled at his wife who was listening to the conversation with an amused expression.

“I can see,” he said, “I shall have to mend my ways. From now on, only absolute politeness to would-be suitors,” Bligh replied giving a bemused wink to Sir Joseph.

The lunch ended with Bligh and Sir Joseph adjourning to Bligh's study in good spirits having enjoyed the company of the children and the usual dinner table jousting.

Meanwhile, Mary sat at her piano and Harriet played the lute with Mama alongside listening when suddenly Lieutenant Putland was shown into the drawing-room. Betsy smiled to herself. This was the first young man to whom Mary had delivered a lecture of indignation about the family history, this was the young man to whom William had been so rude, yet here he was, the very next day. How interesting it was.

As for John Putland, he had been determined to wait at least a week before calling, but his resolve had steadily weakened as the morning progressed. Could anyone, he wondered, be as beautiful as he remembered this girl?

He entered the room. Mary rose up from her piano with some

confusion and surprise. This was the first young man who had called on her, and in her wildest dreams she would not have expected to see this particular Lieutenant again so soon.

“Lieutenant Putland!” she exclaimed. “It is so nice to see you!”

“I have come,” said Putland slowly, with the words he had rehearsed, “to apologise for keeping you for two dances last night. I hope you will forgive me...”

“There is nothing to forgive! I was delighted!” exclaimed Mary. There was silence for a moment, as they gazed at each other.

But Mrs. Bligh quickly came to the rescue. She was an accomplished hostess, and Lieutenant Putland soon fell under her spell. From girlhood, she had been accustomed to entertaining young Navy men, first for her father, then for her husband. Now it appeared she was to occupy the same role for the friends of her growing daughters. Bred in an atmosphere of learning, with her father a Doctor of Laws, her quiet intelligence quickly charmed all with whom she came into contact. She led Lieutenant Putland to talk of his part in the Battle of the Nile under Nelson, they discussed the famous tactics Nelson had used to rout the French fleet, sailing between them and the coast as well as in front of them. They were all familiar with the result, and with Nelson's famous words that the battle had been, “...not only a victory but a conquest”, with ten of the thirteen French fleet taken or destroyed.

After a little while, when the younger girls came in, there was much chatter and laughter. Elizabeth was now fourteen years old, Frances and Jane were twelve, and Anne was nine. If Lieutenant Putland were dismayed at the number of girls in the family he did not show it. If Captain Bligh could manage them, so could he. As conversations

generally did in those days, this one returned later to the subject of Lord Nelson and his victories.

"I was wondering, Miss Bligh," said Lieutenant Putland looking at Mary, "if you would care to join some friends of mine next Wednesday afternoon. We are to visit the Panorama in Leicester Street. Do you know it? There are, I believe, some wonderful scenes there from the battles of Nelson. I would particularly like to see those of the Battle of the Nile."

Mary smiled demurely. "I should be delighted, Lieutenant Putland," she replied. "I feel sure they must be very magnificent."

Harriet was not to be outdone by her younger sister. "I feel sure, Lieutenant Putland," she said with a serious face, "that Mary would be honoured to have you explain them to her."

"I have always so wanted to see them," continued Mary, "so much."

If these two were looking at him with wide, innocent eyes, their younger sisters were not so clever at hiding the truth. By now, they were smiling and looking at each other and giggling.

And what, thought Putland, have I done now? He was to find that visiting a family with six daughters combined the advantage of receiving much attention, with the disadvantage of always being conscious of several pairs of bright eyes watching his every action.

"I'm afraid, Lieutenant Putland," said Mrs. Bligh quietly, "that they are teasing you. You see, the artist who painted the Panorama is engaged to Harriet. The girls know these paintings very well."

"Where the Bligh family is concerned," he exclaimed, "I seem doomed to do the wrong thing."

"Oh no, no," said Mary, suddenly and very earnestly, "you must not

think like that. It was all my fault last night at the Ball. Mama says I must not go on about Papa when people criticise him. And Lieutenant Putland, I would just love to come to the Panorama with you."

"Fine," he replied firmly. "I shall take you at your word. Only you shall show me the Panorama, instead of me showing it to you."

Arrangements were quickly made for Putland and his sister and her husband to call for Mary in their carriage the following Wednesday, and then he left. As soon as the door closed behind him, the excitement among the younger girls could no longer be restrained.

"Mary's first beau," shouted Anne dancing around merrily.

"Be quiet," responded Mary quickly.

"But he's so nice," said Elizabeth, "and so good looking... I wish he was taking me to the Panorama..."

Chapter Eight

Excited by Lieutenant Putland's surprise visit, Mary was even more strengthened in her determination to continue with Papa's letters. She went to bed early, hoping it would be at least an hour before Harriet followed her, and the light would be turned off.

It was August, 1791, when the two ships for the second breadfruit journey sailed. The first letter came from Teneriffe and mentioned excruciating headaches and a bout of fever that Papa had suffered. Poor Papa, thought Mary, he had never really recovered from the open boat voyage. The next letter, which came from Santiago, was not in Papa's handwriting.

"My Dear Betsy," read Mary.

"I beg you will not be alarmed at not seeing my own handwriting. I am vastly recovered since my letter to you from Teneriffe, but as my fever is of a nervous kind, Mr. Harwood thought it improper from me to attempt writing. I anchored here today to procure a little fruit, and shall leave by midnight, as I find it an unhealthy time of the year. I am now taking the bark and feel considerably stronger and hope before we reach the Cape to be perfectly re-established in my health and from there I shall give you a full account of how I have proceeded. I am confident it is ordained for us once more to meet. You may therefore cherish your dear little girls in that happy hope.

"My blessing to them all and with that affectionate esteem and regard you have ever known me, I remain your sincere and affectionate

husband. God bless you my dear love and my little angels.

William Bligh.”

After that, it seemed that Papa's health must have improved. Letters from the Cape of Good Hope were more cheerful. Then after the Cape there was the usual long delay. In the South Seas, so far away, there were no settlements, not even another ship, and no hope of a letter being sent home.

At last, however, came Papa's final letter. It was written from Coupang in Timor again, but the address this time did not mean bad news, for Mary knew that Coupang was on the planned homeward route for this journey.

“My ever dear love and my dear children,

“I am happily arrived here and I anchored this day and found a country ship bound for Batavia, by which I have this opportunity to tell you I am well, except a low nervous disease which I have had more or less since I left Tenariffe. I have gone through the most extreme dangers, but after all a gracious God has restored me to this place of safety.

“I left Otaheite on July 19, with 2,634 plants on board and came through Endeavour Straits surrounded by reefs, dangers and treacherous inhabitants, with the loss of only one man, who was shot with an arrow. I shall leave letters for you when I sail and I hope my dear Betsy, a week will be the most of my stay here to get water and fuel.

“This is the last voyage I will ever make if it pleases God to restore me safely to you...”

“Papa's last voyage!” Mary remembered Mama saying in excitement when she read it to them. Perhaps if she had known how much unhappiness was to follow, she would have wished him away again. Even at the time, she remembered that Mama's joy had quickly led to doubts.

“But if he's here,” she had said, “it will probably mean he will be sent to dangerous battles.”

“But there's no war now, Mama,” said Harriet.

“We can't be sure, my darlings. They say this young Napoleon is determined to conquer the world. There are more battles to come, I feel sure.”

“I hope,” she read, “I shall live to see you and my dear little girls. Success I hope will crown my endeavours and that we shall at last be truly happy. I only wait for wood and water which will not detain us more than a week, for I am anxious not only to be with you, but the westerly monsoon is at hand.

“I sent to you feathers and valuable papers from the Cape of Good Hope, which I hope you have received. My plants, except 200 which are dead, are in fine order and I think it is not likely 200 more will die in the remainder of the voyage.

“I have written to Sir Joseph Banks and the Admiralty recommending you and my dear little girls to him. I hope he has shown some kindness since I left you. Next June, dear Betsy I hope you will have me home to protect you myself. I love you more than ever a woman was loved. You have not been out of my mind for a moment, every joy and blessing attend your life, and bless my dear Harriet, my dear Mary, my dear Betsy, my dear Fanny, my dear Jenny and my dear little Anne.

“I send you all many kisses on this paper and ever pray to God to bless you. I will say farewell to you now my dear Betsy because I am homeward bound. I shall lose no time. May every happiness attend you my dearest wife and ever remember me as your best friend and most affectionate husband.

William Bligh.”

Mary lay back and thought of the loving words. Once again she wondered would any man ever write such letters to her or show her such love and affection? Through her dreaming, she saw the face of Lieutenant Putland. Would it be this man, the first with whom she danced, and whom she already liked immensely? Or would it be someone quite different, someone living somewhere else now and waiting for the time they would meet?

Mary's first ball and her visit to the Panorama with Lieutenant Putland began a round of happiness and social life. There were other balls and dinners, musical and card evenings, and weekends in country homes and there was calling and receiving calls. Lieutenant Putland was not the only young man, but he was the most constant and most favoured.

It was a hectic, feverish season, and everyone felt they must enjoy it to its full. There was peace, but it was an unhappy, uneasy peace. Napoleon's navy had been defeated at the Nile, but most of his army had miraculously found its way back to France. Everyone in England was conscious of him, across the channel, planning and waiting for a chance to attack once more his most hated enemy, England.

So the young people at home, especially those in the Navy, danced away the few months they had, wondering when they would next be called upon to endeavour to humble again the French Navy. The Bligh family was doubly affected. Not only would the young men disappear, but so would their beloved Papa, at present in command of the warship, the Director.

In the meantime, they tried to forget the ever present worry and to enjoy the time given to them, the tremendous pleasure of having their Papa so

often with them, and the importance and advantages of his wide circle of friends. For if there were still unkind rumours about William Bligh, those near to him knew they had no foundation.

And as Betsy watched her family of girls; happy, excited, surrounded by attentive young men, she thought of Harriet's forthcoming marriage and she enjoyed the company of her husband. They had their new home and six growing daughters and William was a success. Or was he?

He was not given another command for a long time. He was given no encouragement to write a book on his second journey for breadfruit. The influential relatives of Peter Heywood had been at work while he was thousands of miles away at sea and he had no chance to reply.

But all this waiting around for a new command paled into insignificance for the Bligh family because Betsy became pregnant again and this time she sensed not only that she was expecting a boy but the doctor told her it could be twins. It was something William Bligh most wanted and his wish was granted. Twin sons were delivered and were named William and Henry.

However, as was a fate so common, the joy was soon followed by great sorrow. The babies only lived for one day and Betsy never again regained her full health.

The coolness of the Admiralty then vanished and a more balanced view took its place. The innuendoes and the criticism were forgotten. Bligh was far too capable a man to be long out of favour, and only one month after the death of his sons, he was once more given a command. It was the 24 gun Calcutta, an armed transport, and under Admiral Duncan he spent the next autumn and winter helping to blockade the Dutch fleet in

the Texel.

Then, early in the new year, 1796, he was transferred to the 64 gun Director. It was Bligh's first battleship, his first important naval command, with 64 guns and 491 men. Then followed some of the busiest, most exciting and happiest years of their lives. If she knew that William was often in danger, she also had the joy of seeing him regularly. When he was on leave, or when he could get away from his ship, he would be at home. How different, she thought, from those long exploratory voyages in the South Seas.

It was while he was on the Director that the mutiny at the Nore broke out, and she remembered the important part her husband had played in the negotiations. It took all of Betsy's calmness and tolerance to face some of the stupid accusations with a wry smile. The family knew, of course, that the mutiny had nothing to do with William. It was a general mutiny among sailors throughout the entire fleet. The conditions under which they lived and worked were appalling, and yet, as soon as danger to the country had passed, many of them were dismissed. There were commanders who had shocking, unreadable records of cruelty.

The inevitable result was mutiny, and it was during this mutiny that Admiral Duncan found himself blockading the Dutch without a fleet. By sending signals from his flagship, he made the Dutch believe that the remainder of the ships were still standing by.

Meanwhile, back in England, commanders of all ships were ordered by the sailors to go ashore and William Bligh was one of these. But when the mutiny was over, and the mutineers were asked to draw up a list of commanders against whom they had grievances, Bligh was not on that list.

More honour was to follow. While still in command of the *Director*, Bligh took part in the Battle of Camperdown, in 1797, where the British fleet under Admiral Duncan soundly defeated the Dutch. During this battle, Bligh's ship acquitted itself with great honour, and was partly responsible for capturing the Dutch flag-ship, the *Vryheid*.

The girls' pride in their father after this battle could hardly be contained. All this time, they had been growing up, increasing in intelligence and beauty, and becoming more concerned with everything their father did.

After the Battle of Camperdown Bligh stayed in the fleet until 1799, and after that the Admiralty set him to work mapping the harbour of Dublin. It was evidence of the worth the Admiralty considered him. When peace had come, after Nelson had so soundly defeated the French at the Nile, he had been given this surveying and charting work instead of being put on half-pay.

It had been a happy New Year and a happy new century for the Bligh family. If only it could last. Now was the time, with their daughters reaching a marriageable age, and with Betsy's own health failing, that they needed peace and rest. But would they be allowed to keep it? It was common knowledge that Napoleon had to be beaten or he would never rest until England was subjugated.

Little did Betsy know that the real enemy of the future happiness was not Napoleon, but a man who had already begun his machinations in a star-crossed penal settlement on the other side of the world considered as a 'thief-colony.'

Chapter Nine

“Betsy!” called William, as he stood at the foot of the stairs. “Betsy!” he called again, as he excitedly walked into the drawing room and then into the study.

“Whatever do you want, William?” She appeared at last, putting her head out of the front door of an upstairs bedroom. “I shall be down in a minute.” He was half way up the stairs before she started to walk down.

“I’ve a new command,” he shouted, waving a piece of paper.

“Does it mean good news?” asked Betsy anxiously.

“Of course it does, Betsy, my dear, it’s the Glatton,” he announced proudly as they stepped down the stairs together. “We’re to put to sea immediately and under Lord Nelson, my dear! What do you think of that? Under Lord Nelson at last. We’re going to hunt down the Danish fleet. We’ll teach them to put that wretched blockade on our shipping.”

“And you call that good news?” replied Betsy faintly.

“What am I trained for, if it isn’t this?”

“I suppose so...” Betsy answered in a resigned manner.

How like a man, she thought. All our peace and happiness at an end, and yet here he is, excited at the thought of hunting out the Danish fleet. What of the family at home? What of their waiting and fear?

Their brief happiness was over. To be sure, there had been ominous warnings and rumours since Christmas, so at least she had been prepared. At the beginning of the year, Russia, Denmark and Sweden,

urged on by Napoleon, had again decided to exclude British shipping from the Baltic, and as shipping and trade were the life and blood of England, she had once more to prove she was the mistress of the seas. So a great fleet mobilised, under Admiral Hyde Parker and Lord Nelson, and Captain Bligh with the H.M.S. Glatton was to be one of the ships to sail away.

Just one day after he left to join his new ship, Lieutenant Putland called, quite early in the morning, and it was obvious to Betsy at once that he was agitated about something and she had a terrible feeling exactly what it was.

As on his first visit she received him alone. She had been sitting at the small secretaire in the drawing room, desolately trying to sort some of the shells in her large collection, and wondering if she would see her husband again. She knew there would be danger in these new engagements.

"Lieutenant Putland," she said smiling, as she stood to greet him. "What a pleasure to see you. We are all very dismal here, for Captain Bligh left us yesterday to join the Fleet."

"I am so sorry," replied Putland, "and I must apologise for calling so early, but I am leave this afternoon! It is very sudden."

"So soon?" asked Betsy, feeling contrite that she had been thinking only of herself. "But perhaps you do not mind so much. I'm afraid you men like action."

"Well Ma'am," replied Putland frowning slightly, "it is what we're trained for, of course."

How like William, thought Betsy. "Do sit down", she said.

"No, no. I cannot sit down. I must see Mary. I've had no chance to say

goodbye. I must have a word with her before I go. There will not be another opportunity..."

"I shall get her for you. She is upstairs in her bedroom."

Abruptly he started to speak again. "I do not just want to say good-bye. There is more Ma'am, would you be so kind as to leave us alone for a little while?"

Betsy frowned. There could be only one thing Putland wanted to say to Mary, and it worried her very much indeed. And Mary was so young. "Lieutenant Putland," she said carefully, in her gentle way. "I do hope you will not think I am presuming too much, but I do hope you're not going to ask Mary to marry you?"

John Putland looked startled. He coughed and cleared his throat. "If I did, Ma'am, would you have any objections?"

"Only that she is so young, so very young. Do you realise she will not even be seventeen until next month? Mary is so intelligent, that it is often difficult to remember her age, but she has seen so little of the world. Do you understand? I do not approve of girls marrying so young. I feel they should have some freedom, a good opportunity to meet many people. I am sorry if this seems unreasonable."

"No, not at all, Mrs. Bligh," he replied. "I do understand it, and I promise I shall not ask her to marry me. But I would like to see her alone."

"All right," replied Betsy, getting up to leave the room. "I shall see if I can find her and send her down to you... she's probably still asleep."

For a few minutes he had the room to himself. His eyes wandered to the framed maps on the wall. Then, hearing the door open quietly, he turned around to see Mary enter the room. She was in her dressing

gown, and her long hair untied, as if she had just got out of bed.

"Lieutenant Putland!" she exclaimed, her face alight, as she came towards him. Suddenly she stopped. "What is wrong... you look so serious. Whatever is the matter?"

"I have received my orders today to join the Fleet," he replied abruptly.

"I must leave this afternoon."

Mary's eyes were bright, the colour high in her cheeks and her heart and mind were in tumult. She had explored this scenario many months before. Possible naval actions were discussed all the time by the men. She felt dismay, because he was leaving, yet excitement too, and envy that he was to set sail with Lord Nelson.

But beneath it all there was a deep feeling of joy because he had come straight up to her with this news. Up until now she had liked him, liked him more than anyone else, but they had been nothing but friends who found much pleasure in doing things together.

"Mary," he said slowly, "will you let me hold one of your hands?" She held it out to him simply, "You see," he said carefully, and smiling a little, "perhaps if I hold it, it will help me say what I want to say. I am not very good at this, you know, I'm more at home on deck shouting at sailors..."

"You sound like Papa," Mary said smiling.

"Yes. I guess I am, in many ways." He was still looking at her hand. "It is a beautiful hand, you know. Just like your face." He suddenly looked at her. "Did you know I thought your face was beautiful?" For once Mary could say nothing, but her eyes kept smiling at him, encouraging him to continue.

"You must have seen how I have kept looking at you... all these months.

And now I want to ask you something very important.” He smiled again.

“Your Mama says I must not ask you to marry me...”

“But...” interrupted Mary.

“But now I have started you must let me finish. She is quite right about that. You are too young. Much too young. And I am several years older. It is something else I want to ask you.”

“Yes?”

“It's a promise. I want you to promise not to marry anyone else until you see me again.” Again Mary started to speak. “No. Let me finish. You see, I may be gone a long time. Who knows? The Navy is a very strange place. A year, two years, no-one can tell. I could find myself cruising the Mediterranean, or kept blockading some port. And you could meet someone else and marry him, not knowing that... I love you.” Mary did a partial squint as John continued. “I would not tell you so soon, if it were not for the uncertainty. So that's all I want. Just a promise. That until we have time to know each other better... will you wait?”

Suddenly Mary laughed and it eased the tension. “Do you know,” she replied, “that's exactly what Papa said to Mama before he sailed away with Captain James Cook.”

“Is it really?” asked John, wonderingly.

“But Mama was twenty-three and I'm only seventeen next month.”

“I guess I am being foolish,” continued John.

“Oh no,” replied Mary earnestly. “No, not at all. With all my heart, I promise...”

Chapter Ten

Waiting, thought Mary angrily, waiting is the worst part of being a girl. Waiting for the bell to ring, or for the sound of a carriage, the clacker of horse's hooves outside. Worst of all waiting for news; a letter, a town crier, anything that would tell you what the Fleet is doing.

The family was sitting around the fireplace, sewing, working tapestry, and talking. Tapestry, thought Mary as she looked scornfully at her sisters and her dearest Mama with their heads bent over their work. How could they bear it? Then her scornful, rebellious thoughts flew to the Fleet again. What were they doing? Where were they? And why couldn't she be with them? Why did men have all the exciting things to do while women stayed at home and waited?

Yesterday had been April 1 and Mary had turned seventeen. There had been a dinner party to celebrate it. That, she thought, was the most exciting thing that had happened to her lately. There would be more dinners and balls and card parties, but now that the Fleet had gone everything seemed to have lost its interest because the men were not there.

Not only was there boredom there was also the anxiety and the wondering. Mary's restlessness could contain itself no longer. She suddenly stood up.

"How can you bear it," she asked angrily. "Sitting here and sewing and talking, when out there they may be fighting to death?"

"Mary, Mary dear, sit down," replied her mother gently. "What else can

we do? And you forgot that I've had a lot of practice. I've spent my whole life waiting for news of your father."

"I don't know how you could. All these years! Waiting! Waiting!" She threw her tapestry on the floor. "I swear I'll never do another stitch until we hear news of the battle."

"Don't be silly, Mary," said Harriet, as she quietly picked up the tapestry and put it on the table. "Do you think it's helping Mama for you to go on like this? Do you think we're not all thinking of Papa?"

Mary turned to her, eyes bright with anger, her mouth scornful. "You can talk," she shouted, "Henry is safely at home, isn't he? He's not away fighting. What do you know about how I feel?"

Harriet turned pale. "What an unkind thing to say," she replied, almost in tears.

"Yes Mary," said her mother. "That was most unfair."

Mary gazed at the circle of unfriendly faces looking at her, burst into tears, and rushed out of the room. There was silence for a moment, and then Mrs. Bligh picked up her tapestry and started to work again.

"It is very hard for her," she said quietly. "We must all be very understanding."

About an hour later, knowing that her anger would have died away, Betsy went upstairs to comfort her unhappy daughter, and brought back a contrite sister to the loving family circle. While this battle raged at home, and Mary's anger rose and spent itself, so too had another battle been waged, many hundreds of miles away, and they were now counting the dead.

All day long the slogging battle outside Copenhagen had continued. Nelson had turned a blind eye to Admiral Hyde Parker's orders to delay

and, with only part of the fleet, had forced his way up the straits of Copenhagen, and Bligh commanding the Glatton, had followed closely behind to take up his position close to the Danish ship.

They were fired upon by both enemy ships and shore batteries, but they had fought it out without flinching and from early morning until evening the bloody battle had continued.

At seven o'clock in the evening, just about the same time as Mary's outburst, Bligh went wearily into his cabin. He rubbed his grimy hands over his red, aching eyes. While his men outside were attending the injured and dead, washing the blood from the decks, and trying to restore some order among the smashed masts and the wreckage of riggings and guns, he sat down at his desk.

He was desperately tired, but they had won a great battle and it must be recorded. He tried hard to recall the order in which the events took place. He frowned as he picked up his quill, and then slowly and painfully began to write.

"At 7.40 am there was a signal for all Captains. At 7.47 another signal; prepare for battle and anchor by the stern, with springs on the cables. At 9.45 prepare to weigh anchor. At the same time Edgar, Ardent and Glatton weighed anchor and the other ships followed in succession.

"After engaging from the south end of the enemy's lines we anchored precisely in our station abreast of the Danish Commodore. At 10.26 the action began. At noon, the action was continuing and very hot, ourselves much cut up. Our opponent, the Danish Commodore, struck us, and his second boats ahead and astern still kept up a strong fire. At 11.24 our top mast was shot away and seven of our upper deck guns were disabled by the enemy..."

He stopped for a minute to think sadly, curling his quill, of the many men he had lost. They had been in the centre of fire from all sides, yet none of his crew had wavered. Thank God it had ended at last.

"The action continuing was very hot," he wrote. "At 2.45 it may be said to have ended. Lord Nelson in the Elephant, our second ship ahead, did me the honour to hail me to come on board, and thank me for the conduct of the Glatton..."

As he wrote on, describing how nearly the whole Danish Fleet had been sunk or captured, and the shore batteries silenced, his mind was partly occupied with reliving the moment when he had stood before the thin, exhausted, battle-scarred Lord Nelson and experienced the amazing magnetism of his personality as he was praised for his part in the action. It was a moment Bligh would never forget.

So the Battle of Copenhagen was won and once more shattering blow was struck at Napoleon's hopes and ambitions.

It was a long time before those waiting anxiously at home heard about it. News of such great importance had to be taken by ship and then by stagecoach to the Admiralty. Then Mr. Saunders, a young clerk at the Admiralty, and a friend of the Blighs, hurried around to tell them of the great naval victory in which William Bligh had played such an important part.

"But is William quite safe? Is he unharmed?" asked Betsy urgently, caring less about the victory than about the life of her husband.

"There is no mention of your husband in person, Mrs. Bligh," replied the young man. "Only that the Glatton fought gloriously. But I feel sure that had he been wounded or killed it would have been stated. The despatches mention that Captain Riou, commanding the Amazon was

killed by gunshot. I feel sure that no news means good news.”

“Oh, I hope so. I really hope so,” exclaimed Betsy.

“And what of Lieutenant Putland?” asked Mary desperately. “He is only a Lieutenant. He would merit no special mention, would he...?”

“I’m afraid not, Miss Bligh. We can tell you nothing about him. I am extremely sorry. There has been no casualty lists yet. They estimate the British loss at about 350 killed and 850 wounded. But the Danish losses, they say, have been immense.” So Mary’s anxiety was not over. She knew the fate of the Fleet but not the fate her Lieutenant Putland. The waiting hung over her like a depressing pall that was always there from morning until night. It never went away.

Many weary weeks were to pass until letters were suddenly delivered to both Mrs. Bligh and to Mary. They had probably come on the same boat bringing mail from the Fleet back to England. Mary snatched her letter from the maid and looked at the writing.

“It is from him, Mama,” she cried. “It is from him. He must be safe.”

She broke the seals quickly and read the short note. “Yes, yes, Mama, he is safe!” she said and burst into tears of relief.

It was a short formal note telling Mary that he thought she might like to know he was quite well and had come through the battle unharmed and that as soon as the Fleet returned to England he hoped to see her. It was not perhaps a very exciting letter, but Mary kept it in the bottom of her workbox, and possibly the presence of it made her sewing and embroidery seem less tedious.

While her sisters comforted and rejoiced with Mary, Betsy quietly opened and read her letter from William. It was a long and joyous letter giving many details of the action and describing the honour Nelson had

done Bligh. It also contained the news that Bligh had been promoted to the command of H.M.S Monarch, a 74 gun ship, whose captain had been killed in action. When her daughter had quietened a little, Betsy drew their attention to the fact that she also had a letter.

“And would you perhaps like to hear what your dear Papa has to say?” she asked.

“Oh, yes, yes,” Mary apologised. “How selfish I have been.”

When Betsy had finished reading Papa's letter there were more exclamations of excitement. “Mama!” gasped Mary. “I don't think I can ever remember such a day. Papa getting such recognition and a promotion, and Lieutenant Putland safe! It is almost too much for one day.”

“We must all be very thankful,” replied her mother. “I wonder if they will be coming home soon...”

For a month there had been no further news. And as the weeks passed she yearned to see her Lieutenant again, for the young man she met at home seemed to have lost their flavour in comparison. Betsy smiled at her daughter's impatience.

“He has only been away two months,” she laughed. “When your father went away with Captain Cook, I had to wait for years...”

“How could you endure such an eternity!”

“It is amazing what you can endure when you have to. And anyway, I do wish you would take an interest in some of the other young men you meet.”

“Mama!” Mary replied impatiently. “None of them is like Lieutenant Putland!”

Fortunately for Mary the Fleet returned to Nore on May 7, and a brief

reunion took place. Again there was much excitement; dinners, a ball, and general rejoicing over the Naval victory.

In another part of England, another moving reunion took place. Lord Nelson returned after his triumphant victory and hurried down to the countryside to see his Emma he thought so beautiful, and the small daughter that had been born to them that spring.

She was called Horatio Nelson Thompson, and was christened with Nelson and Lady Hamilton acting as godparents. It was Nelson's wish that later they would officially adopt the small girl, so that her position in life would be assured. As during the previous year, Nelson was again lauded and cheered wherever he went, and Lady Hamilton and her husband travelled at his side.

As for Bligh, their rejoicing was brief. He was promoted to yet another command, the H.M.S Irresistible, a fine ship of 74 guns, which for part of the time had been Nelson's flagship at the Battle of Cape St. Vincent. So Bligh and Putland had to return to duty. After that Mary did not see John for over a year for his Navy service kept him out of England.

There were letters, however, and occasional visits from Papa, but above all there was Harriet's wedding to be planned. Everyone helped make her trousseau, and there was the wedding gown to be chosen and those for the bridesmaids, which included Mary and Elizabeth. There were the guests to select, and many more details that required attention.

The marriage took place early in 1802, and Papa was home to give the bride away. Once again Betsy felt that joy and happiness had perhaps come to stay. William was content with his fine new ship, Harriet was supremely happy, and Mary also seemed content waiting for the next

time to see John. If she felt some regret that Mary's attachment appeared to grow stronger as time went on, there was nothing she could do about it. Nor were there reasons she could logically give against John. He was well mannered, good looking and obviously devoted to Mary.

There was, however, a constant regret that Mary should have fixed her affections on one man when so young, and also a sorrow that, through marrying a sailor, she may suffer the same as her mother had.

Again their happiness was short lived. At the end of May what all officers feared occurred and William was once more put on half-pay. Everyone knew that the French Navy had still to be faced and beaten, and yet the British authorities, as soon as immediate danger was past, put many of their officers on the bread line. The same treatment was meted out to Lieutenant Putland, and though he was often at Mary's side, he was a somewhat disconsolate companion, and one in no position to offer marriage to a young girl.

Christmas came and went and the spring of 1803 brought warmth and flowers to the parks. It should be bringing us happiness, thought Betsy, as she went about her daily routine, but instead there was nothing but worry where ever one looked.

William was home and safe, but he was a constant irritant at her side. He fretted and fumed at the inaction forced on him and he never ceased criticising the Government for allowing the Navy to be reduced. It was obvious they would be needed soon, but in the meantime good men from his ships had become scattered throughout the country and found employment elsewhere.

Mary was far from happy. She could think of no-one but Putland, and yet there was little prospect of any marriage. He was working as a clerk

while waiting for further Navy work, and he too was discontented and restless. Betsy was far from satisfied with their friendship, and it seemed a poor match. John Putland appeared to have none of the prospects in the Navy that William had at the same age. There had been a skill, a drive, in William that was completely lacking in Putland.

Betsy was the last person to discount the importance of love, but was Mary really in love? John was the first man she had danced with, and Betsy felt he had immediately won her heart by his interest in her father. She knew that in Mary's eyes, Putland could do nothing wrong. And this had been strengthened by his taking part in the same battle, and by his long absences, which made her heart grow fonder.

None of these things would have counted heavily with Betsy, had it not been for the fear of John's health. Now that he was at home, and she had seen him frequently during the winter, she could not help noticing his constant cough and the high colour that often stained his cheeks.

She could never think of Mary without a fear for her future. And what of Harriet? She too was far from well. She was struggling through the early stages of a second pregnancy, and this only twelve months after she had been married. Betsy felt it was too much for her, especially as the first little boy was not very strong. They all loved dearly this little William Bligh Barker, but it seemed hard on Harriet to be pregnant again so soon.

The situation improved however. Bligh, at least, was given employment. For the rest of that year, and well into 1804, his skill as a hydrographer supported him and he was used by the Navy to chart and survey many ports and parts of the English coast line. There were many rumours that Napoleon was planning to launch a huge attack on the English shores,

and more information was needed about uncharted estuaries and ports. For the rest of the family, life moved without more excitement than a holiday at Bath, a few dinner parties and card evenings, and the birth of Harriet's second little boy. There were several eligible young men who called to see Mary, but her heart was set on John Putland, and he was still earning only a meagre living.

During the early months of 1804 the threat from France became greater and the decision was made to mobilise the Great Fleet again. Napoleon had crowned himself Emperor of France. In May Bligh received a new command; the H.M.S. Warrior, one of the finest 74 gun ships in the Navy, and everyone in the family was jubilant at his further promotion.

Then only two nights later came even more exciting news for Mary. She came home early from a small dinner party and rushed into the drawing room without removing her pelisse.

"Lieutenant Putland has a new appointment too," she exclaimed. "He received it today. Mama! Isn't it wonderful? We can be married now!" Mary announced defiantly.

Betsy frowned. "Mary, you are so impetuous. You know how wrong it is of you to burst forth like this in front of the family. We have not agreed to your marriage yet, and you know Lieutenant Putland must come and see Papa first."

"Mama!" Mary replied impatiently. "I know that. Don't be silly. He is coming to see him tomorrow night." Mary danced around the room.

"We think we will be married next week," she informed them all. "John has to leave in a fortnight."

Betsy looked horrified. "I want to talk to you seriously, Mary, right now, and on your own," she said sternly.

"Mama, you sound so gloomy," protested Mary. "You should be happy!" But Betsy was not to be put off. She determinedly hurried the younger girls off to bed and then returned to find Mary drawing sketches of her wedding dress.

"I don't want you to marry Lieutenant Putland like this, so quickly, without thought or planning," Betsy said. "You are too young." Mary crossed her arms and sat down trying to remain calm and reasonable. "You have been saying that for four years. I am twenty now, yet you still say we are marrying too quickly."

"Yes, but he has been away a great deal of that time."

"I think you are most unfair to keep opposing the marriage... many girls have babies at my age."

"But why get married in such a rush now? Only a fortnight!"

"You know why," retorted Mary. "We couldn't get married before, but it is ridiculous to say we are rushing it. We've been waiting and waiting, and now that John is back in the Navy, the time has come."

Betsy looked at her daughter hopelessly. What could she do to prevent her? She knew that everything that Mary was saying was quite logical. It was something deeper that made Betsy fear this marriage.

"Darling, don't take this amiss, but I..." Betsy hesitated. She did not like to express her thoughts so boldly, yet could think of nothing else to say. "I just don't think this is a good match for you. I have been hoping you would change your mind. What about your Mr. Anstruther, who has been so devoted to you? Or the Honourable Mr. Bright? He has very fine estates down in Sussex. Or Mr. Evans?"

Mary stood up. Her eyes were bright, and the colour in her cheeks high. "Mama, you are talking nonsense, and you know it. I love John and that

is the end to it. Would you have me marry without love? Did you marry without love? Was Papa, with his wonderful ability to antagonise every second person he meets, the most eligible young man you met? Tell me honestly, Mama? Didn't you love him in spite of all his faults?"

"Yes Mary, you are right in some ways. But there was always something about your father, some driving force, a strong personality, as you know...", she smile gently, "that made me sure he would be a success." "And did you marry him because you were sure he would be a success, or because you loved him?"

Betsy felt the discussion was turning against her. "I married him because I loved him, Mary. But the drive and the personality were part of the man I loved. I could not have loved a man of lesser character. And sometimes I think John lacks that something in his character."

"I think you are most unfair, Mama," replied Mary hotly. "He fought well in the Battle of the Nile and the Battle of Copenhagen, didn't he? You don't have to be abrupt and fierce like Papa to be strong. Many people can be gentle and strong too."

"There is, I'm afraid, something far more serious I have against John. I did not want to mention it, unless it became necessary." Mary looked at her mother warily. She knew perfectly well what her mother was about to say. "It is Lieutenant Putland's health, Mary dear. That is what I really fear. I do not think he is a well man."

"And would you have me desert a man because he is not well?" she asked angrily as her lips curled scornfully. "I don't for one minute agree that he is as sick as you think. But even if he were, it would make no difference. You have always made so much of it, trying to turn me against him..."

"But Mary," interrupted her mother, "I have never mentioned my fears in that direction."

"You've made little remarks. I've noticed them. You've made them to me... and to him. I've never said anything, have I? But I've noticed. You've asked him how he is and is his cough any better? And has he tried this or that? Do you think I haven't noticed?"

"I'm sorry, my darling."

"If he were a sick man, why would they take him in the Navy? But even if he was ill, desperately ill, I would not let that affect me. Doesn't it mean that he needs me more? Doesn't it make it even more important than that we should be married so that I can look after him?"

"Child, child, you don't understand," Betsy begged as she realised her daughter was every bit like her father and the argument was escalating.

"It is not right that a young girl should assume, for her life, the responsibility of a sick man. You know I believe he is seriously ill, don't you?"

"Yes, Mama! You have not deceived me for a moment. When he coughs or is flushed, you have more than once commented on how he reminds you of Cousin Jane. And we all know that Cousin Jane died of consumption, don't we?"

"And this is only the early stages," interrupted Betsy desperately. "How Jane looked in the early stages... not later on, darling. Not later on. You..."

"If you will let me finish, Mama. I do not believe it, as I have already said, but if it were true, it would not make the slightest difference. Doesn't the marriage ceremony say, 'in sickness and in health'? Could I love him less if he were ill?"

“Darling, you cannot understand. In sickness and in health, yes, that's true. Sickness, if it comes later on, we are all prepared to meet. But to start that way, it is all wrong! Mary, please listen to me!” Betsy continued to beg and plead.

“Married life is full of difficulties, full of obstacles, things to be learned, things to be understood.,” Betsy went on. “You cannot know, but you must believe me. Look at Harriet already. She is happily married, and yet you have heard her troubles. You must believe me, that no matter how happy a marriage is, there are difficulties you would not believe. How can you look for happiness when you start under such a handicap?”

Mary's anger suddenly left her. She knelt beside her mother, and put her head in her lap. She knew every way of winning an argument with her mother.

“Mama darling, I know you believe what you say... but please, give us your blessing. Give us a happy wedding, and help us to arrange it as we want it... next week.” As she spoke, her voice grew lower and lower, and tears began silently to run down her face. “It is not easy, Mama, and if you do not give us your blessing we shall marry anyway.”

Betsy knew she had lost. How many young people, she wondered, had believed that theirs was a love such as no-one else had ever known? The young would never take advice. She knew from experience it was impossible to stop Mary when she set her heart on anything.

And if she opposed this marriage, Mary may elope anyway, and how undignified would that be for the family? She lifted up the tear stained face of her tempestuous daughter, and kissed her on the forehead.

“All right, my darling,” she said softly. “It shall be as you want it.” And

when Bligh returned home that evening he just said one word, 'yes', and disappeared into his study.

Chapter Eleven

One day during the next week Mary was married as she wanted to be, in the small church around the corner and was given away by her father. There was little fuss and few guests. Not that Mary would normally have decided against a large wedding. One side of her nature was proud and slightly arrogant and she loved to be the centre of attention. Allied to her pride, however, was an intense loyalty and although she did not tell anyone, John was not feeling well during those last two weeks. Therefore, without giving the true reason, she insisted she wanted everything as quiet and simple as possible and that was the way the ceremony took place.

All brides look beautiful, thought Betsy, but she had surely never seen one as beautiful as Mary. Her dark hair and bright blue eyes were framed by white lace and in her white satin gown she stood so tiny and yet so proud beside her tall, fair, and undoubtedly good looking groom. The gold and blue of his Navy uniform, one would think, had been specially chosen to match the blue of Mary's eyes. Betsy's heart ached for her daughter and wasted beauty. Dear God, she prayed, make me wrong in what I believe.

After the wedding they went away together for one short week to the country home of a friend of the Blighs, and as honeymoons often are, it contained both delights and disappointments. And on returning to London they learned that Captain Bligh had left to take up his command on the *Warrior*. John Putland had one day of his leave left and he and

Mary found a small, single fronted house not far from Durham Place, which they rented. Mary was determined to set up a home of her own so that if John received any leave they could spend it alone.

Then John also left for his ship. They knew what a battle lay somewhere in the future with the French Fleet for it was still rumoured everywhere that the French were planning a grand invasion of England. Whether William Bligh, or John Putland, would be involved in the battle, there was no way of knowing. There was only the fear and the waiting.

Strangely enough fate had charted a future quite different for them but this lay hidden, so the women could only stay at home and wait for news of the battle.

Letters came from William saying what difficulty all the Captains were having in obtaining a full complement of men. Because of this, the sailing of the Grand Fleet was delayed. It was small wonder, thought Betsy, that they could find men willing to man the ships when they dismissed them so summarily as soon as war was over. She thought of the many crews that had been disbanded only two years earlier.

1804 gave way to 1805, and gradually the ships became ready, waiting to meet the emergency. Lord Nelson, who knew only too well of the danger that threatened, maintained a constant vigilance hoping they would be ready before the French decided to attack. From May 1803, it was said, until August 1805, he set foot out of his flagship only three times, none of which exceeded one hour. And so the preparations went on.

However, when the Grand Fleet was finally called upon Bligh was not destined to sail with it. In March 1805, he suddenly appeared at home. It was quite unexpected because everyone knew that the Navy was standing waiting to fight. The bell at 3 Durham Place rang insistently through the

house and a few moments later William was excitedly entering the drawing room.

“William!” exclaimed Betsy, jumping up from her seat in surprise.

“What is it William?” She could see at once that her husband was more than usually agitated.

“Betsy my dear, I have a most extraordinary offer from Sir Joseph Banks!” he said waving a letter around.

Betsy sat down and opened out the crackling pages and spread them on her lap. How many important things during her life, she wondered, had reached her through letters? She recognised at once the familiar writing of Sir Joseph Banks. What a kind friend he had always been.

“My Dear Sir,

“An opportunity has occurred this day which seems to me to lay open an opportunity of being of service to you; and as I hope I never omit any changes of being useful to a friend whom I esteem, as I do you, I lose not a minute in apprising you of it.”

Yes, it was true, thought Betsy. Sir Joseph had never failed them.

Through all William's ups and downs he had been a staunch supporter. He had given him his first great chance, and had always recommended his promotion. What was he bringing to them now?

“I have always, since the first institution of the new colony at New South Wales, taken a deep interest in its success and have been constantly consulted by His Majesty's Ministers, through all the changes there have been in the department which directs it, relative to the more important concerns of the colonists.”

New South Wales, thought Betsy! That far off penal settlement on the continent of New Holland! What could that have to do with them? She

hurried on.

“At present, King, the Governor, is tired of his station; and well he may be so. He has carried into a reform of great extent, which militated much with the interest of the soldiers and settlers there. He is, consequently, disliked and much opposed, and has asked leave to return.

“In conversation, I was this day asked if I knew a man proper to be sent out in his place, one who has integrity, a mind capable of providing its own resources in difficult times without leaning on others for advice, firm in discipline, civil in deportment and not subject to whimper and whine when severity of discipline is wanted to meet emergencies. I immediately answered. As this man must be chosen from among the best captains I know of no-one but Captain Bligh who will suit, but whether it will meet his views is another question.”

So that was it! A storm of emotion passed through Betsy's heart. There was love and pride at how Sir Joseph Banks described William. He was surely one of the few people who truly appreciated and understood her husband. There was pride also that he should be chosen for this new position.

Then came dismay, complete and utter dismay. Nothing she had ever imagined, nothing, except William's death or injury, which always haunted her thoughts, could so completely bring to an end her dreams and hopes that their turbulent life together would be allowed to run its final course in peace and quiet.

She remembered the letter she had received from him during the second breadfruit voyage, when he had said he would never undertake another long sea voyage. And now this! And far, far worse than any voyage. It took eight months merely to get to New South Wales and how long

would a Governor stay there? Many, many years, she felt sure.

She could trust herself to say nothing to William. She could not even raise her eyes. She knew how excited he had been when he arrived. She could sense his impatience now. But what could she say? To give herself time to think, she read on.

“I can, therefore, if you choose it, place you in the government of the new colony with an income of 2,000 pounds a year and with the whole of the Government power and stores at your disposal. In truth King, who is now there, receives only 1,000 pounds and yet lives like a prince. I would only recommend anyone unless 2,000 pounds was given as I think that a man who undertakes so great a trust as the management of an important colony should be certain of living well and laying up a provision for his family.

“I apprehend you are about fifty-five years old and if so, you have by my calculations an expectation of 15 years' life, and in a climate like that, which is the best that I know, a still better expectation. So in 15 years at 1,000 pounds a year and at a compound interest of 5 per cent, will have produced more than 30,000 pounds. And in case you should not like to spend your life there, you will have a fair claim on your return to a pension of 1,000 pounds a year.”

Betsy's dismay deepened. She could see immediately what a wonderfully good offer it was. Even better than Sir Joseph calculated, for William was only fifty-one years old. No wonder William was excited about it. It meant wealth and position beyond anything they had ever dreamed. This, she knew, meant more to William than to her. She had known life in wealthy, cultured circles all her girlhood, but William had never possessed anything other than his own hard earned pay. What could she

say to him? How could she deny him this? Still she could not find words, so she returned again to the letter.

“Besides, if your family goes out with you, as I conclude they would, your daughters will have a better chance of marrying suitably there than they can have here for as the colony grows richer every year, and trade seems to improve, I can have no doubt that in a few years there will be men capable of supporting wives in a creditable manner and very desirous of taking them from a respectable and good family.

“Tell me, my dear Sir, when you have consulted your pillow, what you think of this. To me, I confess, it appears a promising place for a man who has entered late into the status of a post-captain, and the more so as your rank will go on, for Phillip, the first Governor, is now an admiral, holding a pension for his services in the country.”

That was the end. She slowly folded the pages over and raised her eyes to William, trying to smile. The pain that sometimes troubled her, shot through her at just that moment, as though warning her of the impossibility of the proposition.

“What do you think, Betsy?” he burst out immediately. “Governor of New South Wales!”

“You like this idea, William?” she asked faintly.

“It would be something, wouldn't it my dear? A Governor! And the salary, you must admit it's magnificent! Double what the other governors have been getting. And my rank to go on, Betsy. What do you think?”

He must have suddenly become aware of Betsy's silence. He sat down opposite her and gently took her hand. “But it all depends on you, my dear. I have already written to Sir Joseph that I can decide nothing without consulting you.”

She replied slowly, and so quietly that he could scarcely catch the words. "I am sorry William, but I could not come with you. I could not possibly come with you. You do realise that, don't you...? My health... I try not to worry about it... but I could not make that voyage."

"Are you quite certain dear...? I told Sir Joseph that I was doubtful. I explained about your health, but I thought... perhaps..." His usually sure voice trailed away.

"You know how sea sick I get, William, even if I'm on board one of your ships for one hour. I simply could not face a long sea journey. And it is not only that..." Again she spoke very quietly. "I think it would be the end of me." Suddenly she exclaimed more firmly. "William, my dear, we are too old for this. Why, we're grandparents! It is too much for us to take on. Too much for me, anyway. After all these years, I could never start travelling."

Bligh rose slowly to his feet. "No, my dear," he said thoughtfully, "I can see that now. It would indeed be too much for you. I had thought of it, of course, and warned Sir Joseph, but I wanted to make quite sure." It was impossible for him to hide his disappointment.

"William," she said slowly, "would you like to go by yourself?"

He turned around and faced her. "I don't really know, Betsy. To be honest, I have thought of that too. You see, my dear," and he became animated again, "there's a job to be done here. You can see that, can't you? These army men and traders have got control in New South Wales. I've heard about it before. Various people have spoken of it, and I have heard Sir Joseph on the subject. They're running the colony for their own good and the small man's being ruined. They need a strong man to put an end to it all. It's the challenge, Betsy... a challenge... and I

think I'm the man for it."

Betsy bowed her head. "How long do you think you would be away?" she asked, her voice almost failing her. She could no longer hide from herself what the future held. She had known William too long not to be able to read his thoughts and feelings.

"I don't know, my dear. I just don't know. Five years at the most I should say. But it could be possible to do it in three years... what do you think?"

Betsy knew what he wanted her to say. Quite apart from her own feelings, there was something else. Was it the best thing? Should he go alone to New South Wales? It was different from being in command on a ship. There was society in the colony and he needed someone by his side. Did he realise how lonely it could be? And the horrible rumours of what really happens there.

"Have you thought you may be lonely there, William? Especially if you will be fighting the interests of the wealthy colonists. It will be very different from being on board a boat. You will be alone in Government House. There will be entertaining. I think the position perhaps calls for a Governor and his wife."

"I could manage on my own, Betsy... And there are all sorts of things we must find out before we make a decision anyway. If you stay here, the savings will not be as great as Sir Joseph sets out. We shall be maintaining two households. I want you to go and see him, Betsy, and find out everything from him in person. Will you do that my dear? If you feel it is too great a parting for you, we'll forget about it."

"But you do want to go, don't you?" asked Betsy insistently.

"Yes, I do." He replied. "It's the biggest opportunity I have ever been offered...."

Leaving behind the wreckage of peaceful thought and hopes, William Bligh hurried back to his ship, and Betsy found herself facing the most difficult decision of her life. Who could say the separation would be for only five years? Who could tell what would happen once William arrived in New South Wales? It may be years and years before she saw him again.

Yet, she mused, what was the use of keeping a man at home against his wishes? She sighed. All her life she had adapted herself to his comings and goings. Only one doubt remained. Could William really manage this new task on his own? Was it fair to let him go? Should she make a pretext of her own health and unhappiness to keep him at home?

A position such as Governor needed a lady. She felt sure that the last two Governors had taken their wives with them. She had heard of Mrs. King and had read in a newspaper somewhere of the first orphanage for girls she had been responsible for starting in the new colony. No, thought Betsy, she was not at all happy at the idea of William going on his own. At just that moment there was the sound of the bell followed by a great bustle in the hall. 'The girls!' thought Betsy, and they were suddenly filling the room. At times she found it hard to realise that this grown up family could possibly be her children. The youngest was now fourteen, and altogether they were rather overwhelming. They had been to look at some recently imported laces and muslin's that Aunt Hallett had seen at Mr. Wisdom's.

"I have come to have tea with you, Mama," she heard Mary saying. "I do hope it's... Mama, you look quite faint..."

"Yes, yes, Mary," Betsy replied quickly. "I have just had some rather startling news... your father has been invited to be Governor of New

South Wales!" She looked long and hard into Mary's eyes. "Here, my fair lady, read these to the girls..." as she handed Mary the two letters. "One is from Sir Joseph Banks to Papa and the other is Papa's reply. And then, when you have finished, we must decide what is to be done. For Papa, believe it or not," and here she smiled a little, "has left it to me to decide."

Mary began to read the two letters quickly. There were interruptions and astonishment and through it all Betsy lay back in her chair with her eyes closed letting the tide of conversation flow over her.

When the letters were finished Betsy insisted that tea be ordered and poured. Then once again she sat back to let the torrent of what the five girls had to say flow uninterrupted. As far as she could gather, the idea of going on an eight month cramped sea journey to a convict settlement had little appeal to them all.

"My god," Harriet said bluntly, "isn't that place just a prisoner hulk the size of a continent? And Sir Joseph says my sisters will meet and marry worthy men... but they're all convicts... they walk around in chains and get flogged."

Life in London was just beginning to be very exciting for the girls. They were making new friends, their life was filled with social activities, holidays to the Betham family on the Isle of Man, to Bath, where Mama went for her health, weekends at the country homes of friends, visits to the home of Lord Darnley, even occasional visits to Bushy Park, where the Duke of Clarence lived with Mrs. Jordon and their growing family. The girls had no wish to leave all this behind. Questions were asked and answered, but the more they heard, the more the girls seemed to prefer to stay in London, except it seemed for Mary. Her face was more

thoughtful, her eyes fixed on her mother, and there was a slight pucker on her forehead. She had the air of waiting and thinking. When she saw her mother looking at her, she suddenly smiled.

“Mama,” she said quietly. “I am wondering if I have understood it rightly. You feel Papa wants to go, and you are willing to agree to that, but you doubt if he should go alone?”

“Yes, Mary, that's right. I know for certain that I could not face the voyage.”

“Then Mama,” replied Mary with determination, but still maintaining an outward calm, “I have the solution.”

“What is that, Mary?”

“John and I shall go with him!” The room became suddenly silent.

“Yes,” continued Mary before anyone could speak. “We shall go. Papa will get John appointed to one of the ships out there. They must have ships, surely. Or he can go as Aide-de-camp... or something, whatever. And I shall go as the Governor's Lady!”

With the last few words she could no longer contain her excitement. Her eyes grew bright, and her old proud look returned. The sight of it made Betsy's heart ache, for it made her realise that it had been lacking of late.

“All my life,” Mary continued, “I have dreamed of the time when I could go with Papa to sea. When I was only eight, and we saw him sail away to get the breadfruit again... do you remember, Mama, down at Portsmouth? Even then, I longed to go with him. Always I wanted to go to share his adventures instead of being left at home. And now I can. And what is more, he needs me! Oh Mama,” she said impetuously as the stream of words continued. “Don't you think it is a wonderful idea?”

Don't you think it will please Papa? And won't Sir Joseph agree? You will go and see him, won't you, and say that Papa wants to accept this offer and that John and I will go with him? You will, won't you, Mama?" The other girls sat in stunned silence as they stared at Mary. What was this they had just heard? It seemed that fate had made its move thought Betsy. The one obstacle was now removed. Just as she had done so many times before she would stay at home and carry on with the family. William would sail away to attempt another difficult assignment and Mary would go to be his companion.

Late that night when Mary had returned to her lonely home and the girls had gone to bed, Betsy took up her quill and started to write to Sir Joseph. She hesitated, wondering how best to express herself. She was tired and sad.

"Captain Bligh makes me think he is inclined to accept your offer your generous friendship has made him to be Governor of New South Wales. "His affection for his family made him wish we could have accompanied him, but as he knows that with respect to my unfortunate self, this is impossible, and how to divide us is also impossible, he seems determined to undertake this voyage as he did all his others with the hope of return..."

Should she mention here the idea of Mary and John going with him? No she thought. It will be better to wait until she could see him and then she would explain fully her fears about William being alone and suggest that someone in the family be with him.

"He tells me he has enclosed a letter to you to be presented to the Admiralty if you think a temporary absence from his ship can be granted for him to settle his plan with you. If he gives up his ship I fear it will not

be easy to get him another.

“He is anxious to know many things but the distance he is from you makes it impossible for him to get informed. May I, dear Sir, beg the honour of seeing you as soon as it is convenient to you? If you indulge me with that favour I shall be able to give him some information on certain points which he is anxious about.

I am dear sir with sincere regards,
Elizabeth Bligh.”

So the wheels were set in motion that were to take Mary to the other side of the world and to make her a participant in events that far exceeded in excitement or the need for courage anything about which she had dreamed.

Chapter Twelve

"Any news yet, Mama?" Mary asked anxiously.

"No, my darling. None at all. It is really most vexing. Letters, visits, talks, letters and more letters, but still the Admiralty refuses to make up its mind on the appointment."

"It is so unsettling," replied Mary angrily. "There is so much to do and yet no point in starting until we are certain."

"How is John?"

"He writes he is in bed again," Mary sighed. "But I am sure he always gets up too soon. Oh Mama, it would be so good for him I feel sure. The climate in New South Wales is said to be so warm."

Since the fateful night when the Blighs had decided that Papa would accept the offer made through Sir Joseph Banks, Mary had become a constant visitor to the house to help her mother with what appeared to be endless negotiations over the details of the appointment. In reply to Betsy's letter, Sir Joseph had quickly made an appointment and he had immediately been able to answer many queries.

It would be necessary to take beds, linen, plates and all tableware, but the heavy furniture, such as tables and chairs would be found at Government House already. Servants would be provided in a reasonable number from among the better convicts and Bligh would be allowed to take with him a secretary of his own choosing. A salary of 1,000 pounds would

commence as soon as he left the *Warrior*, but the salary of 2,000 pounds would not commence until he reached the Colony.

Other matters were not so easily solved and on two matters the Admiralty was slow to decide. One was whether William could carry on his appointment as Captain and be given command of one of the ships at the Colony. The other was whether Lieutenant Putland could go with him as his Lieutenant.

The second, of course, was Mary's greatest concern and resulted in her calling to see her mother almost daily. During this time it was impossible not to confide that John's health had indeed deteriorated. He was still on active service, and no-one knew he suffered from more than a bad cough, but Mary had to admit it was worse. She would never forget the first time she had seen the tell-tale bloodstains on his handkerchief.

The year moved slowly on. While the rest of England stood waiting and wondering when the French would launch their threatened invasion. William on the *Warrior*, and Mary at home, were both waiting and chafing at the enforced idleness caused by the slowness of the Admiralty's decision. Decisive in their characters both of them were anxious.

"If only they would make up their minds," she said angrily. "Papa at least knows he's going. But for us, there is only doubt and more doubt."

"We must be very patient, darling, and it is not easy for poor Papa either. I think he is nearly going mad on his ship. All the rest of the Navy is getting ready to fight the French, while he feels he is neither one thing nor the other. He is torn in two," Betsy replied shaking her head.

"Does he think there will be a big battle?"

"He is certain of it. He says Lord Nelson never leaves his ship."

“Oh Mama, I hope orders come through before the battle. If Papa is to govern New South Wales, I just wish they would let him get on with it.”

“It is not going to be easy, Mary,” replied her mother gravely. “I had another talk with Sir Joseph yesterday and he told me things about the Colony that are hard to believe. I fear all the leading citizens will be opposing Papa. Do you know that a few of the Army officers and leading traders hold a monopoly there and they make those poor settlers take rum as payment for their produce?”

“Surely he must be exaggerating.”

“He doesn't seem to think so, dear. And if he were, why on earth would they be going to all this bother to send out Papa just when he is needed in the Navy?”

“Well I'm sure Papa won't be stopped by such things,” replied Mary bluntly. “Oh Mama, if only I knew for certain that I was going. It's months since we first heard about this thing. I can't bare the delay.”

“I think perhaps I'll write to Papa and suggest he gets Lord Darnley to write to Lord Camden about it. It may help hurry things along....”

“Mama, that's a wonderful idea,” exclaimed Mary. “Here, I'll get your quill and paper and you can do it immediately.” Mary was desperate and Betsy was made to sit down and write immediately to William of this latest idea and one more step was taken towards gaining some finality in the arrangements.

Whether or not it would make any difference to the decision will never be known but Lord Darnley did write to Lord Camden. At last on one cool day at the very end of September, Bligh still aboard the *Warrior*, received a letter from Lord Camden. It said that both his final requests had been acceded. By the same mail came a letter from Betsy saying that

everything else was finalised.

Bligh hurried down to his cabin and immediately wrote a letter to his friend Sir Joseph Banks. He felt he could not wait a minute to express the thanks for the many kindnesses he had done for him and his family.

“My Dear Sir,

“I have now received a letter from Mrs. Bligh and have just a moment to say that I feel the highest regard for you and your great and kind attention. I know that you will do all that can be done for me and in return you will ever find me gratified and you can have every confidence in me.

“She says the whole is taken out of control of the Admiralty, which is certainly wise and proper, and much more agreeable to me. Acting independently of the Admiralty will insure me success, and I shall with the greatest pleasure comply with whatever regulation you may have in your power to make for the advantage of the settlement which no doubt will thrive under a steady and just government administrated with due spirit...”

There was one other matter Bligh wanted to mention. Was this the right place he wondered. He did not want to appear too demanding. And yet the authorities seemed anxious for him to go, so perhaps it would be a mistake to allow the opportunity to pass.

“I would have asked,” he continued, “to have had my son-in-law made a Captain, but that is not to embarrass you my dear Sir who, as Mrs. Bligh says, we have always regarded as our good and kind friend. I cannot express how much I feel your attention in giving up so much of your time to her in explaining circumstances for which she and my little girls are so thankful. They seem reconciled as much as I can expect to my

leaving them, and I really believe Mrs. Bligh would not live one week on board of ship.

“I have now only to say, my dear Sir, that with a strong recollection of your friendship, I do with a most affectionate mind, undertake your kind and generous offer under a confidence of giving you great satisfaction and that I shall live to see you happy in the event.

Ever faithfully yours.”

He signed his name and wearily put down his quill. Now it was time to go home and perhaps they could leave for New South Wales by Christmas. But first Bligh sat back and closed his eyes and made plans. He would have to take special care in fitting the ship on which they would travel. He must have a large airy cabin built on deck for Mary. He had always been happy to sleep in a cabin below but he would spare no trouble to make the tedious voyage as pleasant as possible for her. What a blessing it was for her to come with him he thought.

Before the final departure for the other side of the world was made fate directed one more cruel blow. No sooner was William home, and the family rejoicing because Mary and John could go with him, than news came from Harriet. Her eldest son, the dear little William Bligh Barker had died. Scarcely had they absorbed this personal sorrow, than it was followed by a national one.

The small schooner Pickle battled its way home from the battle torn, storm buffeted navy, and Lieutenant Lapenotiere, landing at Falmouth, made nineteen changes of horses between Falmouth and London, until he finally reached the Admiralty at one o'clock in the morning and, sea and road weary, strode into the candle lit room.

“Sir,” he cried, “we have gained a great victory, but we have lost Lord

Nelson!”

The most famous of all sea battles, The Battle of Trafalgar, had been won eliminating the French and Spanish naval fleets and the English supremacy of the sea established. But the English people were heartbroken. They cared less for the victory than for Lord Nelson. To everyone it was a personal sorrow. How fickle is human nature, however, for all the adoration they heaped on their hero they cared little for his last wish.

“I leave Emma Lady Hamilton a legacy to my King and Country that they will give her provisions to maintain her rank in life. I also leave to the beneficence of my country my adopted daughter Horatio Nelson Thompson.”

The nation heaped great honours and wealth on Nelson's brother and family, but cared nothing for the divine Emma. Perhaps, had the little people been given a say in place of starched authority, Emma too would have received her share.

Under the shadow of the national and private mourning the Bligh family continued to make preparations for their departure. It was decided they would travel on the Lady Madeleine Sinclair, a transport taking goods and other passengers to New South Wales.

What a complicated undertaking it was to travel to the other side of the world in 1805. Mary insisted that her piano and lute must be included. Also a suitable maid had to be found for her and Eleanor Piper was chosen, among many applicants, a common sense stocky woman in her early thirties. And Bligh required a Secretary to go with him so a young man was chosen called Edward Griffin.

Then there were preserves and jams and other foodstuffs to be made

and packed if passengers wanted to eat well on the long journey. Hens were taken in crates, cows and a calf, and sheep and pigs, all for fresh food on board.

Chapter Thirteen

Mary Putland and her abrupt, determined, uncompromising father were to become part of an extraordinary beginning to a great country. Most new continents are pioneered by the adventurous, the brave or the non-conformist; those looking for freedom. Not Australia. Her first settlers were the weak, the sinning, the unwanted, the unskilled, the dregs of gaols and prison hulks, people condemned in their own country and sent thousands of miles away with the fervent hope that they would never be seen again.

Fortunately, many of these outcasts were more sinned against than sinning. They had committed small crimes in an unjust community that made an honest existence difficult and many thrived in the new environment. Also there were the political prisoners from England and Ireland, men of broad views and liberal outlook, only too ready to disseminate these same views in a new country.

As many as two hundred crimes of a various nature were punishable by exportation and English gaols were crammed to overflowing. The prisoners lived in unbelievable squalor, the murderer sleeping next to the poacher, the political prisoner next to the man who stole to feed his children. They were condemned but there was nowhere to send them. The American colonies had freed themselves from British rule so Britain had find somewhere else to send its convicts.

The large, practically empty, southern continent of New Holland was suggested. It was far enough away to be ideal. There was little public

conscience. No-one bothered about the souls or the families of the prisoners who even if given a seven year sentence would never return. The decision was made and in 1788 Governor Phillip was sent from England with eleven ships, 717 convicts, soldiers, marines, army officers and a few hardy wives and children. With these people Phillip was expected to make a settlement in an unexplored, unknown continent. It was a badly planned and poorly equipped expedition, sent away hurriedly with little thought for what was really needed to pioneer a country. It had no hope of relief from any outside source, and it found itself in a huge, hostile continent, occupied by the most primitive of human peoples, in the eyes of the English, and stocked by remnants of the most ancient species of animal life.

Its hostility was not obvious. Its dangers lay in its complete indifference. A harbour that lured the weary shiploads of people to its shores by sheer beauty and one small stream proved to be hemmed in by huge blue mountains. Furthermore, the land surrounding it was poor in yielding good crops.

For years, these early settlers were dependent on supplies from home, and when the half-starved inhabitants ran down the beach to greet the Second Fleet they discovered to their dismay that it carried hardly any more stores but many more convicts; sick, starved and staggering from an appalling voyage.

Yet out of this struggling, wretched collection of human beings and poor dwellings, Governor Phillip gradually brought order from chaos. Better land was found on the Parramatta and Hawkesbury rivers. The best of the convicts were given grants and started farms for themselves. After four years, when ill-health forced Phillip to return home, he left the

colony almost able to keep itself in the necessities of life.

Some of this William Bligh already knew. Some of it Sir Joseph told him. Some of it neither of them realised. They were far too close to the events to be aware of their significance. Their involvement lay with the present.

"It's what has happened since Phillip left that concerns us, Bligh," explained Sir Joseph, during the first of many talks they had together. "It's a major tragedy. Phillip was a fine man, the best we could have chosen. He had a great struggle but laid down many important rules. And these rules he followed implicitly. No grants of land to Army officers, land in the centre of the town to be leased only, convicts to work first for the Government, and so on..."

"And I take it," asked Bligh, "that these rules were not kept up, Joseph?" "No, William. That accursed illness of his made him leave before the new Governor, John Hunter, arrived. And the military ruled the place for two wretched years."

"In their own interests, I gather."

"Exactly. The marines that went with Phillip had already been replaced by the New South Wales Corps, and I'm afraid they were a poor type of man. The best soldiers were too busy fighting in Europe to be interested. After Phillip left you wouldn't believe the villainy that passed for administration. Large grants of land to all the officers, some of it right in the centre of town, the pick of the convict labour to work their properties, and at no charge, of course. You'd be amazed at the officers who openly live with convict women. And the illegitimate children, Bligh! But the worst of all are the monopolies."

"Yes, I've gathered something about them. The rum monopoly is the

worst, I believe.”

“It's ruining the country, William, and above all, the small settler... he's given a few gallons of rum for a year's harvest. They say there's more rum and wine consumed in New South Wales than anywhere else in the world.”

Sir Joseph continued to give many examples of how leading citizens deprived the small man of true payment for his work or produce, and then when destitute, bought up his land for practically nothing. “And the worst of the lot, Bligh, is a man named John Macarthur.”

Did the first mention of that name sound a warning note in William Bligh's mind? Probably not. He was too busy absorbing all the new information that it is unlikely one particular man held any significance for him. “By grants, by monopoly, by devious means, this man Macarthur has acquired so much land that I believe he's the wealthiest person out there and I fear the most unscrupulous.”

“But what I can't understand, Sir Joseph,” asked Bligh, “is why the two Governors who took over after the military rule haven't done something about these injustices.”

“That's the whole point, Bligh,” replied Sir Joseph excitedly. “They've let themselves be brushed aside by these people who are entrenched very nicely indeed... that's why we thought of you, William. A strong man is needed down there... someone who won't be put off with pretty speeches, insults, intrigues...”

“Tell me more about this Macarthur man...” Bligh asked.

“I've met him at Kew. He's an attractive man, a real spellbinder. He was back here after bigger land grants and more sheep. He seems to think there's a great future for it out there. He was a young Scottish Lieutenant

originally, Governor Grose appointed him Regimental Paymaster and Inspector of Public Works... posts that gave him leverage by controlling the supply of labour..." Banks stubbed out his cigar and looked at Bligh. "Well he used the labour for himself."

At another briefing Arthur Phillip was present. He had retired to Bath, but was happy to help out Banks in preparing Bligh for what he could expect in his new position. Phillip was a small, frail-looking man, and Bligh marveled at how he had found the strength to combat the difficulties of the first settlement.

"Yes," agreed Phillip, "I must say he was a nuisance even then. I remember he was involved in two duels on the way out and I seem to remember he insisted on changing ships too... He didn't come with the First Fleet, of course, but as a Lieutenant, I think, on the Second Fleet, as a member of the New South Wales Corps. You remember, they came out then to replace the Marines I had."

"Yes, yes," replied Sir Joseph, "I've told Bligh about the New South Wales Corps."

"Anyway," continued Phillip, "I heard about the quarrelling on the way out, and I must say that as soon as he arrived he started complaining and making trouble. His wife though was by far the most attractive women in the Colony and very smart too..."

"It's a pity she couldn't keep him in hand then," replied Sir Joseph. "As far as I can tell he's a born troublemaker. After Phillip here left, the Corps let Macarthur do whatever he liked, and by the time the poor Governor Hunter arrived Macarthur was practically running the place and he and his cronies made Hunter's life a hell. They insulted him. They sent a flow of letters home criticising everything Hunter did. That's

what you're up against, Bligh."

"Well these type of people know how to use the system.... just look what they said about me and the mutiny. Anybody would have thought I caused it! It won't worry me, Joseph."

"I'm glad to hear it. I think you need to know what you're up against, all the same," Banks confided. And at another briefing, Banks had written evidence of the trouble Macarthur was causing from one of Governor Hunter's official despatches from New South Wales. "There you are, Bligh, see for yourself what your predecessors have to say about Macarthur. You don't want to take the matter too lightly, you know. I had a clerk copy them out for me."

"There is not a person," Bligh read, "whose opinions I hold in greater contempt than I do this busybody's because I have observed that under the most plausible of them has always been a self-interested motive."

Bligh looked rather impatiently at the long extract and glanced through it. He had quite gathered the point Sir Joseph was trying to make.

"I need not inform you who or what Captain Macarthur is. He came here in 1790 more than 500 pounds in debt, and is now worth at least 20,000 pounds. His employment during the eleven years he has been here has been that of making a large fortune, helping his brother officers to make small ones, mostly at the public expense, and sowing discord and strife... cunning, impudence and a pair of basilisk eyes... persecution and opposition became Macarthur's system... many instances of his diabolical spirit had shown itself before Governor Phillip left this colony, and since then he has been the master worker of puppets he has set in motion. So sensibly wounded were Governor Hunter's feelings previous to his leaving the colony that he was obliged to call this

perturbator to a private account, which he declined...”

“There's a lot more of it, Bligh. I just had a few extracts copied. King actually sent Macarthur home to have him tried for the trouble he had caused.”

“Is that a fact? I didn't know that. What happened?”

“Such was this wretched man's scheming that the evidence against him disappeared on the way home... believe it or not, when it reached London the dispatch box was empty.”

“It's incredible,” exclaimed Bligh.

“But what's more incredible, continued Banks, “is that in spite of all that had been said against him, he wormed his way into a friendship with someone at the Colonial office. And he returned to Sydney, not in disgrace, but with a further grant of 5,000 acres for his sheep breeding experiments! I was furious about it, damned if I wasn't. I wrote a report to the Colonial office myself about what had been done, and what I thought of it.”

Yet this same Colonial office, which handed out the 5,000 acres to Macarthur and supported its Governors so poorly was now sending Captain Bligh. His iron will was a by-word in England and he was expected to succeed where Hunter and King had failed. And they were giving him implicit instructions to stop the rum trading.

“The biggest problem is the distance, William, as you know...” Sir Joseph confided.

“Yes... eight or so months for a letter to reach you, then eight months for a reply...” Bligh replied knowingly. “The tyranny of distance.”

“Anyway, William, I've arranged a good salary for you...” Banks said smiling.



Sir Joseph Banks in 1812 as president of the Royal Society and wearing the insignia of the Order of the Bath.

“It’s very generous,” replied Bligh.

“Betsy and the girls will be well looked after.”

“Mind you, the Colony is a pond of floating currencies and barter, you know... guineas, johannas, guilders, mohurs, rupees, Spanish dollars and ducats, all left by visiting ships...

IOUs are probably never trusted...

but the main one is rum. Real

Jamaican rum I hear lands at the

Colony at 6 shillings a gallon and

reaches the small settlers and convicts

at two to four pounds... cheap Bengali rum is the most profitable...”

Banks explained.

“You sound more like a banker than a botanist, Joseph,” Bligh replied.

“Well good luck William.” Sir Joseph Banks said as he made his final farewell. “If you can bring eighteen men nearly four thousand miles in a small twenty-three foot launch, you can do anything, I guess... At any rate, you’ve got about 8,000 people down there to run and a quarter of those are children, mostly orphans...”

The following day Bligh moved his family to Portsmouth and took up lodgings until the ships were ready to leave, which took some time. It was a strange feeling for Mary. After years of wanting to go to sea, finally that moment had arrived.

“Your cabin is like a palace!” Betsy said to Mary as she surveyed her

daughter's living quarters for the next eight or so months.

“Well only the best for the First Lady!” Bligh announced proudly. The girls crowded into it and inspected every part of it, especially the piano. They only rarely had the opportunity to actually board a ship, but this time William wanted Betsy to see firsthand where her daughter would be.

“Yes, it's perfect...” Mary replied, but then her eyes wandered over to the other ship. “If only John was on our ship and not on the other one with that terrible Captain Short...”

“I know my dear,” Bligh lamented. “But there will be plenty of times he will visit you on the journey. This is a convoy and we're all together.”

When the time came for the ships to set sail and when, in spite of numerous delays and contrary winds, and with their numerous belongings safely stowed on board, the ship finally sailed away from the shores of England, Betsy and the girls waved from the wharf and they all cried.

As for Mary Putland, still only on the threshold of life, her future was indissolveably bound to her father and husband. There was no turning back now and the moment she could see her mother and sisters crying in the distance made the start of the voyage all the more emotional.

Chapter Fourteen

After just four weeks the excitement and novelty of adventure on the high seas had well and truly worn off. It was terrible.

"Here's your linen, Ma'am."

"Oh thank you Eleanor. Put it away in the drawers for me, will you please?"

"Yes, Ma'am. Are you feeling better?"

"Oh..." replied Mary. She was sitting at her desk with the doors and windows of her cabin wide open to catch the warm breezes blowing in from the sea. "Yes, yes, yes! This perfect weather makes everything worthwhile. Don't you think so, Eleanor?"

"Well I don't know, Ma'am," replied Eleanor doubtfully. "If I'd known what it was going to be like, I doubt if I'd ever have come with you. And that's the truth. Still, I suppose it's better than staying at home."

Mary laughed. "Of course it is. Why Eleanor, you'd have lived out your life in that drab, little, cold, horrible house, looking after your father. And now he's happily living with your sister, and you're seeing the world!" Eleanor looked out the cabin window at the vast ocean.

"It's not much of it we've seen so far, Ma'am..."

This time Mary sighed. "Yes, only the sea. I must say it's very different from what I imagined. I'd always thought the sea would be a great adventure. Instead it's this dreadful monotony."

It was now Eleanor's turn to look on the better side. "Don't forget you've been sick, Ma'am. I'm sure things will be better when you're properly on

your feet. And if you could see more of Lieutenant Putland, I'm sure it would cheer you up."

Mary's face clouded. "I'll never forgive Captain Short, I hate him," she replied angrily. "He could have so easily allowed John over here more often. He's deliberately keeping him away from us."

"It's a shame, Ma'am..." Eleanor replied as she straightened herself from closing the bottom drawer of Mary's chest and glanced towards her mistress. "Well that's the lot, Ma'am," she said. "Is there anything else you need?"

"No, Eleanor. I'm going to start a letter to my sisters."

"But they say we won't be nearing St. Helena for weeks."

"I know. But there is always a chance of passing a ship going home. I was furious at missing the last one." She frowned. "It was really most thoughtless of Papa not to warn me it could happen. He had a letter all ready to send to Mama, did you know?"

"I don't think he wanted to worry you about writing when you were so sick, Ma'am. After all, he would have put all the news in his letter. There was no need for you to write."

"Perhaps you are right, Eleanor, but the girls would be expecting to hear from me. Anyway, if it happens again, I'm going to be prepared."

"If there's nothing else you want, Ma'am, I think I'll sit in the sun for a while."

"All right, Eleanor."

Mary picked up her quill and frowned. They had been gone a month and yet this was her first letter. There was so much to say but it was

difficult to know where to start or what to put in and what to leave out.

First, she must explain why she did not write by the ship on which Papa had sent home a letter to Mama. Her sisters must have wondered. They were so used to receiving letters from Papa from all parts of the world, but this was her first great venture, and she knew how anxiously they would be waiting to hear how she had fared. There had been such fears and tears, such exhortations, when she left. She felt they would never see her again.

“Lady Sinclair,

February 26, 1806.

“My dear Sisters, Harriet, Betsy, Fanny, Jane and Anne,

“I have been so disappointed and vexed at missing the opportunity of writing to you by Sir Richard Strachan, that I shall from this time always be prepared to meet with a conveyance for my letters. As Papa is Mama's correspondent, we have agreed that I shall become yours. Within these few days, I have been totally incapable of such an office, from the most severe sea-sickness that you can imagine But this delightful climate will I trust in a short time restore me. That Mama and all of you my dear Sisters are perfectly well is our most fervent prayer. We reckon, that you my dear Harriet, have by this time got over your confinement. What happiness it will give us to hear of your recovery and it is almost unnecessary to add as well as that of Mr. Barker and the welfare of all the family. Tell Henry, that we often talk of him, and that he is amongst our constant toasts.

“Putland is still on board the Porpoise, and his absence fell heavily on my father during my illness. Eleanor was also very sick so he was my only

attendant. We have been very unfortunate in our cook, he is without exception, the worst I have ever met, and appears a very ill-disposed man. This gave Papa a great deal of trouble in making my Barley Water, Sago, etc., with Messrs. Griffen and Johns for assistance, on my cabin fire. Indeed I could not sometimes help laughing in the midst of my sickness, to see them literally tumbling over each other. I suppose you are at present all happy to sit around your fire at home, whilst I am sitting with all the doors and windows open about me, although the heat is not so great...”

Mary put down her pen to rest for a moment and gazed around her. Yes, she thought, how wonderfully good Papa had been to her. There had been his tremendous care in fitting up their ship, the *Lady Madeleine Sinclair*, which was only a transport vessel, so that she had this large, airy room on deck and was surrounded by her own furniture and piano that she was taking out to the colony.

And how kind he had been when she had been ill. Sixteen dreadful days, when she could barely raise her head from the pillow and he had waited on her hand and foot. And what a blessing young Mr. Griffin had been, her father's secretary, a young man already devoted to him. Like so many people who came in close association with her father he was able to look beyond his bursts of irritability and temper to see his kindness and efficiency that lay below.

Yet, for all the kindness and attention, Mary wondered about the dreadful delays at the start. They had sailed before Christmas, but had been driven back again and again by contrary winds, until it was January 28, 1806, before they finally left England.

How hateful the waiting on board had been, with only brief and unsatisfactory visits to shore. And how horrible it was to see the prison hulks where hundreds of wretched people were kept imprisoned in utter degradation. And to see a man flogged from ship to ship for some trivial misdemeanour. Surely nothing he did could deserve that. And to see the horrid drunken women, ugly and painted, who freely went on and off ships to keep the sailors happy. Mary felt she had learnt more about wickedness and degradation in those weeks of waiting than she would have known in a lifetime.

And then, still before the journey had commenced, there had been the undignified squabbles with Captain Short of the *H.M.S. Porpoise*, the small navy ship that was to lead the convoy.

Drunk, disorderly, inefficient, Captain Short had done everything he could to make their lives a misery. Sir Joseph Banks had warned them he had a reputation for such behaviour and had tried to have someone appointed to his place, but without success.

What that man hadn't stooped to! What wretched luck that they should have him. Mary sighed. And how patient Papa had been. She would not have thought it possible for him to show such patience in the face of overwhelming provocation. She thought of the stupid letters Captain Short had sent to Papa seeking his advice, and then purposely ignoring it. And how he had refused to let Putland come to see them. And yet this little man Captain Short had a wife and six children on board with him. How wretched they must be and what misfortune for John Putland who had been made Lieutenant on the *Porpoise*.

On and on the squabbling had gone even after they had sailed, and all

the time the dreadful sea-sickness. At first Mary wondered if she should tell the family of her misfortunes but then decided they would want to know exactly how she was faring. So once again she took up the quill.

"I am almost ashamed," she continued, "to tell you, that once or twice, my courage completely failed me. One night in particular, I was quite alone and shut up in darkness and the confusion on deck appeared so great to me that I was overcome and obliged to call my Father. I fear I shall never be able to forgive Captain Short for keeping Putland from me at that time when it would have been the greatest comfort for me to have had him to speak to at nights, as I can never sleep...

"It will give you some idea of the situation when I tell you that the storm, which lasted sixteen days, had in some degree abated and Piper and I attempted to play Backgammon but couldn't keep the board steady...

"I am now going to take my morning walk and if anything occurs that I think will amuse you, my dear sisters, I shall open my desk."

Mary put down her pen and stretched her fingers that had cramped from writing. Then she went out through the open door on to the deck to find her father standing by the railing.

"Hullo, my dear," he said. "Beginning to enjoy it a little more now?"

"Yes Papa, provided it doesn't get rough again. I've been writing to the girls. I'm not going to be caught without a letter again."

"There probably won't be another chance to send letters until we pass St. Helena. I believe the Justiana is leaving us there. Still, as you know, there's no telling if another ship will appear on the horizon... Now my dear that you're so much better, what say we have a couple of little

dinner parties? Would you like that?"

"Of course, Papa."

"I don't want you to think life at sea is all dull," laughed her father.

"We'll ask the Captains of some of the other ships to come and dine with us... Brooks and Townson perhaps... and Mr. and Mrs. Gore also.... What do you think of that?"

"Fine," said Mary. "Perhaps the cook will be persuaded to produce something better than usual. I never imagined a ship's cook could be so utterly hopeless. We should throw him overboard and prepare the meals ourselves..." Papa laughed in agreement. Then Mary gazed across at the other ship half a mile away. "If only Putland could come over here, Papa. I keep wondering how he is."

Although Mary had told her sisters some of the fears and troubles in her letter she had kept the greatest concern hidden in her heart. The rough cold sea trip, the storms, the long watches under Captain Short, had undoubtedly made John's cough worse. If only this warmer weather could bring him relief. Then there was Sydney Town. All her hopes now were pinned on reaching New South Wales and the warm even climate she had heard so much about. Surely that would set him right.

Bligh's brows had shot together at Mary's words about his son-in-law. "I think you'll have to put it right out of your mind any hope of seeing Putland. I am quite sure," he continued bitterly. "That drunken Captain Short is determined to cause as much distress as possible. Dammit, Mary, what a pleasant trip we could have had without him. And they bring on my headaches again. I tell you what, my dear, there will be more unpleasantness yet. I know that wretch will want to call in at Rio.

But it would be wrong, I'm sure of that."

"But you have the authority to decide, Papa," replied Mary quickly.

"Your secret orders from the Admiralty say so."

"I know, my dear. I'm the one to make the decisions on the course and the ports of rendezvous. That's what the orders are and Short knows it too. But as soon as he hears I've decided one thing he works and quarrels and agitates for another. He wants to call in at Rio for a few days on the town. But with all this fighting, no-one really knows who has control of Rio... there's no reason to stop there. But you watch, Mary, there'll be plenty of trouble to come..."

Bligh's words were prophetic. As the convoy of ships moved slowly south, gradually becoming more and more oppressed by the heat of the tropics, and as St. Helena and Rio de Janeiro drew nearer, the quarrels between Bligh and Short flared and subsided, and flared again.

Sometimes Short appeared anxious to appease Bligh and would allow Putland to visit the Lady Madeleine Sinclair as often as he liked. Then at other times he seemed determined to heap insults on Bligh's head. Yet at the same time Bligh was immovable in his decision to take the safest course and not stop at Rio.

In spite of all of this Mary was now feeling well again and she found there were many things to make life pleasant. There had been little glamour since her marriage for which she had fought so hard. Now suddenly there seemed a brightening on the horizon. John was with her more often and again she found herself the centre of attention.

Her father was the most honoured passenger in the entire convoy. After all, he was to be Governor of New South Wales and Mary was the

leading lady. There were dinner parties and musical evenings. Mary had both her lute and piano in her cabin and was often requested to play. The Captains and Officers from the other ships came to visit her and young Mr. Griffin became her devoted slave. Mr. Gore, who was going to the Colony to be Provost-Marshall, and his wife often joined the party. The little group of vessels was like an isolated community set apart from the rest of the world, yet all the time it slowly moved forward towards its destination. Sometimes Mary would stand on the deck and gaze at the five other ships and wonder about the hundreds of people on them, the sailors and merchant men, the settlers and convicts.

"You know, Papa," she said one day as they gazed at the rest of the convoy, "we meet only the men in command of those ships. What of all the hundreds of people on board them? Why do they choose to travel these hundreds of miles across the world? It seems such a long way."

"It doesn't seem such a long way to me," Bligh replied taking her arm in his. "And most of them do it for a living. Some people have sea in their blood and wouldn't earn their living any other way, they're born into it... The Elizabeth's a whaler, it's a hard life whaling but there's money in it. The Justiana is a trading ship. There's money in that too. And the Porpoise as you know is a Navy ship."

"But what of the other two, Papa. The Convict ships... don't you ever think of them... the hundreds of people shut down below? I know they've all committed crimes, but I often wonder how they bear it."

"Of course I think about them, Mary. The convicts are a very important part of the country I'm going to govern. Many of the freed convicts are the very people I'm going out to protect. It's the small settlers and the

freed convicts that are being ruined by this utterly damnable Army Corps out there... as a matter of fact, Mary," he continued, "I thought I would go and visit the two convict ships and address them... tell them that provided they behave they'll get a good deal in New South Wales."

"I'm sure that will help in the long term, Papa..."

Captain Bligh was true to his word. As a result, when Mary sat down next day to add to the letter to her sisters, a letter that had been steadily growing as the days passed, she had something a little different to tell them.

"March 4, at 10 O'clock," she wrote, "Papa went on board the *Alexander* to see the state of the ship and convicts. Those poor unfortunate creatures were delighted to see him and Papa told them that if Captain Brookes reported their behaviour as good during the voyage he should do all in his power to improve their situation and they appeared quite happy to hear this news..."

"In this ship there are female as well as male convicts. Amongst the latter is a clergyman, of the name Newisham, a man of very good family. His wife is with him and they say she is a very genteel woman. Tomorrow Papa goes upon the same duty, to the *Fortune*, another convict ship..."

After that another week went by with nothing eventful taking place and the happenings recorded for her sisters were mostly of a feminine and domestic interest.

"This morning," she wrote, "I opened the packing case with my hats and bonnets and I discovered another theft, which must have been committed in Anthony's Lodgings. Nothing less than a beautiful Mob Cap, that I had laid upon the top but I did not nail down the lid until the

morning we left you when I suppose they took advantage of the confusion we were in and stole it. I know Mrs. Hallett and Anne will join with you all in saying 'well it is no great loss!'

"Yesterday we had some tarts made of the preserved gooseberries, which are remarkably fine. Papa was much pleased with them and desired to thank Mama and you all...

"I forget whether I told you that I found my lute has exceedingly improved. It has quite a fine loud mellow tone far superior to the one I had in London. I am very fond of it and when I am well I find it a great amusement. My piano likewise improves and stands in tune remarkably well.

"Our Hens have just begun to lay and they give us six or seven eggs every day. We have been very fortunate with our poultry and they are all in very good condition, as are the cow and the calf and we are enabled to supply all the passengers with milk mornings and evenings and send Putland a bottle at every opportunity. We have had three little roasting pigs and there remains one which we do not intend to kill. So much for our stock."

On March 12, there was some excitement, and when Mary sat down at her desk that day, she was able to describe how they met three Portuguese ships and how the Master of one came on board.

"We gave him a bottle of Brandy," she continued, "Which he seemed to think a great treasure and in return he sent us some oranges and bananas. I was much disappointed with the latter, as they are generally considered a very fine fruit. Papa is very fond of them. I do not know of any thing that I can compare to the taste of them but in appearance they

are exactly like a cucumber except that the skin is perfectly smooth They yield a strong perfume, not at all pleasant to me, indeed so much to the contrary that they have made me feel very faint.”

It appeared as if, after the early storms, the voyage was to continue in comparative peace and quiet with Mary seeing John occasionally and Captain Short satisfied that he had done his worst. But such was not the case.

The day after Mary received the gift of the bananas she was on deck walking with her father. Whether it was the result of the bananas, which Mary blamed, or because the weather had become a little rough, it is hard to say, but she began to feel uneasy in her stomach again so she was hoping the fresh air would banish her sickness.

“You'd better get that screed you've written to the girls sealed up,” Papa advised. “Remember the Justiana will be leaving us for St. Helena in a day or two... and are you feeling better?”

“A little Papa... but this sea-sickness is a wretched. What a blessing you've never suffered from it.”

“I wouldn't be much of a sailor if I did... nonetheless, my dear, I've ordered the course of the ship to be altered a little. It should be helping you... see, it's not rolling as much now as it was... do you notice?”

Mary's reply was deafened by a sudden shout from her father.

“By God hell and damnation! What's he up to now?”

“What, Papa? What?” asked Mary in the confusion. “I can't see anything.”

“Look!” shouted Bligh, waving his arms around. “Can't you see? Short's

signal! Can't you see? By God, he's ordered me to steer to the windward! What the devil! Damned if I will!"

Swearing and calling out, Blyth rushed away from Mary and down towards the helmsman shouting at him to keep the course he was on. "I'm in charge of this convoy. I'll not take advice from Short!"

There was suddenly an explosion near the ship with a cascade of water flying up into the air. For one moment Blyth stood perfectly still, arrested in his angry rampage by something that was too outrageous for words. He had exhausted his flow of language on lesser misdeeds. A shot had been fired from the Porpoise and it had landed in front of the Lady Sinclair.

"My God!" he shouted suddenly breaking his unnatural silence, "I'll have him in irons for this. I'll court-martial him when he gets to the Cape!"

Mary was just as angry. She felt the rage mount up inside her. Captain Short had fired a warning shot from his cannon. At just that moment another shot came over and landed right under the front of the boat. By this time everyone was on deck and Eleanor was standing next to Mary.

"What's happening, Ma'am?"

"I can't believe it, Eleanor!" she gasped. "That odious man Short! How dare he! What will Putland be thinking?"

"He must be drunk again, Ma'am," said Mr. Griffin.

"He's out of his mind, Ma'am," said Eleanor.

"Mad, that's what I say. Quite mad!" Blyth yelled over the confusion.

"Are we all going to be sunk now?"

"Is it another mutiny?" Mary whispered in disbelief.

But nothing further happened. Captain Short's drunken outburst had evidently subsided and there was calm. For a whole day and a half those on board could talk nothing but this extraordinary event. Was Captain Short drunk? Why had he done it? What would Captain Bligh do?

For the moment Captain Bligh was far too busy writing his despatches about the entire incident and the series of insults he had endured.

Everyone else were busy adding a description of it to their letters that would go on the *Justiana* and Mary sat in her cabin with quill in hand.

"The bad conduct of Capt. Short," she added to her letter, "has taken up Papa's whole time, nor has he finished. I cannot describe how much it has vexed him... I know that if the *Justiana* does not leave us till the morning he will be up all night writing to Mama and the Admiralty...."

Just then there was a disturbance on deck and Mary looked out to see John Putland climbing up over the side of the ship. She rose to run to him but saw him turn quickly towards her father's cabin. Of course he was on official business but at least he was safe.

How difficult it was to wait and yet she knew she must. She stood at the door of her cabin and watched her father and Putland locked in discussion. How angry her father looked and how worried and ill John appeared. At one stage he coughed badly and glanced at her over his shoulder. Her heart ached for him. The conversation between them went on and on. Finally he began to leave so Mary ran over to him and in the end Mary had barely two minutes of her husband to herself.

"Whatever happened John? Are you all right?"

John coughed and cleared his throat and gave Mary a hug. "I'm sorry... I must get back to my boat. Short is a lunatic. I fear for your safety Mary...

I must go...”

“But why did he fire on us?”

“Rio. He is demanding we stop at Rio. I must go...” At that Putland kissed Mary and then he clambered over the side of the boat into the small launch and was rowed away as Bligh watched on. The family would scarcely believe what she had to write.

“3 pm. Putland has just been on board. He can scarcely speak from agitation about the subject of the shots which were fired at us. Captain Short had the brutality to make him fire at us. That is, he was officer on the Watch. And he told him to prepare a third shot for if we did not bear down immediately and stop at Rio he was to fire right into us. I think such an inhuman thing, as making a man fire at his father and wife was never done before. Putland did not stay more than half an hour with us so that I had very little conversation with him. He desired to be most affectionately remembered to Mama and you all.

“God bless and protect you my dear sisters, with my affectionate love and duty to Mama, believe I shall always remain your truly affectionate sister,

Mary Putland.”

The letter was completed at last and with many others was rowed over to the Justiana. Then the Justiana set sail for St. Helena where the letters would be transferred to a home going vessel. How long, Mary wondered, before her sisters would read her words?

Chapter Fifteen

After that extraordinary event a strange quiet fell over the convoy. The heat of the tropics lay like a sticky mantle over the small ships and everyone seemed to only have time to keep cool. Even Captain Short ceased to cause trouble and allowed Putland to stay on board with Mary.

Perhaps it was the heat. Or perhaps it was a feeling that he had overstepped the mark in actually firing on the man who, when they reached New South Wales, would be his Governor. Maybe he had finally accepted the fact that they would not call at Rio and he had suddenly realised that the Cape of Good Hope was drawing ominously closer. There Bligh would have others in authority to support him against this troublesome man.

Whatever it was, life at last became peaceful and uneventful and for another two weeks the small ships moved slowly on. Then the writing of letters started again. The time was approaching when the convict ships and the Elizabeth, who were short of water, would leave for Rio. Bligh, in spite of an attack of cruel headaches, was again trying to complete the full despatches he had been unable to send with the Justiana.

"Mary my dear," he said, "I'll have to leave the letters to the family to you, my dear. I must finish these despatches."

"So little has happened, Papa. There seems nothing worth writing about."

"Nonsense, my girl. You must find something. Letters mean so much to

them at home.”

Mary went to her cabin and sat down at her desk. She sighed as she lifted her quill. How hot it was. What a relief it would be to reach the Cape and to once more walk on firm ground. Let's hope, she thought, that it's in English hands, what with the war on, anything could have happened.

She gazed out her open window and let her thoughts drift to the convict ships that were to leave them soon. How little cause she really had to complain. She thought of the hundreds of people packed below decks in this stifling hot weather. If she felt like this how much worse must they feel.

Some days, when the ships had been near, these people came up on deck for a brief on hour walk. How could they bear to go down again to the heat, the stuffiness and the horrible stench. She had heard they had one open bucket for their slops. But they had no choice in the matter. And a baby had been born on the Fortune. How did a woman manage with a new baby? What a dreadful price these people paid for their crimes, many so petty.

“April 1.

“My dear Sisters,

“By Captain Brookes leaving us for Rio de Janeiro, I have the opportunity of sending you this letter. By the Justiana who left us about a fortnight ago I sent you a journal I had kept up... since then nothing has occurred worthy of remark. Captain Short has been perfectly quiet and on Saturday gave Putland leave to stay with us until he made a signal for him which has not yet been hoisted. By the Juliana Papa wrote to Mama and sent a letter to the Admiralty and Secretary of State Office

concerning Captain Short as he could not get the statement and rest of the papers ready in time. Ever since then he and Mr. Griffin have been employed with these from morning till night and the close confinement and warm weather has made him rather unwell with headaches but we are now losing the heat of the Line, the Equator...

“You will perceive that we have lately crossed the Line. I am sure you have heard so much of the ceremony that is performed so it would be needless to report it. We expect to reach the Cape in a month or six weeks. From whence you will hear very fully from us. We are very disappointed at not going into Rio on Mama's and your account, but Papa has commissioned Captain Moore of the Fortune, who appears to be the man of the greatest taste, to purchase for Mama and all of you what he thought to be the prettiest and best stones, preferring sapphire, emerald and amethyst... Mama's of course to be the most handsome.

“It is our fervent prayers that Mama and you my dear sisters continue well and that you my dear Harriet have got over your confinement. Need I say how anxiously we shall be expecting letters from you upon our arrival at Port Jackson. Papa begs that you my dear Mama will always tell him what passes of consequence in the world.

“God bless you my dear Mama and sisters. Papa tells me to always give you his affectionate love although he may write himself. Putland writes the same and with kindest wishes to all our friends, believe me always to remain yours unalterably,

Mary Putland.”

That letter went on its way and Captain Short made one last request to call in at Rio. When Bligh refused, and the other ships had left, only the

Porpoise and the Lady Madeleine Sinclair were left to continue their lonely way towards the Cape of Good Hope. After another two long months, and without sight of ship or land, they finally anchored at Simon's Bay.

Their fears of French possession were quite unjustified and they found Cape Town in the hands of the British. Sir David Baird made much fanfare for the visitors and gave Blyth and his daughter all the honour their future position merited.

Mary found the beauty of the flowers and trees of Cape Town and the surrounding countryside and the ever present grandeur of the flat topped mountain hard to believe. At last she felt as if she were seeing the world. Here was excitement, colour, pomp, beautiful homes and many servants.

She was entertained as a grand lady. Here, thought Mary, was a taste of what life would be like in New Holland and she enjoyed every minute of it. Even Captain Short has been so co-operative for the last few weeks that Blyth decided not to take any action against him. Blyth had a strangely forgiving streak in his character.

At last the time came for the joys of the Cape to be left behind. The small ships sailed again. The next time Mary would set foot on land would be in a couple of months at the colony of New South Wales where she would be centre of all social life, where her father would achieve great success, and where her dear John Putland would surely permanently recover his health.

Chapter Sixteen

On April 20 the first pebble was thrown into the always turgid pond of Sydney's gossip mill. In the centre of the front page of the Sydney Gazette, Sydney's only newspaper produced by ex-convict George Howe at the back of Government House, appeared a letter written by the Right Honourable Lord Vincent Castlereagh to His Excellency, Governor King.

“Downing Street,

July 13, 1805

Sir,

In conformity to your request and to the assurance given to you by Lord Hobart in November 1803, that a proper person should be selected to relieve you in your Government, the King has been pleased to appoint Captain Bligh, of the Royal Navy, as your successor.”

Immediately a ripple went round the Colony. Here was news indeed. A new Governor! So poor old King, stricken with his gout and exhausted by the monopolists, was going home at last. Bligh was to come. It was said he had six daughters. That should make things look up.

The ripple was nothing compared with the waves that followed. The army officers, such as the short, dark Captain Abbott, the infamous Captain Kemp, or the high living Captain Harris, on his park-like estates on the Parramatta Road, and the monopolists, ex-convict Simeon Lord,

sitting like a handsome spider in his grand mansion in the centre of Sydney, the wily Nicholas Bayly, or the famous John Macarthur, all these men, and many other like them were masters at intrigue and gossip.

They were not deceived for one moment by the simple announcement in the Gazette. They had heard of Captain William Bligh, some had even read his book, and they knew immediately why he was being sent to the Colony.

Hunter and King were easily manipulated, but now the British Government was sending out a man of iron? They laughed at the idea. Someone who would curb their power? They laughed again. They'd see about that. Their privileges had been threatened before and they knew how to deal with them.

Following the announcement the Colony was immediately deluged with stories and anecdotes. The Regimental Mess and the few drawing rooms of the Colony hummed with gossip. The convict women who lived with the officers and soldiers soon heard about it too. Everything that had ever been heard or said about Bligh was repeated.

The old story of the Mutiny on the Bounty took pride of place and the lies that the Heywoods and the Christians had invented were repeated and exaggerated. Although it had nothing to do with Bligh, even the Mutiny at the Nore was dragged in. John Macarthur and his friends made sure that everyone in the colony, particularly the soldiers, knew that a tyrant, a bully and an autocrat was coming out to govern them.

The settlers, many miles from the centre of the colony heard the stories too, but they were made of harder stock. They were not taken in quite as easily as the people in the town. Perhaps only an autocrat and a tyrant

would be able to stand up to John Macarthur and curb the monopolists and the rum sellers.

While the stories were circulating around the Colony, the object of them, William Bligh and his daughter were standing on the deck of the *Lady Sinclair* gazing at the distant coast of New South Wales. Though the two small ships had made the journey very quickly from the Cape, it had seemed an eternity to Mary.

They had battled across the Indian Ocean, across the south of New Holland, around the southernmost part of Van Dieman's Land, and now were on their last stage, sailing up the east coast of New South Wales. Sometimes they could see their new country quite closely, with fierce brown cliffs and headlands. Sometimes it was merely a thin line on the horizon.

"What a dreary voyage it has been Papa, and so cold these last few weeks. And as for the people on this ship, I hope I never see them again."

"You'll see a lot of them, I'm afraid. The Gores, for example... he's to be our Provost Marshall, as you well know, and if I'm to bring about any of these reforms, I'll need plenty of assistance from him. He's a good, worthy man."

Mary sighed. "I know, Papa, and his wife too. You've said that before. But she's so boring. All she can talk about are all those children. I'll scream if I hear them mentioned again...."

"It's been dull for you... especially these last two months with only the Porpoise for company, which is no company at all. And with John so sick you've had a hard time, I'll admit..." Just then Putland walked up

and joined them.

“Feeling better John?” Bligh asked.

“Yes Sir... as we go north, you can feel the change in the weather, don't you think?”

“Indeed... though even in Sydney, of course, it's winter now. So don't expect too much. A few more days and we'll be there. Mary's here complaining of the boredom. She's always wanted to go sailing and now she's longing to stop. So am I, I must say. But it won't be a bed of roses when we get there...” As he was speaking, John's face, which had appeared so happy, clouded over.

“Is it so bad, Mary dear? It's all my fault, I'm afraid Sir,” Putland responded as he briefly put his handkerchief over his mouth and coughed. “Pardon... what poor sort of husband I have been yet Mary never complains to me.”

“Papa is talking nonsense,” replied Mary angrily. “I'm not complaining at all,” she continued hurriedly. “I'm just bored with some people here... don't you long for fresh faces and to get off this ship?”

Three days later the anticipated moment arrived and the two heads guarding the entrance to Port Jackson came into view. The moment the two ships were seen from the white cottage perched on South Head a flag was run up at the flagpole so the inhabitants of Sydney Town knew a boat was arriving.

What a pity, thought Mary, that Putland was not with them for this moment since he had returned to his own vessel for the official arrival. Imagine being stuck on the same boat as that loathsome Captain Short

all this time.

Slowly they sailed through the Heads and none of the descriptions that had been told had prepared them for what they saw. Even Bligh was amazed. In all his travelling this was one place he had never seen.

"It's so beautiful Papa," Mary sighed in disbelief.

"I think Rio is the only harbour I have ever seen to equal it."

The sea and the sky were blue and on the left the land rose steeply with bay following bay in endless variety. Each headland covered with trees almost to the water's edge except for a crescent of sand at its foot. On the right were a series of larger bays with arms stretching out each side and the land rising more gradually, also thickly covered with grey green trees.

For six miles they sailed, astonished at each new coloured bay, at the native canoes on the water's edge in some places, and past Pinchgut, the tiny island used for recalcitrant prisoners. Then finally, at long last, they sailed around the corner into Sydney Cove and dropped anchor.

Mary stood gazing at the settlement that now lay before her. Her father in full uniform stood at her side equally absorbed with the view of the Colony.

"Well," he said rubbing his hands. "There you are, Mary. That's our future domain. What do you think of it?"

"But Papa," wondered Mary. "Do you think that's all there is?"

"I expect that's the whole of Sydney Town."

"But the houses are so small. There's hardly a decent building there. It's very disappointing, Papa."

“Disappointing? I’ll not have you say that. Just look at Government House over there...”

The township lay before them in a half circle, stretching around the curve of Sydney Cove and following her father's pointing finger Mary picked out Government House standing alone on the left.

“That would be it I’m sure,” continued Bligh. “See? And that’s the Government landing stage.”

Government House stood on its own well away from the rest of the town. A long gracious two storied house with a pillared veranda across its front. Its grounds ran down to the water’s edge where the landing stage was. On the township’s side the grounds ended with a strong fence and a small guardhouse where a sentry stood. Tall trees were scattered about.

“That does look all right, Papa. But it’s about the only decent sized building in the place. What are those big buildings on the hill at the back of the town?”

“I think they’re the Barracks, my dear. And further to the right of those up the hill, that’s the Church. Then those big buildings down near the water’s edge, I believe they’re Government stores and storehouses belonging to some of the wealthier people.”

“Apart from those, Papa, there’s hardly a decent house to be seen. Two or three perhaps. Most of them are very mean looking. And round on the right there nothing but a jumble of huts.”

“It’s a small colony, Mary.”

Chapter Seventeen

It was another bright sunny day. Tommy and Matt, two of Sydney's many orphan children, had climbed one of the trees that overlooked the Governor's landing wharf. They were concealed from those below, but could see everything that took place. They had arrived at seven o'clock in the morning and had carefully walked right around the outside of Government House then scaled the fence and approached the wharf from the other side away from the town.

By either good or bad fortune, they had managed to keep out of Governor King's orphanages. Tommy had selected the thickest tree, in the best position, and now he and Matt were safely installed and determined to miss nothing. By nine o'clock things were starting to move.

"The soldiers are coming," whispered Matt. "See? From the barracks."

"And the people too... you won't be able to move round here soon."

"And don't you move, Matty, we've got the best view in town."

Under their very eyes they watched the red and the white of the New South Wales Corps as they marched from the Barracks with their band and colours and formed into an avenue stretching from Government House down to the wharf.

At the sound of the band the people had come out, men, women and children, standing as close to the Governor's wharf and the Governor's fence as they were allowed. Meanwhile, the privileged few, the leading citizens and traders, were arriving in their carriages and coaches and



Government House Parramatta 1805

began gathering at Government House.

Great things were to happen today. Tommy had heard about it all while sitting quietly in a corner of a Tavern at The Rocks. As long as you were quiet, Tommy had found, you could go practically anywhere in Sydney. People were used to kids hanging around. If you made a nuisance of yourself they'd throw you, but if you stayed quietly they let you be.

Women were few and men were many. The few decent women in the colony set up cottages of domestic virtue. After them, there were only the convict women to be shared among the soldiers, sailors and convicts that thronged the streets. These women lived as best they could. Sadly, the Government gave them no place to live, unless they were bad enough to be imprisoned.

The most fortunate ones set up permanent liaisons with officers. Some even married. Most of them lived from man to man, many at The Rocks area, a jumble of huts, brothels and inns at the opposite end of the town

from Government House. If these women possessed any moral virtues before they left England they were certainly crushed by the awfulness of the journey to New Holland, where they were not only treated as lacking human qualities, but also fair prey for any man.

In Sydney Town it was here that the 'disorderly women' accumulated around Sydney Cove, whose westerly arm, The Rocks, was the most dangerous thieves' kitchen in the Colony.

Tommy and Matt's mother had died when Matt was five. Their father, a soldier, was not even sure that they were his and disowned them and was then moved to Parramatta. Tommy was nine and vowed two things; one was to look after Matt, the other was to keep away from any authority.

A kind woman, who had become a friend of their mother's on the journey out, allowed them to sleep in a shed at the back of the house where she occupied the euphonious title of housekeeper. She made it quite clear to them that they were never to come near the house and never to be seen by the owner. So they crept in after dark and often found a few scraps of food waiting for them. Apart from that, they lived by their wits, and the knowledge that freedom, however uncomfortable, was better than an orphanage.

"Here they comes now... look Matt, the new Governor."

"Look how smart his blue and gold is..."

They watched Governor Bligh leave the Lady Madeleine Sinclair and heard the guns booming as he did so. Then they saw him board the H.M.S. Porpoise, where, at last, he was rid of the detestable Captain Short, and could hoist his Pendant, as Commander in Chief of all His Majesty's ships in the Colony.

Again the guns boomed, this time from the Porpoise. Much to their

delight it happened twice more. From the Governor's six-oar cutter, Bligh boarded and left the Buffalo and the Fortune, and each time fifteen more guns were fired. Tommy and Matt could scarcely believe their eyes or ears.

The boom of the guns caused disarray amongst the birds in the surrounding harbours bush. Galahs, bald-eyed corellas, pink Leadbeater's and black funeral cockatoos, rainbow-coloured lorikeets and rosellas fluttered in swarms at the noise. Even that spectacle wasn't the end.

Under the very eyes of Tommy and Matt the boat rowed gracefully in with the new Governor and Mary by his side and landed at his wharf and the guns started again. This time it was a salute of nineteen from the shore battery. Tiny budgerigars, disturbed by the noise, flew up in green clouds.

"That is loud," said Tommy. "I haven't seen anything like this before in my life."

"And look at his daughter," said Matt. "She looks really smart."

While this had been taking place, the doors of Government House had opened and Governor and Mrs. King and their attendants had walked down the avenue of soldiers to officially welcome the new Governor. Mary was standing proudly with her father. This was to be their official welcome and Mary's whole being was filled with pride and joy. The number of guns did not seem too many to her. In her opinion they were merely indicative of her father's worth and at last he had a position to equal his ability and integrity.

Suddenly there was a loud crack nearby, almost like a gunshot. The branch that Tommy and Matt were crouching on had snapped. In a split

second it was like a slippery slide of shining grey green eucalyptus leaves and Tommy and Matt proceeded to slide down it at speed landing on the ground with a thud.

Both were winded by the fall and Matt burst into tears. The two boys were in a heap about thirty feet from the official party as it walked by. The party stopped in surprise and looked over to see what had happened.

“Are they all right?” Mary asked immediately. She broke from the procession and walked quickly to the boys as they tried urgently to compose themselves.

“Stop crying Matt, at once...” Tommy whispered angrily. “Oh my god... she's heading this way!”

Tommy stood up and brushed himself off. Everyone was looking at them. They were covered in dirt from the fall and their clothes were rags anyway. Matt had blood on his knee-caps.

“Are you all right boys? That was quite a fall,” Mary sympathised as Bligh and the others in the official party murmured amongst themselves. “Yes, yes... we're fine Ma'am... sorry...” Tommy said, standing at attention and visibly embarrassed.

“Where are your parents?” Mary asked looking around at the crowds on the other side of the fence.

“We don't have parents, Ma'am... we're orphans...”

“Oh...” Mary replied. She had heard about Governor King's orphanage, and here was first hand evidence. “Did your whole orphanage come here for this ceremony?”

“We don't live in the orphanage, Ma'am,” Tommy tried vainly to explain as he realised they had been caught out as street kids by no less than the

First Lady-in-Waiting.

“Hmm....” Mary thought quickly as she glanced over her shoulder to see her father watching. “Soldier!” she commanded to a nearby member of the Corps. “Take these boys down to the barracks and clean them up and then bring them back to Government House straight away so I can talk to them.”

“Of course, Ma'am,” the soldier replied as he led them away. Mary then turned around and joined her father again. Here was more evidence of the underside of life in the new Colony.

Mary had recovered from her disappointment at the first sight of Sydney. From the gates of Government House, where she had walked with Mrs. King the day before on a brief tour, she had seen the dirty untidy streets and had noticed the poorly maintained gardens and the dogs and goats that wandered around in the dust.

Moreover, some of the things Mrs. King told her had horrified her. The lawlessness and drunkenness of the ordinary people were only equaled by the cheating and squabbling of those in high positions. Mrs. King had had enough and told Mary so.

In fact the more she heard, the more certain she became that what her dear Papa had said was right. Here indeed was work for Papa to do. She could not help thinking how weak Governor King must have been not to have reformed the place.

However, just one glance of his face, as he bowed to officially welcome her, made her regret her mental criticism. He looked completely exhausted, his face lined with pain and weariness. Mrs. King had already told her that he suffered from gout.

As her thoughts continued to dwell on the two boys she had just met, she

found herself walking up through red-coated soldiers to Government House. How could she help but feel happy and proud, conscious of the many admiring glances.

The arrival of a person of Mary's beauty and accomplishments in the Colony was indeed an event. It was not long before everyone knew of the rose silk gown and bonnet and the white satin slippers she had worn. In fact, everyone agreed that she was even more attractive than Mrs. Macarthur.

As for those present at the reception, nothing was lacking in their expressions of joy, their politeness, their promises of loyalty and assistance to the new Governor, or their pretty speeches and compliments to his daughter.

If the entire Colony was seething with the implications of his arrival, if the military and civil exploiters of the community were determined to resist him to the last inch, no indication was given. No more promising a welcome, no greater friendliness, could be shown. Until the monster was going to spring, no-one could be more affable than the officers of the New South Wales Corps and their friends.

Once the ceremony finished and the soldiers marched away, most of the townspeople wandered off. The bell-birds chimed in the distance. Then, one after another, the leading men and women of the small society were presented to Bligh and his daughter.

There was Lieutenant-Colonel Johnson, Commander-in-Chief of the New South Wales Corps; fair and weak faced. Then there was Mr. Richard Atkins, the Judge-Advocate; good looking, but later to be found out as weak, vacillating and a drunkard. After them there was Captain and Mrs. Abbott, Mr. Palmer, the Commissary-General, to become one

of Bligh's staunchest supporters. Then D'Arcy Wentworth, reputed to have been a highway robber in England, and now assistant surgeon. And finally John Harris, owner of the fine Ultimo House and surgeon to the New South Wales Corps.

One after another they came and were introduced; the so-called elite of the small colony. But then there was a hush over the large reception room. Mary looked around in surprise wondering what was the reason until she caught the end of Governor King's words.

"... Mr. And Mrs. John Macarthur."

So here he was, thought Mary. She knew why there was a hush.

Everyone was watching to see the meeting between her father and the man who had already ruined two Governors. How would the third one manage this perturbator, as Governor King described him?

Mary allowed herself a little smile. If the onlookers expected fireworks they were mistaken. Papa, when he chose to be was just as expert as the New South Wales Corps at being affable.

"Ah, Mr. John Macarthur, eh? Delighted, I'm sure. I've heard a lot about you Sir. You have many concerns here, I believe. I hope to benefit from your advice..."

"I shall be delighted, Your Excellency," replied John Macarthur, bowing low, "to do anything in my power."

"And Mrs. Macarthur," continued Bligh. "How charming to meet you, Ma'am. I hope you will be company for my daughter here. She pines for someone to play duets."

John Macarthur was now bowing over Mary's hand and she looked at him with her clear blue eyes wonderingly. He was a handsome man, there was no doubt, with a charming smile. Could he be the villain he

was painted? A strong, dark face, to be sure, and an arrogant nose, but surely not as evil as some people said.

Yet, as he passed by, Mary was left with a feeling, a reminder of something in his face. It teased her for several moments and she found her eyes following him as others spoke to her. The strangely shaped eyes, the nose slightly turned up, what was it? Then she remembered, it was a picture in one of her books at home in England, a storybook they had loved as children, about ancient Greek and Roman myths. This man was like one of the dark woodland satyrs that haunted the forests. Yes, thought Mary, all he needed were the little horns.

But now there was Reverend Samuel Marsden standing before her; a well fed worldly cleric, and she was hearing that he was exceedingly interested in sheep breeding experiments. And with him was Mrs. Marsden, obviously soon to have a child. She heard of their other children and how they were soon to return to England for a visit. And so it went on. There were not that many of them but they were Sydney's entire elite society.

At last they were all gone and Mary and her father sat by themselves in the drawing room of Government House exhausted.

"Well well," Bligh said to his daughter with a wry smile, "after all this time we have finally put faces to the names we've heard so much about in England."

"Everyone seemed so polite, I guess Papa," Mary said, but then she put her face closer to her fathers. "Except so many of them had rum on their breath! I mean, really and truly Papa, you would expect...." Mary didn't finish her sentence because Eleanor strode into the room with two boys.

"A final meeting, Ma'am," Eleanor announced proudly. "May I

introduce Masters Tommy and Matt. Your Excellency and Lady..." It was Tommy and Matt, this time washed and scrubbed and in a new set of clothes.

"Well I can hardly recognise you two," Mary said with a smile.

"Thank you, Ma'am... this is such an honour," Tommy said. He and Matt had never had so much information and instructions drilled into them in such a short time while at the barracks getting cleaned and made ready for the presentation.

It was all too brief as Mary was exhausted physically and mentally from the strain of all the attention. After all, they were only on the high seas a couple of days before, and Mary still found walking on firm land a bit strange. But one thing stood out; these boys had a different and peculiar accent. They were known as Currency because they had been born in Australia.

Their accent lacked both the euphony of standard English and the glottal patter of Cockney. It was unmistakable and broad, 'as the scent of burning eucalyptus.' So Mary quizzed the boys about their day to day lives, instructed the servants to give them a good meal and invited them to return to Government House in a few weeks to say hullo again after everything had settled down.

If the show for the day had finished for Tommy and Matt, they had not long to wait for the next one. Five days later, at noon, they were up another tree, and once again they saw the New South Wales Corps paraded in all its faded glory. This time Tommy knew what was about to happen.

"They're going to read out that Governor Bligh's the new Governor now, see Matt? And what he's to do."

“Oh,” said Matt, although not very clear about it, or what England was in the first place.

“He’s taking over from Governor King, you see? And today’s the day. And they’re reading out his Commission... that’s what they call it. I want to hear it if I can.”

Tommy was destined not to hear the Commission. The words drifted away in the thin winter air before they reached the small boys sitting in the large tree. If they could have heard them, and understood them, they may have been surprised at the absolute authority that was given to this one man over the lives of so many. Authority to make laws, to carry them out, and to be the final court of appeal for all justice.

Every aspect of the Colony, from the small trifle to the highest duty, came under his control. The red-coated officers, standing so straight, were probably not surprised. They had heard it all before, some of them several times. Moreover, they knew how little authority meant without the power to carry it out.

Nor was it new to Governor King. He was remembering the time, five years earlier, when he had taken over from Governor Hunter and how shocked he had been at Hunter’s appearance and at the appearance of Sydney; it’s slovenliness, the poverty of the poor people, and Hunter’s failure to remedy it. How sure he had been that he, John Gidley King, would soon set it right. What plans he had. How he would tidy the place up, help the farmers and curb the monopolies.

What had happened in those five years? He thought with dread of the years of bickering, insults and failure. But what could you do when you sent John Macarthur home to be tried and he came back triumphant with an order of 5,000 acres of land and thirty servants? He had given up

trying to withstand this detestable man?

Would Captain Bligh, he wondered, be able to succeed where he had failed? He had a reputation second to none. And King, only the day before, had met with Bligh to encourage and reward him for his appointment as next Governor, although he didn't particularly like the man.

"Well Mary dear, King and I have finished our meeting and he has granted us a large acreage in Parramatta and some more in the west of the town and I have granted Mrs. King a large area on South Creek near the Green Hills. And for your husband, land for a farm."

"John will be delighted..." Mary replied, distracted by the swiftness of the decision. But Bligh was a man of action and he was quick to head off with his entourage to speak to the free settlers and farmers and hear what they had to say.

Chapter Eighteen

Mary walked slowly from the Government Wharf towards her new home, Government House. She had just farewelled Mrs. King, who was returning by boat to Parramatta. What a good friend she had proved to be, thought Mary. With Papa and Putland away, it had indeed been pleasant to spend time with her and it was a friendship to be treasured, and one that was an oasis in a veritable desert of social life.

It was a pity that Papa and the ex-governor didn't get on as well. It was, of course, difficult for them both. King was ill and irritable, and most certainly jealous of Papa's good health, physical strength, and a salary double that of his predecessor. Papa deserved it, of course, but King would not realise that. And dear Papa, try as he could, was unable to hide completely the criticism he felt for King's regime, so much allowed to pass, so much left undone. Perhaps one should be thankful, thought Mary, that the relationship was not worse.

Mary walked across the columned veranda, through the parlour, and upstairs to her bedroom. There she found Eleanor, sorting some clothes.

"Well Eleanor, they have gone. I shall miss Mrs. King."

"Yes, Ma'am. It has been quite busy for you. Still, the Governor and Lieutenant Putland should be home soon."

"Yes indeed. I was just thinking, Eleanor, how considerate of the King's to vacate this Government House so soon and move to Parramatta. Mrs. King told me today that when they first arrived at the colony, Governor

Hunter stayed on interminably at Government House, interfering and complaining. He was here for months before his boat sailed."

"I think, Mrs. King, Ma'am, is a lady of very good sense."

"And with an intelligence too, Eleanor. How strange," she continued, "that she came to marry Captain King, and if the gossip we have heard is true, to accept him with the knowledge of his two little boys born on Norfolk Island."

"Life was very hard in the early days of the Colony, Ma'am. You should hear some of the stories Mr. Howe tells me. Don't forget there were only the convict women and Captain King was only a Lieutenant then."

"I guess you're right, Eleanor. One certainly has to change one's ideas in this place. I have never seen so many children wondering round, dirty and uncared for... I expect it is to be Captain King's credit that he looked after his boys. I believe many of the soldiers disown their children."

"Or get moved to some other place, Ma'am. It is very hard for them."

Mary laughed. "I can see you are determined to see good in everyone today, Eleanor. Did you get any really interesting news from Mr. Howe?"

"Yes, Ma'am," replied Eleanor excitedly. "There's the new issue on your desk there. I thought you should see it the moment you came in."

Mary hurried over and picked up the small newspaper and held it up.

"The Sydney Gazette!" she read deliberately. "How important it sounds, and yet how small a paper to hold all the news of the Colony. Only four pages again, Eleanor."

"Yes, but the paper quality is better don't you think, Ma'am? And Mr. Howe says he has enough paper to keep him going for several months. Only two weeks ago he was using his last sheets."

As Eleanor was talking, Mary started to read it. "Oh, Eleanor! A

hailstorm in the Hawkesbury district... I do hope Papa was not caught up in it. It says the hail stones were three inches in circumference! What an odd climate. Do you think that is possible?"

Eleanor smiled. "I think Mr. Howe exaggerates sometimes, Ma'am."

"And an earth tremor at Richmond Hill! I shall indeed be glad when Papa returns."

Every day brought something new and strange about this amazing place. There was Mr. Howe, for example, an ex-convict and yet the editor of the only newspaper for government announcements and he worked away in his small room at the back of Government House. They both found the Colony a desolate place for conversation and here was someone of interest.

Then her mind turned again to Mrs. King and the two illegitimate King sons, which everyone seemed to know about and accept. How unconventional everything was. Mary smiled as she thought how Harriet would have hated it all. Even though they resided in Government House, they lived so close to humanity. There was no escaping the weaknesses, crimes and passions of the everyday man. The chain gangs working in the streets were unavoidable. Just looking at the scars around their ankles was unbearable.

The crowd of hovels and huts around on the docks where the convict women and prostitutes lived could not be hidden in such a small community. Everyone knew when an officer or soldier had a convict mistress.

Yet some people seemed determined to live as if none of this existed. There was Surgeon Harris at Ultimo with his lavish gardens and spotted deer. And then, of course, the Macarthur's. While staying at Parramatta

with the Kings, Mary had called on the Macarthur's at Elizabeth farm. There was no denying the beauty of their place; it had peace and homeliness.

She remembered again the long white house, surrounded by roses and fruit trees beginning to reveal their red, pink and white blossoms. In fact, thought Mary, it must be admitted that, despite the poverty and depravity, the entire settlement was growing more beautiful every week. Or was she just beginning to understand it more? Or become drawn into its strangeness?

Perhaps it was the many English trees brought by the early settlers that were slowly bringing forth their green leaves. Already, under Papa's regime, the houses and trees were beginning to look tidier. Some of the convicts had been taken from the wealthy colonists and set to work tidying the towns and leveling the worst of the roads. Mary was growing accustomed to the Eucalyptus trees that had appeared so pale and lifeless on first impression. These ancient Eucalyptus where white sulphur-crested cockatoos would settle then with raucous shrieking fly away on mass.

Her thoughts returned to Elizabeth Farm, which was owned by Macarthur, and her visit to it. Could those terrible things she had heard about Mr. Macarthur possibly be true? With her own eyes she had seen his tenderness to his own children, his obvious love for his wife. Never, she was sure, could one find a more devoted family.

And Elizabeth Farm itself, with everything so beautifully cared for, so carefully planned, could that be done by a man capable of starving the ordinary people? Yet one could not disbelieve the words of people such as the ministers, Mr. Fulton and Marsden. Did these people have some

*John Macarthur*

personal grudge against Mr. Macarthur? Anyway, Papa would soon find out from the people themselves; the small farmers at Parramatta and on the Hawkesbury River.

She remembered how casually Mrs. Macarthur had asked her about her father. "With your father and husband away, Mrs. Putland, you must be glad to be staying with Mrs.

King? But I expect they will be back soon..."

"Oh no, Mrs. Macarthur," Mary divulged. "I do not expect him for some time. He has a lot of ground to cover, and the roads are quite shocking, as you know. Papa is determined to see the whole of the Colony for himself before he takes notice of some of the things he is told."

Mary did not think it would do any harm to let Mrs. Macarthur know what Papa was doing, and Mrs. Macarthur was evidently happy with the information she had gained. She quickly changed the subject and appeared to become completely absorbed with the matter of the roads.

"Yes, Mrs. Putland. The roads are quite terrible. The trouble is that most of the settlers will do nothing about them. They do not even look after their farms properly. Such carelessness and laziness you would not believe. You will have noticed that the roads around our property, to the contrary, are well cared for and a pleasure to drive over."

'With so many convicts assigned to you it's no wonder your roads are so good,' Mary wanted to say. But Papa insisted that she must show neither

favouritism nor animosity towards any person in the colony. Instead, therefore, Mary merely smiled. "Yes, indeed," she said. "Your roads are excellent Mrs. Macarthur, as is your whole property. I have not seen such neatness nor industry since we have arrived here."

It had been amusing, Mary thought, that when Mr. Macarthur joined them he had also enquired as to how long Governor Bligh would be away.

Mrs. Macarthur had quickly interrupted her husband, and explained that she and Mrs. Putland had already discussed the matter. Again Mary smiled. Mr. Macarthur had then changed his questions into a dissertation on the laziness and drunkenness of the small settler.

Mary would have dearly loved to challenge him on this. She thought nostalgically of her mother's drawing room at home in England and the many discussions, the lively arguments on a new book or play, women's rights to education, controversial political matters and so on. How she would have loved to speak her mind.

'I have heard it said, Mr. Macarthur,' she could have said, 'that you contribute greatly to this drunkenness with your monopolies and underhand ways... paying people in wages they can drink, like rum...'

She was the leading lady of the Colony, however, and she knew she must guard her tongue and her argumentative spirit. The teasing remark was left unsaid. She had heard so much of these rages of his, his nick-name 'Jack Bodice,' and his refusal to believe in any opinion other than his own, and his insistence that what was good for John Macarthur was good for the Colony.

And Mary wondered about the three addresses that were read out at the official ceremony. The second two had been so strong, so critical of John

Macarthur, there must have been some truth in them.

She recalled again the first address of welcome, received just days after their official landing and the politeness and pleasantries of their official welcome.

Thinking of the address she could see, in her mind, the faces of the three men who signed it. There was the fair, weak-faced Lieutenant Colonel Johnson, signing for the Military. The attractive but drunken face of Richard Atkins, signing for the Civil Administration, and then the face of the man so much in their thoughts, handsome, arrogant, John Macarthur, signing for the free settlers. How grimly Bligh had smiled as Macarthur read the flowing phrases of welcome.

“Hah!” Bligh had exclaimed later in private. “What honeyed phrases they use. When they find I mean business out here I wonder how long it’ll take them to change their tunes.”

But even Governor Bligh had been surprised, so soon after the first one, to receive the second address of welcome. Mary remembered how John Putland had brought it out to her when she was sitting in the garden.

“Look Mary,” he laughed. “We’re being welcomed again. And a hundred and fifty signatures this time! Not three. Griffin has just counted them!”

Mary remembered the moment well for her husband’s face had been laughing and his eyes had looked clear. Her first thought had not been for the document in his hand, but a prayer of thankfulness that he was looking so well. The climate was, after all, doing him some good.

Then, taking her eyes from his face, she had turned her attention to the piece of parchment in his hand. It was an address of welcome, as the previous one had been, but there was one important difference. This

one stated, in no uncertain terms, that the previous address had certainly not been from 'the free inhabitants of Sydney', and furthermore, had they deputed anyone to sign for them it would not have been John Macarthur.

"See," her husband had continued, "they say it is Macarthur's fault that the price of mutton is so high because he has deliberately withheld a large flock of wethers from the market to obtain any price he likes later on." This was the first official complaint Bligh had received since he landed.

If they had laughed about the second address, Mary remembered that they felt like crying when even a third one arrived. This was from the settlers on the Hawkesbury River, those furthest from the centre of the Colony, and it had been signed by 244 settlers.

Again it declared John Macarthur had no authority to sign on their behalf. The small settlers had almost been ruined by a terrible flood, and yet their poverty had been increased by the traders who offered them extremely low prices for their grain and farm produce and then paid them in rum or useless currency.

The address of welcome then drew up a bill of rights begging the new Governor to restore freedom of trade. They had asked that their goods should be bought and sold in a fair and open market; that monopolies and extortion should be stopped; that the laws of the realm should take their due course, and that justice should be administered by the Courts according to the law of the land; and that they should receive payment for their goods by money or Government orders that would buy what it was worth.

It was pathetic thought Mary that people had to beg to be paid for their

goods and services in money instead of rum or useless goods. And how unbelievable that men such as Macarthur, Lord and Johnston, who lived so graciously, should deliberately work to deprive men of such simple justice.

Papa's reaction to the three addresses had been immediate and typical. He would go at once to visit these settlers, every one of them, and find out the truth of their claims. What had he discovered, wondered Mary? When would he be back? She felt sure it would be soon. Mary's thoughts were interrupted by a knock on the door, and she became conscious that she was still standing, gazing out at the beautiful harbour. "Dinner will be ready soon, Ma'am," Eleanor announced.

Just then there was the noise of a carriage outside, people calling out, someone running down the stairs. Mary leant out the window.

"It's Papa," exclaimed Mary. "Papa and John!" She ran down the stairs and outside, straight into the arms of John. "Let me look at you," she continued, standing away from him for a moment but her smiles changing to a frown. "... but you look so tired."

"Now Mary, don't start worrying. I am tired. Don't forget we've had a long ride today. But I'm well, Mary, the spring weather has done wonders to me. I'm going to get completely better, I feel sure," he assured her, but nonetheless coughed.

"Oh John. I hope so... But where is Papa?"

"He's gone inside, Mary. I don't know how you missed him. Perhaps he went to his study. He and Griffin had a pile of papers. Lord! How dusty one gets on these roads. Your father worked like a madman, Mary. Honestly, I don't know how he does it."

"And you too, I suppose?" asked Mary anxiously.

"No, he's been very good to me, often leaving me with one group of the farmers while he went off to visit some more. Poor Griffin, though. I think he's about dead! You know what your father's like, Mary, 'Take a note of this, Mr. Griffin! Take a note of that!' I honestly don't think the man has had a minute's rest. But what an experience it's been for us all."

"Never mind, he seems to like it." Mary replied. "And what do you think? Is it as bad as we have been told?"

John suddenly grew serious. "Worse. The hardships these people have endured are unbelievable. They can't even get the simplest necessities in life. And they've had no help from the Government at all. I can't understand it. I think King has done nothing at all for the past few years."

"King is a worn out man, John. I have seen them constantly while you have been away, and he is sick and exhausted."

"It needs a strong man, Mary. You have to work with a man to really know him, and my admiration for your father grows every day. I've been telling some of the farmers the same thing too. 'Governor Bligh will see that his orders are carried out,' I say. 'You'll get good money for your crops and tools and goods to carry on with.' You'd have laughed to see me, Mary. A bit of a change from being a sailor." Just then Bligh appeared.

"I'm fine, Mary, absolutely fine. But I've plenty to tell you. Everything we've heard is correct, and I'll not rest until some of these iniquities are set right. Where's Griffin gone? I'll start drafting some new regulations immediately." He started to walk inside again, but Mary ran and stood in front of him.

"You'll do nothing of the sort, Papa. You will rest and talk to me. Then

you'll have a quiet dignified dinner and talk to me some more. I want to hear every single thing the two of you have done, and what you've found out."

"But Mary..."

"There are no buts at all, Papa. I'm the First Lady. You need a rest. Apart from anything else, if you start work straightaway you'll get one of your headaches."

Bligh suddenly smiled, the same sweet smile they all knew so well, so different to his angry outbursts. "You're probably quite right. We'll take dinner and this evening just rest, but tomorrow we start. All of us. We'll get this Colony in good working order, with a fair return for everyone, if it's the last thing we ever do."

Mary looked at her father and smiled, then she laughed.

Chapter Nineteen

The next day the bright blue sky and a perfect climate greeted Mary as she looked out over the harbour. Her father strolled out onto the balcony and joined her.

“Papa, you look well rested... did you know I am taking Tommy and Matt for an outing today? They want to show me some picturesque areas they visit from time to time and introduce me to a friend of theirs...”

“Splendid idea, but be careful and be sure to stay close to the three soldiers I have assigned you all,” Bligh said cautiously.

Even a simple picnic was quite a logistical undertaking for the First Lady of New South Wales. Eleanor appeared on the balcony. “Ma'am, Tommy and Matt have arrived and are waiting in the carriage. I've packed all the lunches, so we're ready to go when you are,” Eleanor said with her usual precision.

James, the driver of the carriage, gave his whip a crisp crack, and the carriage jolted off with Mary and Eleanor sitting opposite Tommy and Matt. The guards opened the imposing iron gates of Government House and the carriage passed through them, followed by three soldiers on horseback.

It was quite a spacious carriage and was comfortable considering the conditions of the roads. But it was very recognisable as the Governor's carriage and so wherever they went people would look and smile, or frown and whisper, depending on their opinions of the new Governor. Others paid no attention at all as they went about their daily business in

the town. Suddenly Tommy and Matt started crouching down and hiding their faces.

“Ma'am, do you mind if we lie on the floor, out of sight?” Tommy whispered self-consciously pushing Matt's head down.

“Whatever for?” Mary inquired looking about her.

“It's the orphanage up ahead, Ma'am... I don't want them to see us.”

“Why ever not?”

“They might call us back, demand we return there. It's not all bad, but we prefer our freedom, Ma'am,” Tommy continued in urgent whispers.

“Of course boys, lie right down on the floor, you'll be fine. James! A bit faster please!”

The driver gave an additional crack of his whip and the horses quickened their pace as the carriage thundered past the orphanage. A group of kids milling around the orphanage door looked up in surprise as their eyes flickered in disbelief at seeing the Governor's carriage go by. But they waved and clapped nonetheless and then fanned the dust away from their faces.

The two boys peaked their heads up; once the orphanage was out of sight they briskly sat back on their seats as if nothing had happened, smiling away at Mary and Eleanor.

“How long do you think it will take before we pick up your friend and reach our picnic site, Tommy?” Mary enquired curiously.

“Oh not long, Ma'am, maybe an hour or so with this carriage, then maybe another half hour after that...”

Mary and Eleanor sat with their backs to the driver and could see Sydney Town disappear into the distance. It was such a small town, thought Mary, and it was only a few weeks ago they were rolling around on the

high seas. Now the swells and waves were replaced by the jolting and bumping of the carriage on the rough dirt road.

Occasionally a few riders on horse would gallop by in the opposite direction, or a bullock dray plodding along towards the town. After an hour, Tommy and Matt started watching out attentively, their eyes searching the road ahead for any sign of their friend.

"I trust he will be clothed..." Mary said, glancing at Eleanor. The two boys responded quickly and defensively.

"Of course, Ma'am! He knows the importance of this! Trust us," Tommy said as Matt crossed his arms in protest. "Coo-ee!" Tommy called out loudly.

"There's someone ahead up there now," the driver called out, giving a backward glance of annoyance to the three soldiers following on horseback.

"Ah yes, Ma'am, that's him!" Tommy said excitedly, as he peered out the carriage window and waved.

Standing next to the road was an aboriginal boy of about ten years old. The carriage came to a standstill. The dust settled and Mary looked out the window.

"That's him, is it?" Mary asked, looking surprised.

The boy stood there nervously. A sight to behold. He was wearing a perfectly clean white shirt and dark brown shorts. His hair was brushed and he was handsome. But he had bare feet. He smiled, revealing bright white teeth.

"Hi Dessy!" Tommy exclaimed as he and Matt leaped out of the carriage and greeted their friend. "I told you we would be here... may we present to you the First Lady of New South Wales?"

“Hullo, Ma'am. It's a pleasure to meet you,” the aboriginal boy said in a carefully rehearsed manner.

“The pleasure is mine...” Mary replied, looking pleased, then glanced at the driver and the three soldiers on horseback watching on. “Please, join us.”

The driver clambered down and opened the carriage door for the boy and he climbed in and sat between Tommy and Matt. Everyone looked at each other smiling, almost in disbelief. Suddenly there was a crack of the whip and the carriage jolted back into motion and the journey continued.

“We have known Dessy for many years now, Ma'am,” Tommy explained, “and we wanted you to meet him.”

“Dessy? That's an interesting name,” Mary said as she admired his looks.

“And what does your name mean...?”

“Desert, Ma'am, it's short for desert... Dessy they call me, Ma'am,” he replied politely.

“Why Desert as a name?” Mary continued inquisitively as the carriage bounced along the increasingly bumpy road.

“Because my dad told me that's where I'll end up living after all our coastal land is taken, Ma'am...” Dessy explained in a matter-of-fact way.

“Oh... I see.” Mary and Eleanor sat in silence.

“What about your parents, where are they?” Eleanor interjected. Dessy looked out the window for a moment.

“My father was shot dead when I was about three, and my mother disappeared about a year later... I've never seen her again... Ma'am...”

“Oh...” Eleanor said, looking at Mary.

“He's an orphan like us, Ma'am,” Tommy said, “but we are friends and

try and help each other..”

“It's the best of both worlds!” Matt suddenly exclaimed, breaking the tension.

The procession continued in the direction of Parramatta, the sunlight flickering through the tall gum trees with the glimmering harbour going in and out of sight. In many ways it was an ideal outing. After a while the sound of singing and laughter could be heard.

“That's strange...” Dessy whispered to Tommy. “Our destination is just up ahead, but it sounds like other people are there...” Mary overheard this.

“I thought we were going to a secluded watering hole for a picnic,” Mary said to the boys.

“Well we did too,” Tommy replied looking rather confused.

“Is this it, Ma'am?” The driver asked, as he turned around and gestured urgently with furrowed eyebrows at the three soldiers following.

“We think so, James,” Mary answered, as she peered out the window.

“Let's have a look anyway.”

But by then the singing was much louder and some of the words were becoming audible. The carriage stopped and everyone alighted. Dessy and the boys led the way up a small ridge as Mary, Eleanor and the soldiers followed. They could now clearly hear the words.

“Bligh, old bugger Bligh, Bounty Bligh...

Foul mouthed captain, flogger, tyrant...”

And then the singing of the chorus, with much worse to come, was loud and clear.

“Mutiny, mutiny, mutiny!” Followed by uproarious laughter.

They all reached the top of the small ridge and stood in disbelief at the

scene before them. There was, indeed, a picturesque watering hole, but it was occupied by about ten to fifteen completely drunk and naked men partaking in debauchery with a few convict women. It was clear they were men from the New South Wales Corps because their uniforms, red coats and hats, were strewn around the place along with empty kegs of rum and some horses tethered further away.

Mary had never dared to believe such a sight could be imagined. Even her worst experiences of the filthy convict hulks in England didn't compare to this. This sight was truly horrible. It was debased; 'a sink of infamy'.

"I'm terribly sorry, Ma'am," Tommy immediately pleaded to Mary. "We had no idea of this!" Tommy and Matt looked angrily at Dessy who looked like he would cry as the people below, quite unaware of being watched, sucked on rum and cavorted merrily. Even the flogging scars on the few convict women were blatantly visible.

Suddenly a loud gunshot rang out across the watering hole. One of the three soldiers guarding Mary and the entourage had fired a warning shot over the heads of the drunken party below them in and around the water.

There was silence. The singing stopped and the rum-drunk revelers looked up in surprise.

"Don't anyone move!" yelled the soldier angrily at the chaos below them.

"Okay, Ma'am, let's get out of here right now..." He commanded as the three soldiers pointed their bayonets at the party and retreated towards the carriage. Within seconds they were back inside the carriage and it was thundering its way back towards Sydney town with the three soldiers on horseback guarding them looking over their shoulders.

Mary was visibly shaken, not just by the way the carriage jolted them around, but from what she had seen and heard at the watering hole. They all sat in silence with the three boys averting any eye contact. Mary had even recognised some of the men at that brief, terrible scene, as the soldiers at the official ceremony that marked their arrival at Government House. It was much worse than she could ever have dared to think in her worst nightmares.

After half an hour they all began to regain their composure as Mary rearranged her gloves and bombazine shawl. The three boys started whispering to themselves and finally Tommy looked up at Mary.

“Ma'am, I'm terribly sorry... can we drop Dessy off here so he can return to his tribe, please Ma'am?”

Mary was in another world. “Oh, of course, sorry boys. James! Please stop here.” The carriage stopped in a cloud of dust and Dessy got out quickly and vanished into the bush, then returned within seconds and thrust his white shirt through the window to Tommy and then vanished again. The carriage jolted off and Mary and Eleanor stared at Tommy as he folded the clean and pure white shirt.

“Oh, I'm sorry Tommy,” Mary sympathised warmly. “You obviously went to so much trouble to make this outing a success. How was Dessy to know these terrible people would be there? We'll have another outing another day. Why not invite Dessy to Government House one day?”

Tommy blinked in surprise, but inside he wondered if it was such a good idea. Mary, too, was quick to reconsider her invitation. After all, the resentment of her father as Governor was very strong in many quarters and she had just witnessed the strength of it.

Mary didn't want to dwell on this so she allowed her mind to wander off

to the more interesting ideas she had about creating a large park alongside Government House. She had consulted Thomas Alford, the head gardener, and together they had drawn up a design with paths and a carriageway around the point and the next cove with a variety of flowering trees and shrubs. Extra convicts would be employed for the road works and landscaping. It would be marvelous with stone seats and cedar benches for anyone wanting to admire the view of the harbour. The settlement of Sydney came into clear view and the two boys asked if they might be dropped off outside town. Mary thanked them again for their efforts, gave them most of the unopened picnic lunch, and suggested they drop by in a few days to help with the garden, if they wished.

Soon Government House itself loomed up in front of them as the carriage passed through the gates. Inside its confines Mary felt much safer. It had taken her awhile to get used to her position as First Lady.

Four or five nights a week there were dinner parties for captains of visiting ships, officers of the Corps and various free settlers. And after dinner she played the piano and with ports and cigars the guests would discuss the issues of the day in the Colony and the world; Napoleon's conquests and how power was shifting from the navy to the military to defeat him on land; the local orphanage; the convict population and easing their workload; John Macarthur; and finally the ever present hostility towards Governor Bligh because he was reigning in the excesses of the New South Wales Corps, which is why he was appointed Governor in the first place.

Throughout all of this, however, Mary's husband was still coughing and seemed unwell. Putland's doctor, Dr. Harris, kept prescribing fresh air

and plenty of rest, which did little to help. Then Governor Bligh dismayed Mary by putting Putland in command of the Porpoise and sending him on a round trip to Norfolk Island. There were orders from England that the Norfolk Islanders should relocate to Van Dieman's Land. It was the last thing Putland needed.

On his return several weeks later Mary was shocked to see his condition. Putland could hardly walk and was put to bed. This time when he coughed he spat up globules of bright red blood. Finally Dr. Harris announced he had consumption, or tuberculosis, which everyone guessed but feared to say for over a year. Mary cancelled all her engagements and dinner parties at Government House were scaled down and she concentrated her efforts on caring for her ill husband.

Governor Bligh continued to cause resentment in the Colony. An anonymous epigram was circulated, 'O tempora, o mores, Is there no CHRISTIAN in New South Wales to put a stop to the tyranny of the Governor?' And in an act of obvious provocation, John Macarthur had a wine still shipped in from England, which Bligh had impounded.

But in all of this there were moments of relief and happiness. In September a parcel arrived from Mary's mother and sisters. It was a beautiful white muslin dress, cut in the latest London style, slim and high waisted. Mary lifted out the layers of white lace and the form fitting undergarment was cut like trousers.

"Pantaloons!" Mary exclaimed in excitement, as she showed them to John, who was sitting up in bed.

"You must wear them to church this Sunday," he suggested.

The day was bright and sunny as Mary and the Governor arrived by carriage at the stone church. Mary proudly strolled down the aisle as the

congregation, including many from the New South Wales Corps, rose to their feet. No sooner had Mary and Bligh sat down on the front pew than a murmur rippled around the church. To Mary's surprise she quite clearly heard some comments from behind her.

"Look who's wearing the trousers now!" was one comment heard by everyone. This was followed by laughter and sniggering. "Bitch fashion," was another. Catcalls and commotion spread around the congregation amidst calls for "Shh!" and "be silent" from the more responsible free settlers and serious churchgoers. It all became louder and louder until Mary fled into the vestry in tears and sat down with her head in her hands. Bligh followed her into the room angrily slamming the door. It opened again and Mr. Fulton appeared as the commotion crescendoed. He closed the door, muffling it a bit.

"Do you want to go home, dear?" Bligh asked sympathetically.

"No, no, Papa... just ask Mr. Fulton to start the service," Mary sobbed.

"Yes, of course. I do apologise, Mrs. Putland..." Mr. Fulton said as he and Bligh re-entered the main hall, leaving Mary to ponder her new dress and pantaloons. The muffled words of the Book of Common Prayer soon soothed the atmosphere and the Sunday morning church service continued without issue.

At the end of the Divine service Mary listened as the congregation left. She borrowed a cape from Mrs. Fulton and waited until the last of the soldiers had been dismissed before making her way to the carriage with her father. She felt ashamed and humiliated.

Once back at Government House, Eleanor helped Mary undress in front of her ailing husband as she recounted every horrible moment of the church service.

“They simply don't appreciate the latest fashions from London!” Mary lamented as she changed into a more comfortable blue skirt. She then sat down and penned a letter to her Mama and sisters about the dress, without mentioning the reaction.

“... it was altogether different and superior to anything of this kind that had been seen in this country. All I can do for you in return my dear Mama is to be very particular in collecting shells and everything I can think to please you.”

Putland would have loved to have strolled along the beautiful beaches in and around Sydney with Mary as they did on many occasions collecting shells and conches for her mother, but it was not possible now. And then there were the concerns about Papa.

“... in general he gives great satisfaction but there are a few that we suspect wish to oppose him... Mr. Macarthur is one of the party and the others are the Military Officers, but they are all invited to the house and treated with the same politeness as usual...”

Mary looked up at her husband as he had another coughing fit. In her mind she knew she was becoming a twenty-four-year-old widow.

“... I wish I could tell you that Putland is as well as my father. Since you last heard from us he has been constantly ailing and has had every symptom of a consumption and for these two months past he has been confined to his room...”

This letter left Sydney by the Duke of Portland, but would not reach home until the Easter of 1808. Mary thought about what her mother had warned when she first announced she was to marry John Putland, and realised what her mother would be thinking in nine months time when she got the letter.

Putland lost more weight. Even his small excursions downstairs to listen to Mary play the piano to him, Bach and Mendelssohn being their favourites, and short visits by Tommy, Matt and Dessy, who had thrown caution to the wind and worked one or two half days a week in the garden, were curtailed when Dr. Harris warned them all to 'prepare ourselves for his dissolution.'

Despite consumption's last 'animated glow', Putland's gasps grew desperate. On January 4, 1808, his eyes flickered no more and it was all over. Mary's father tried his best to console her, but she was not interested to hear that Providence might have its reasons. She really longed to be hugged by her mother.

Governor Bligh gave Putland a military funeral with full honours. Navy personnel, officers of the New South Wales Corps, attended in full dress uniform and the coffin was draped in a Naval flag. Many close friends from outlying farms and the Government House staff were the chief mourners. Mr. Fulton spoke of the resurrection and the life and everyone sang, 'There is a green hill faraway'.

John Putland had yearned to visit Ireland one last time but it wasn't to be.

Chapter Twenty

A most gratifying tribute arrived from the settlers of Hawkesbury to Governor Bligh and hundreds had signed it. Their testimonial praised his wisdom and salutary government.

“... the present flourishing state of this country, rapidly growing in population, opulence and all improvements calculated by a wise and patriotic government to make a large Colony of people happy and rich in all their internal resources...”

It was a wonderful endorsement for Bligh. But in all the sadness that surrounded the passing of John Putland, friends and staff had played down, or not even mentioned, the ever growing hostility amongst the military officers and most of the influential people in town towards Governor William Bligh.

Nearly everyday there were violent confrontations between drunken soldiers and heavy-handed constables. Within days of Putland's burial, John Macarthur was making trouble at the church right next to Putland's grave. He claimed he had the right to churchyard land. And his anger at the confiscation of his beloved wine-still had fermented to the extent that a warrant was issued against him.

January, 1808, went from bad to worse. It culminated with the officers of the Corps holding a big mess dinner and Governor Bligh had naively and stupidly agreed to their request for spirits for the function to be supplied from the City of Edinburgh moored near the wharf. He was trying to appease them but the dinner seemed like a rallying call for

action.

The next day John Macarthur faced a court where soldiers lined the walls to support him. By mid-morning the judge advocate had rushed to Government House to report that Macarthur had 'swayed the weak-minded with his eloquence', and that the court had broken up in pandemonium.

After much discussion, Bligh issued a warrant entitling the Provost Marshall, Mr. Gore, to arrest Macarthur. This was carried through and John Macarthur was safely confined in a town cell, or so they hoped, and law and order was restored. But from that cell Macarthur plotted his revenge.

In her mourning, still in black, Mary spent many hours in her garden. It was a relief for her to have Tommy, Matt and Dessy visit and ask to resume their part-time work there. They seemed such sensible and down to earth young boys.

At one stage in the day they stopped to have some lemonade offered by Eleanor. Dessy approached Mary carefully.

"Excuse me, Ma'am... can you explain something to me please...?"

"Yes, of course, Dessy, what is it?" Mary answered, happy for any distraction from her sad thoughts.

"When Tommy and Matt call out to me in the bush, they call 'Coo-ee', as you know, Ma'am. But Tommy claims there is another meaning for 'coo', it's a takeover..."

"Yes, an army take over, a coup ...Ma'am," Tommy claimed attentively, "Isn't that correct?"

"Well, yes... that's right, a coup d'etat, or putsch..." Mary replied in a puzzled way. "Why ever do you ask this question?"

“Matt and I were in a Tavern at The Rocks yesterday, Ma'am, and there was a lot of drinking and loud shouting as usual, but in one corner I overhead three soldiers talking about a 'coup' against the Government, Ma'am...”

“Which government?” Mary asked, blinking her eyes in disbelief.

“Your father's government, the New South Wales government, Ma'am, that's what they said, I heard it clearly, didn't we Matt?” Tommy said defiantly as Matt nodded earnestly in agreement.

Mary had been in another world with the illness and death of her husband. Suddenly a strange awareness overtook her. “Really? Is that true?” She looked out over the still harbour and to the few ships moored there and whispered under her breath, “another mutiny for... Papa.”

At six o'clock that evening Governor Bligh, the First Lady, and a larger group than usual, sat down for dinner at Government House. But it was interrupted by a knock on the door. A document had arrived stating Major Johnston's order for John Macarthur to be released from his cell. Bligh was furious.

One of the dinner guests, William Gore, had gone to the doorstep and reported that he could clearly see activity near the barracks.

“Papa, I think this could be the military coup d'etat I warned you of...” Mary said to her father as everyone stood up in alarm.

“But this can't be... I run the place...” Bligh replied in surprise.

“You must hide your papers Papa,” Mary urged. “Hurry.”

Bligh disappeared into another room. Henry Fulton and Mary rushed upstairs and looked out the bedroom window to get a better view.

“Jubb!” Bligh yelled out from his study. “Assemble our horses!”

People were massing along Bridge Street. Drumbeats sounded

ominously and the military band began to play 'The British Grenadiers'. Suddenly the New South Wales Corps swung into action.

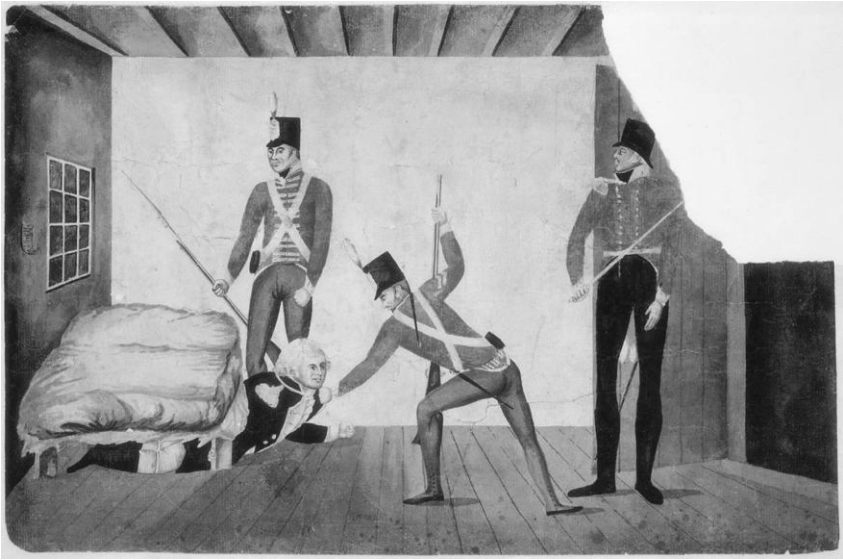
Mary felt faint. A distant 'coo-ee' distracted her momentarily. She looked over to a tall gum tree and could see Tommy, Matt and Dessy perched on a high branch, silhouetted against the glowing red of the early evening. She waved urgently for them to go away, but strangely it gave her a strength she hadn't felt before.

Four hundred men of the Corps, muskets loaded and bayonets drawn, marched briskly up the hill and reached the gates of Government House. To Mary's horror, the sentries deserted their posts and fled. The gates rattled and swayed as the soldiers pushed and shoved at them. Mary located her parasol and rushed down the stairs. Henry Fulton followed without quite the same enthusiasm. The gates burst open and the four hundred soldiers stormed through them into the Government House compound. Mary confronted them angrily at the steps of the front door.

"Scum! Rogues! Rebels!" Mary yelled. "Fight me first!"

Ten of the soldiers ascended the steps with one over enthusiastic, overweight and sweating soldier at the front. Mary lunged forward and whacked him over the face with her parasol as hard as she could. He looked stunned and lost his balance. Mary then pushed the sharp end of her parasol into his chest causing him to topple backwards knocking over the nine soldiers behind him like dominoes. They lay sprawled out on the path at the bottom of the steps.

From their vantage point atop a nearby gum tree, Tommy, Matt and Dessy cheered. A pause followed as the soldiers in close proximity stared in disbelief at the First Lady of New South Wales and they didn't quite



The arrest of Governor Bligh. A propaganda cartoon around 1810 designed to depict him as a coward.

know what to do.

Lieutenant Cadwallader suddenly broke the silence. “Get up! We’ve got four hundred soldiers! It’s one woman with a parasol. Step aside Mrs. Putland! Charge!” He bellowed as the soldiers on the ground scrambled to their feet and the rest stormed up the steps pushing Mary aside. The front door was smashed with rifle butts, the window panes shattered, and they gained entry.

Henry Fulton tried to pull Mary aside but she continued thrashing her parasol at the soldiers as they thrust past. Within seconds Government House was swarming with soldiers. They tramped in and out of rooms, up and down stairs, in search of the Governor while officers collected every official document they could find.

But there was no sign of Bligh.

Finally Sergeant-Major Whittle noticed a locked door to a servant's attic room at the very top of the house. He kicked it open with his boot and the door flung off its hinges revealing Governor William Bligh standing there in full dress uniform with his medal dangling from the Battle of Copenhagen. They were taken back by his splendour.

"You could have knocked," Bligh said calmly.

But soon his temper exploded. From downstairs they could hear the yelling and swearing as Bligh was bundled down the stairs and frog marched into the drawing room where Johnston had him and all the guests arrested.

"This is treason!" Governor Bligh screamed angrily as his guests were manhandled out of the house leaving only Bligh, his daughter Mary and the servants. It was still very noisy with the rebels outside laughing and yelling.

"Another mutiny for Captain Bligh!

Where's the launch now?

Three cheers for Fletcher Christian!"

Suddenly John Macarthur entered the house with several other civilian rebels. He looked proud and arrogant. He smirked when he saw Bligh. "Confiscate the keys," he ordered loudly and Bligh's office was locked. "You're a goat in sheep's clothing, Macarthur," Bligh responded disdainfully.

"How droll," Macarthur replied looking him up and down. "Post five sentinels at the front door and gates, the rest of you follow me." The remaining soldiers and rebels left the house and the four hundred soldiers marched back down the hill.

By ten o'clock it was all over. But the celebrations erupted all over the

town and soldiers lit bonfires, sang, danced and drank. Effigies of the Governor were burnt. Vigilantes harassed anyone loyal to Bligh.

Macarthur toured the streets like a hero and Johnston took the title of Lieutenant Governor and began the task of restoring order. Governor Bligh and Mary remained under house arrest.

By mid-February the town's drunken spree had come to an end and people got back to work. Major Johnston announced the appointment of John Macarthur as Colonial Secretary, the chief authority in New South Wales.

Mary Putland could never have imagined such a change in her life. First of all her beloved husband, John, had died and soon after her father was under house arrest and Government House ceased to be a centre of government. It was virtually deserted. There was nothing to do.

Bligh was certain the authorities would act as soon as they found out. But news took eight or nine months to get to London. He hoped to see battleships charging through the heads, cannons blazing, to subdue the rebel Corps. Perhaps the Governor-General of India could raise a force, or Lieutenant Collins in Hobart. But nobody came to his rescue.

"God this place is indifferent," Mary said to her maid, Eleanor, as they contented themselves in the Government House garden.

"Well I'm just thankful we weren't flogged," Eleanor replied knowing full well the conditions of other convicts.

So they wore old hats, stout boots and torn mantles, and filled their days working there. Bligh and his loyal assistant, Mr. Griffin, busied themselves writing dispatches to London. At nights Mary played her piano without an audience. There were no more dinner parties and house arrest made William Bligh moody and indecisive.

Finally something did happen. Colonel Foveaux's ship the Lady Sinclair sailed into the harbour. He had decided to stay in Sydney and not go to Norfolk Island and he would assume control of the Colony until His Majesty's pleasure was known. Macarthur and Johnston would take no further part in administration. It was a bit of a surprise, especially since Foveaux had a much worse reputation than Macarthur or Johnston combined.

Naval power was all Bligh had. On land he was under house arrest but at sea he was still Commodore and Commander-in-Chief and he sent Foveaux a note saying he wished "to go to England immediately in command of the ship Porpoise, having my broad pennant, which is at the peril of anyone to tarnish or deprive me of." But then the next moment Bligh would change his mind and refuse to leave until he was re-instated as Governor. It was as if house arrest was starting to affect his mind.

The third Christmas at Government House was a dismal affair. Bligh, Mr. Griffin and Mary were weary of confinement. But worse was to come. After nearly a year, on January 30, Bligh was taken out of Government House and put in confinement in the military barracks in town. Mary joined him in sympathy as a protest. Foveaux began putting much more pressure on Bligh to return to England and just wanted to get rid of him from New South Wales. Finally Bligh agreed and on March 17, the Porpoise weighed anchor and sailed out the Heads. Mary was so happy. She was returning to London to live with her mother and sisters. And the sailing was good with warm temperatures and plenty of breeze and no trace of the seasickness that plagued her on the Lady Sinclair. The food was excellent with fresh beef, fruit and vegetables.

Everything seemed fine until they reached the sheltered waters of Port Stephens, further north, where Bligh ordered the anchor to be dropped.

Chapter Twenty One

"Papa, why have we dropped anchor here?" Mary asked her father as he paced the deck.

"I was appointed Governor of New South Wales and I intend to be Governor!" he replied firmly. He signalled to a young sixteen year old midshipman to see him. "Collins! Captain Porteous informs me you're Lieutenant Governor David Collin's son, is that so?"

"Yes, Sir," the lad replied eagerly.

"Well you'll see your father soon... we're sailing to Hobart Town," Bligh announced and three days later the Porpoise weighed anchor and sailed south. After a few days of heavy seas across Bass Strait they entered the calm waters of the Derwent estuary.

Governor Collins was soon on board, more to see his son than to welcome Bligh. And then they all adjourned to dry land. But Hobart Town was not a congenial place to be. The cold winds of April blew up from the Antarctic and there was snow on the nearby mountains.

Governor Collins paraded around arm-in-arm with a flame haired sixteen-year-old lass from Norfolk Island who irritated Mary with her silly laugh.

In fact Hobart had been over-run by the relocation of settlers and convicts from Norfolk Island. The newcomers outnumbered the original settlers. It was a bleak, unforgiving place. Bligh, however, could clearly recall his first visit to Hobart many years before.

"On my first tour of the Derwent with Captain James Cook," Bligh

announced proudly as they sat down for dinner with Governor Collins, "we planted Van Dieman's Land's first apple trees."

That was about the best of it. Collins clearly resented having a man like William Bligh loitering around the end of the globe when he was supposed to be on his way back to England.

And even though Mary took up residence in Hobart's Government House, Collins was being provocative by not giving her protection from a guard, so Bligh, aware of his various enemies, insisted they live on the ship. And soon after, Collins forbade any contact with the former Governor or his family from anyone and even buying provisions became almost impossible.

A long standoff began and Bligh set up a one ship blockade. Then things took an appalling turn for the worse.

George Collins, the son of the Governor, had a night out on the town and returned to the ship drunk. The next morning, when he was called to take his watch, he was still drunk and with a bad hangover had made an insolent remark to Captain Porteous. Bligh was up early and decided to intervene.

"Drunkenness and insolence won't be tolerated young Collins by anyone," Bligh said firmly, "Twenty-four lashes." The punishment took place before noon. "Stay in your cabin Mary," Bligh instructed his daughter. "You won't want to see this..."

"He's barely sixteen years old!" Mary protested.

"But he's old enough for the navy, he's derelict in his duty, so stay out of it!" Bligh replied harshly. Mary returned to her cabin and shut the door, but she could still hear the punishment. The boy remained silent for the first few lashes, but then the groaning began followed by a continuous



Lachlan Macquarie 5th Governor of New South Wales

howl. He was a whimpering wreck by the time he was carried down for Dr.

Macmillan's attention.

Mary stayed in her cabin all afternoon. Finally she joined her father in his cabin for supper.

"Who wouldn't prefer a voyage without punishment?" Bligh said, breaking the silence in the cabin, as he ate his bread and

soup. "But the law of the sea..."

That was enough. Mary exploded in anger, and when ignited, a temper far worse than even Bligh's. She grabbed the Bible on the shelf and threw it at her father's head, whacking him across the temple. He looked shocked.

"Don't even say it!" Mary shouted. "Your law of the sea is lamentable! We're stuck in this miserable place and all you can do is beat the Governors young son." And then she burst into tears and swept her bowl of soup off the table. Mr. Griffin remained silent.

Days passed, then weeks. When ships arrived from Sydney or Calcutta, the Porpoise signalled them to pull alongside. Bligh and Captain Porteous demanded access to mail and newspapers, while the purser negotiated to buy stores. It was freezing cold. Fifteen of the crew went down with bronchitis and one died of pneumonia.

They seemed doomed to an endless winter; a frosty wilderness of

boredom. Not only had the world forgotten them, but Mary began to admit to herself that her father's conduct defied logic.

At last some news filtered through. The captain of a ship from the Cape of Good Hope had heard that the New South Wales Corps was to be recalled back to England and in its place would be the 73rd Regiment; a fleet of eight ships under the command of Colonel Lachlan Macquarie. But would Bligh or Macquarie be Governor? Bligh estimated that Macquarie would arrive in Sydney in February 1810. Then on New Year's Day a trading vessel arrived from Rio with news that Macquarie and his fleet had called there three months ago.

"They're well ahead of schedule," Bligh confided to Mr. Griffin and Mary. "We must sail immediately", he continued in a mild panic.

Sails were inspected, cargo stowed, charts consulted and on January 3, the Porpoise set sail into huge seas for the Colony Bligh once governed. After a few days they approached the Sydney Heads and the calm waters of a beautifully fine and warm January day in New South Wales. At first they anchored in a sheltered bay with cannons at the ready in case of hostile fire.

Instead a small boat approached with a friendly envoy. So friendly, in fact, that the young officer who boarded the Porpoise was a certain Captain Colden Antill, Governor Macquarie's aide de camp, who, as it was soon revealed, was Mary's cousin. Mary was delighted.

So they weighed anchor and continued their journey to Sydney Town. On this short leg Bligh fell silent as Antill described in glowing terms the character of Macquarie.

"He's Scottish. Tall, in his late forties, a most capable officer, held in high regard by all ranks," Antill explained enthusiastically. "He has

tremendous plans for the Colony; repairing roads, a new hospital, schools..." His voice trailed off as he noticed how solemn Bligh appeared. "The 73rd are a tough, no-nonsense regiment of Highlanders," he continued, "they'll sweep aside the New South Wales Corps and ship them back to England. The government wants to set up a great nation here."

There were so many tall ships in Sydney Cove that the Porpoise had to moor close to Bennelong Point. Then a barge approached with a man in uniform of the 73rd Regiment. He was a tall handsome man and about to change Mary's life. He stepped on board and gazed in a friendly manner at Mary.

"Ah, good," Antill said happily, "it's Colonel O'Connell, the Lieutenant-Governor." Maurice O'Connell bowed and introduced himself.

"The Governor's compliments, Your Excellency, and to you, Mrs. Putland. I've come to welcome you on shore among friends today. Governor Macquarie has sent word to the regiment, and your formal reception is planned for tomorrow morning," he said politely as he gazed at Mary again.

"Would it be possible for us to walk around on the shore please, Lieutenant O'Connell?" Mary asked as she glanced at the freshly painted Government House in the distance. "Will it be safe for us?"

"You have my word, Mrs. Putland," O'Connell assured her. "In fact I will assign some of my own men to your personal guard...." Once again he gazed at Mary, and then his eyes brightened further. "Your Excellency, may I persuade you and your beautiful daughter to dine with me tonight on board here?"

Chapter Twenty Two

Government Wharf was much the same as Mary stepped onto dry land. It was strange to think that nearly a year ago she was expecting to step onto the shores of England, but instead was back in Sydney and strolling towards Government House.

Mary stopped to look at her garden and immediately became lost in that world she lived under house arrest where she spent so much time in the garden filling in her time. It was still in very good order and a lot of things had grown. She wondered how Eleanor was. Suddenly the spell was broken.

“Commodore Bligh!” came the new voice. “We are so pleased to see your safe return,” said the new Governor. Standing in front of Mary on the veranda was Lachlan Macquarie and his young wife, Elizabeth.

Macquarie was tall with dark eyes expressing energy and his wife was also tall, warm, had pale eyes and a fringe of curls. Both Bligh and Macquarie had strong Scottish accents and quickly adjourned to the study for talks. After small talk between Elizabeth and Mary, Bligh suddenly returned from the study looking disappointed.

“What's happened?” Mary quizzed her father.

“I'm two weeks late...” Bligh whispered to his daughter. “Macquarie was instructed to swear me in for one day then I would swear him in as new Governor. But they went ahead without me...”

“Oh well”, Mary replied sympathetically, “what could you do in one day anyway, Papa? And it's just another ceremony...”

“Indeed,” Bligh said, as he looked around the harbour. “The fact is Macquarie has the job. So let's return to our boat.”

In the afternoon the Government House chef arrived on board the Porpoise with the evening dinner and made the best he could with the facilities. It was a perfectly still, flat, warm evening on the harbour and a table was set up on deck with candles and trimmings and a vase of frangipani flowers. Just before dinner, Maurice O'Connell arrived on a small boat and everyone sat down for dinner.

The meal was perfect. The very best French wines were poured, “Snatched from Napoleons own vineyard,” O'Connell confided. Fresh oysters and toast were served followed by roast beef and potatoes and fresh beans and pumpkin pulled from the Government House vegetable garden and finally Yorkshire pudding. The view of Sydney in the evening was exquisite and Mary was swept off her feet by the Colonel. When he looked at Mary and smiled, there were deep creases around his hazel-green eyes and his long sombre face was transformed.

“My friends tell me you're an accomplished pianist, Mrs. Putland,” he said then asked, “I wonder when we will have the pleasure of hearing you play...?”

“Oh really, I'm out of practice... and my piano is all packed up in readiness for our journey home...” replied Mary as her voice trailed off. She looked at O'Connell wistfully. His attentive expression was framed by the scenery of Sydney Town behind him.

“Oh... that's right... the journey home...” He answered looking disappointed.

“You came out here via Rio, I believe?” Mary asked the Colonel to

change the subject.

“Ah! Rio!” He smiled, glancing at Bligh. “You must know it well yourself, Sir... but it was all new to me, despite my time in the Caribbean, fighting the French in the perilous Dominica.”

They all chatted about Bligh's time in Jamaica, St. Vincent, Barbados, Trinidad and Martinique, his bread fruit voyage on the Providence, and the Battle of Copenhagen. O'Connell was careful to compliment Bligh at every turn, more so to impress his daughter than the former Governor himself. Finally the best port in the Colony was served and Bligh, Colden and Mr. Griffin strolled to the other end of the boat for cigars leaving Colonel O'Connell and Mary alone.

The ship was motionless. The wine and the relief of arriving back in Sydney to such a warm welcome had intoxicated Mary. The evening was so perfect. The evening lights glittered.

“Your reputation as the woman who stood up to four hundred soldiers at the overthrow of the government has reached England,” O'Connell said quietly to Mary. “Everybody here has an enormous respect for you...”

“Oh... it was just a spur of the moment reaction, really... Colonel,” Mary replied humbly. “I didn't really think...”

“I trust you're not armed with your parasol now....” O'Connell said intimately as he suddenly leant over and kissed her on the lips.

Their embrace was interrupted by footsteps and the sound of oars rowing.

“Ah, Colonel O'Connell, your boat is here as arranged to return you to the wharf,” Bligh said as he peered over the side of the Porpoise to watch the small launch arrive and avoid letting on what he had just witnessed. O'Connell stood up awkwardly and smiled.

“Perfect timing... Well! I guess I will have the pleasure of seeing you tomorrow for your reception at Government House...” he said as he bowed and kissed the hand of Mary and then nodded to Bligh.

Mary returned quickly to her cabin with her palms sweating and her heart beating fast. She parted the small curtain of the cabin window and looked out to see the boat being rowed towards the wharf with Colonel O'Connell standing at the stern as the reflection of the moon flickered off the puddles created by the oars plying the water.

The next morning the 73rd regiment, commanded by Colonel O'Connell, lined up on one side of the wharf, with the men of the Corps on the other. Bligh and Mary were treated to a thirteen-gun salute with drums, fifes and bugles. In contrast to the 1806 arrival, only a small number of private citizens and free settlers came to watch the pageantry as Governor Macquarie and Bligh led the procession up to Government House followed by Mary and Elizabeth. At one stage Mary's eyes opened wide as she caught a glimpse of Tommy, Matt and Dessy waving to them. The reception went well with new acquaintances laughing and chatting around Mary. Government House was a cheerful place and there was an enormous atmosphere of goodwill and hopes for a bright future.

A small cottage, a square brick building with four rooms and a semi-detached kitchen, was organised on the Tank Stream near Government House for Bligh and Mary. Mr. Jubb, their old and loyal steward, engaged a cook and personal maid for Mary and her piano was unloaded.

“We don't need anything large, do we Papa?” Mary said enthusiastically as she tinkered on the piano keyboard. “It is so good to be on shore again...”

“Governor Macquarie has assigned us guards,” Bligh said, “otherwise I wouldn't leave the ship until the men of the Corps are sent home, which will be soon.”

The Reverend Samuel Marsden knocked on the door on his return from England with news about Betsy and the girls.

“Mrs. Bligh and your sisters are in excellent health,” he reported. Mary felt homesick as Marsden continued. “They were terribly upset to hear the news of your husband's death and Papa's overthrow as Governor by the traitors... and oh dear, your father was slandered by that rogue Captain Short at his court martial...” Bligh bristled. His anger was obvious. “But Betsy is in constant contact with Sir Joseph Banks... he is a real friend to you.”

No sooner had Reverend Marsden left than there was another knock on the door. Mary opened it and to her surprise who should be standing there but Tommy, Matt and Dessy.

“What an absolute pleasure!” Mary exclaimed as she hugged them all.

“Come in at once and sit down!” The boys were so well dressed for this visit.

“We heard you had arrived back in Sydney, Ma'am,” Tommy explained.

“And we couldn't believe it because we thought you had returned to England forever...”

“No, Papa sailed us to Van Dieman's Land instead! It seemed like forever there,” Mary said laughing. “Why didn't you come and see me after the ceremony when we arrived? I saw you there.”

“Ma'am, we were advised to stay away by our family,” Dessy replied politely.

“Family?” Mary asked curiously.

"Yes! A family on a farm in the Hawkesbury has taken us all in!"

Tommy said proudly. "They are great admirers of you, Sir, and wanted to look after us." They all looked at Bligh. "We work on their farm and have our own small bungalow at the back... we can come and go as we like and we get paid!"

"Well, well, well, what luck for you," Bligh said, glancing at Mary.

"There are many good people out there... when Mary and I return to England, we will know you are in safe hands..."

"But you can't go to England, Ma'am!" Matt suddenly blurted out.

"Colonel O'Connell wants to marry you!"

There was a long pause. Mary blinked her eyes in embarrassment.

"Whatever do you mean?" Mary asked, as she gave a sideways look at her father. Suddenly he stood up with his lips pursed.

"I must go to my meeting with the Governor," he announced abruptly, as he headed for the door. "We have arrangements to be made for our journey back home to our family... Mary's dear mother, and sisters... in England," he mumbled gruffly as the door slammed behind him.

The three boys looked confused. "How do you know this?" Mary asked urgently. The boys glanced at each other.

"Well, I thought everyone one knew, Ma'am..." Tommy replied defensively. "Isn't it so?"

"No! It's not so. I'm returning to England in March, I'm sorry to say. I will miss you all a lot," Mary announced as she rubbed her forehead. After the boys left, Mary sat down and thought about this new man in her life, Maurice O'Connell. Since their first strange encounter on the Porpoise on the night she had returned to Sydney, she had seen a lot of him, but only to talk to at social occasions. He was forty-two years old.

His voice was beguiling, with only the faintest trace of an Irish accent, plus a hint of French precision. Everything about him was gentleman like.

At one of the dinner parties Bligh and Mary hosted at their small cottage on the Tank Stream, O'Connell had approached Mary after she finished playing the piano to the guests. They chatted quietly about their previous lives.

"I studied in Paris for a time after leaving school," Colonel O'Connell confided. "It was before the Revolution, of course, and later I went onto military school. I served with a French émigré brigade under the Duke of Brunswick, and then I followed my uncle, Count Daniel O'Connell, into the Irish Brigade of the British army..."

"I've always wanted to visit Paris..." Mary mentioned. "And then what?" "Well after that, the West Indies..." he replied with a smile. "And I know a lot about your family history... anyone who has sailed knows the various stories of your father... but I am sure he will approve of my plans..."

Mary remembered those words clearly. She was too intrigued with his mannerisms and charm to explore what he had meant by 'plans'. Maybe now, having heard this gossip from the boys, did she have an inkling of those plans.

But then there was her father's attitude. For him the Irish meant trouble-makers, revolutionaries, Papist knaves... and an Irish name like O'Connell was a real stumbling block, and he had studied in France; the inescapable inference was that he was a Roman Catholic.

The next opportunity Mary had to meet Colonel O'Connell was at a picnic organised by the Governor to see the progress of Lady

Macquarie's Chair. It was hand carved by convicts into sandstone rock in the shape of a bench and faced north-east towards Port Denison and the Pacific Ocean.

"My wife mentioned she thought this position was perfect to sit and relax and watch for ships from England sail down the harbour," the Governor announced to their group of friends, "and I will name it Lady Macquaries Chair!" They all applauded graciously and Elizabeth Macquarie laughed and nodded and the late afternoon picnic began on a sunny day overlooking the picturesque harbour.

There was plenty of news to talk about. Lieutenant Governor Collins had suddenly died in Hobart Town at the age of only fifty-three. And the soldiers of the New South Wales Corps had begun boarding their transports along with their wives and children for their return to England. But Colonel O'Connell had become the centre of attention when it was announced he would be in charge of setting up a race meeting for Sydney. The Governor was quick to champion a spring racing carnival.

"The town needs some big popular events," the Governor said agreeing with O'Connell. "Not those degrading sports like cock-fighting I hear about, or men at The Rocks carrying human jockeys on their backs in sprint races, or worse, inciting drunken Aborigines to fight one another..."

The conversation went quiet. There were still so many problems with the Colony, Mary thought to herself. And gambling wouldn't help.

Nonetheless, the picnic was great fun and as the guests wandered home Mary sat on the unfinished sandstone bench alone looking at the ships moored around the harbour and pondered her journey home. Just then she was startled to hear the familiar voice of Colonel O'Connell.

"Mary, may I join you?" He said as he appeared from around the path. "Yes of course!" she replied, moving along a bit for him to sit down. "It's a terribly good seat this one... just perfectly placed..."

"This town won't be the same when you go," he said quietly. "I don't know how we will manage without you..."

"Well, I'm sure..." Mary was about to make up some fanciful reason when Colonel O'Connell grasped her hand and looked into her eyes.

"Please, would you consider staying as my wife?" He asked. Mary's eyes blinked as she wondered if this moment would ever arise. She had thought about it.

"Maurice, I'm immensely gratified by this offer, but my father is set on returning me to my mother and sisters... to my homeland... England."

"But this can be your home," he calmly pleaded.

"Yes, but I've been a widow for two years, and everything has been prepared for my return..." Mary argued in an unconvincing way. "What will my father say? You don't know him..."

"If you love me, you must marry me... I'll take care of your father," O'Connell assured her.

"All right then... give me a few days to think about it." With that they kissed and then walked back to the town together as the sun set over the harbour. They both knew that departure time was fast approaching. The next day Mary spoke to Elizabeth Macquarie. They were nearly the same age and had confided a lot already about being the First Lady of New South Wales.

"Maurice has made me an offer for marriage," Mary said. "I'm so drawn to him... he's honourable and insistent..."

"Well he's from a very old military family... Lachlan tells me they fought

the French kings for two hundred years. He's free from vices and moderate in his habits. He has most agreeable manners, as you know..." Elizabeth argued. "Do you really love him?"

"Oh dear... half my trunks have been taken on board the boat and my piano's been packed up yet again... how can I think? I do so want to see my mother..." Mary lamented. "But yes, I do love him. It's all so rushed. How can I be rational?"

Bligh had already set up office in the Hindostan, the boat that would return them to the homeland. There was a knock on his cabin door. Edmund Griffin opened the door and seeing Colonel O'Connell standing there with a certain expression he excused himself and went up on deck.

"Yes? What is it Colonel?" Bligh asked abruptly. "Come in man." O'Connell stepped inside the cabin and went straight to the point. "Your daughter's plans have changed, Sir. She has consented to marry me."

Bligh was calm for moment. Such a possibility had crossed his mind on the first night he watched O'Connell and Mary dine together on the Porpoise when they arrived from Hobart. But his heart had other things to say and he exploded into a rage.

"How dare you, Sir!" Bligh roared. "Your impertinence has gone far enough! My daughter Mary is a child, about to return to her mother... you are a middle aged man. Say no more! I will speak to my daughter myself." At that he stormed out of his cabin slamming the door and clambered from the deck into the rowboat. "Take me ashore," he commanded angrily.

The six sailors started rowing the six-oar cutter as Bligh stood at the

stern. "Faster! Harder! Get your backs into it!" Bligh suddenly yelled. "My God..." whispered one sailor to the other rowing next to him, "I'm glad I wasn't on his four thousand mile journey..."

Mary stood at the door of her cottage and could see her father in the boat as it was paddled at quick pace towards the wharf. The soldier assigned to protect Mary watched with trepidation.

"Well, here comes Papa now..." Mary said. "Even from here I can see he is furious..."

"Will it be parasols at ten paces, Ma'am?" The soldier replied.

"I don't think it will come to that, Sam, I know Papa too well," Mary answered giving him a stern glance. She then went inside the cottage and sat down. Indeed, Mary was well prepared for the confrontation.

Finally the exhausted sailors stopped rowing and the boat glided up to the side of the wharf and Bligh scrambled out and headed straight up the long path to the cottage. As he got closer the sentinel stood rigidly at attention looking straight ahead and gave a crisp salute as Bligh stormed by and opened the door. Bligh was sweating, hot and flustered. But he was taken aback by what he saw.

"This is a pleasant surprise, Papa," Mary said with a warm smile as she sat at her table stitching the seam of her best dress. She sat in exactly the same pose as her mother used to sit when she worked on her endless sowing. Papa immediately recognised the pose. Before Bligh could open his mouth, Mary continued speaking in a soft voice. "I'm sure Mama is so looking forward to seeing you... won't she be, Papa?"

"Well... of course..." Papa replied defensively. He wiped the sweat from his brow, then resolved to speak his mind. But once again, before he started to talk, Mary continued.

“You'll have Mama and the girls when you get home... and I will stay and have my husband, Maurice... here....” Mary said softly as she put down her stitching and looked into the eyes of her father. “It's like another mutiny isn't it, Papa?” she said smiling.

With this one sentence, Papa had the wind taken out of his sails. The confrontation had been becalmed. He lowered his shoulders in resignation and sighed.

The wedding took place at the church on May 8, 1810. Colonel O'Connell wore his full dress uniform with red jacket, silk cummerbund, medals and ceremonial sword. Bligh, glittering with even more medals and braid, gave Mary away with good grace.

Mary wore a beautiful cream dress and her maid, Hannah, helped her twine silk ribbons into her hair. The Reverend Samuel Marsden officiated, bulky in form and loud in voice.

Amongst the invited guests were Tommy, Matt and Dessy, their adopted family, and other families from the Hawkesbury. On Mary's suggestion, Tommy had chosen a few of the brightest young girls from the orphanage as bridesmaids led by Eleanor.

Governor Macquarie could not have been more happy. In fact, as a wedding present he granted his Lieutenant Governor a thousand acres at Eastern Creek, adjoining Mary's farm, Frogmore. Colonel O'Connell was no longer a penniless career soldier. He named his new farm 'Riverston' after his birthplace in Ireland.

“I now pronounce you Man and Wife!” Marsden declared triumphantly. Then followed embraces and laughter and celebration. Bligh accepted congratulations with gruff courtesy and showed no inkling of any disappointment. The reception was held at Government House and the

drawing room had flowers everywhere picked from the garden outside. It was a wonderful occasion.

Two days later Bligh, Maurice and Mary assembled on the wharf. There was no ceremony. They shook hands and embraced for the final time. "Have a safe journey, Papa," Mary whispered into her father's ear as they hugged.

"Yes, of course I will," Papa replied quietly. "And thank you for all your help... you have been an angel..." He then stepped into the small barge to be rowed out to the awaiting *Hindustan*. Mary and Maurice began walking towards the point as they watched the progress of the boat.

Finally it reached the *Hindustan* and Bligh clambered on board carrying many of his supporters, and the soldiers of the New South Wales Corps, and with its sails set it weighed anchor and made its way towards the Heads along with the convoy of the *Dromedary* and the *Porpoise*.

Mary and Maurice sat on Lady Macquarie's Chair and could clearly see Bligh standing at the stern of his ship. They waved to each other. Then Bligh looked once more at Government House and turned his back on it and took command of his boat as it headed off to London via Rio de Janeiro.

Father and daughter never met again.

Postscript

1810 was the year of the first spring racing carnival held at the newly-named Hyde Park attracting huge crowds. Balls and celebrations continued for a week. A grey gelding won named Chase, owned by Captain Ritchie.

In November the Macquaries toured the outlying settlements and Lieutenant Governor O'Connell became acting Governor for the duration of that tour.

In early 1811 long-awaited letters arrived of congratulations from Mary's mother and sisters. Papa wrote that the pressures of the past few years had damaged Mama's health.

In the first week of 1812, Mary gave birth to a healthy son, named Maurice Charles O'Connell; a red head with a congenial disposition. (He grew up and had a distinguished career in the Queensland Government, was knighted, and died in 1879.)

By Easter of 1812 news arrived of Johnston's court martial. He was found guilty and thrown out of the army. His co-conspirators escaped prosecution entirely. To the judges in London, there was an unreality about the fractious faraway colony and the affray of January 26, 1808 at the farthest outposts of English power. Although it was mercifully bloodless, and at some levels, verged on farce, it became known as the Rum Rebellion. Bligh was outraged by the courts ruling.

Macarthur got off scott free and returned to Sydney but was told to stay out of politics. He later went mad and died.

However, the authorities respected William Bligh and he was promoted to Rear Admiral of the White. The returning families of the Corps suffered terribly during their first northern winter. As many as sixty children born in the Colony died when an outbreak of measles combined with the bitter cold.

Two weeks before Christmas, 1812, Mary received news that her mother, Betsy had died. In 1813, Colonel O'Connell signed a lease for the Vacluse Estate that included a five hundred acre farm. The harbour was within walking distance and the moorings were good.

Orders came through from England of a posting to Ceylon for Colonel O'Connell. At the end of February, 1814, all the belongings from Vacluse went on board the General Hewitt and they set sail.

In England Bligh never went to sea again but retired to Kent with some of Mary's sisters. However, suffering from an internal complaint, Bligh collapsed and died while visiting London in December, 1817. He shares a tomb with his wife, Betsy.

In Ceylon, the second boy, Robert Brownrigg O'Connell was born but died fourteen months later from tropical fever and he was buried on a hillside near the Indian Ocean.

Mary had many more children. There was William Bligh, Anne Elizabeth, and Charles Phillip. Sadly Mary Nino Godfrey died young in Athlone, Ireland, on February 19, 1825 at two years old. The family made regular visits to Ireland and England to visit their many cousins.

In the mid 1830's, O'Connell was posted back to New South Wales with the 73rd Regiment. They bought a comfortable house on the Woolloomooloo hill, named Tarmons; a stone house with a sloping garden overlooking the harbour. O'Connell commanded his regiment

well into his seventies.

On July 12, 1846, Maurice O'Connell became Acting Governor of New South Wales between the time Governor Gipps left and Fitzroy arrived. But he and Mary didn't take up residence at Government House.

Soon after he retired they booked a passage back to England. On the morning Mary and Maurice were due to sail he collapsed at Tarmons from a heart attack and died. He was eighty years old. For the second time Mary was widowed in Sydney Town. O'Connell was given a full military funeral at the new church, St. James's. He had had a successful career; decorated, promoted and knighted.

In the late 1850's Mary moved to Paris to live and moved into a garden flat with a high ceiling in the Chaillot Quarter. It had a gilt mirrored hallway and marble bathroom. Her children were spread out around the world. She read with great interest about the Victorian Gold Rush that transformed Australia.

Finally Mary returned to England for good and died at the residence of her son-in-law, Colonel Somerset, at the Beaufort Buildings in Gloucester, on December 10, 1864. Mary was 81 years old.

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Daughter to Bligh

The amazing story of Mary, the daughter of the famous and controversial Governor Bligh.

This book is suitable for all ages and is essential reading for any person interested in the fledgling colonial outpost of Sydney.

JOYCE THORPE NICHOLSON (1919 – 2011)

Author of over 25 books (including ‘Mutiny on the Bounty’), a business woman, publisher, owner and Managing Director of D. W. Thorpe Pty Ltd from 1968 to 1987] and a founding member of the Women’s Electoral Lobby and Sister’s Publishing.



FRONT COVER :

Portrait of Mary Bligh

Courtesy Mitchell Library, Sydney